

Hippopotamus as White

A complete practical curriculum from the ground up

White uses a restrained double fianchetto, often g3, Bg2, b3, Bb2, d3, e3, Nd2 and Ne2. The extra first move does not make passive play automatically strong. This course starts with 1.g3 and teaches earlier central action whenever the full formation would concede too much.



The reference position - White to move

YOUR PERSPECTIVE

White is at the bottom of every diagram. Coordinates remain explicit and all pieces stay upright.

WHAT YOU WILL LEARN

24 opening branches, six middlegame laboratories, 48 exercises with explained answers, and a 12-week practice plan. Each subject also appears in one combined volume.

START HERE

Read this booklet first. Then learn one line from each family in Booklet 01. Use 02 for plans, 03 for practice positions, 04 for retrieval and 05 for study schedules and reference.

How to use this course

YOUR FIRST PASS

Use a real or digital board. Read the foundations, then learn only the first line of each opening family. Play slow practice games before trying to remember every variation. A useful opening lesson ends with a decision you can explain, not a string of moves you can recite.

YOUR SECOND PASS

Return to the branch your opponent actually played. Replay it from move one and stop before each move by your side. Name the threat, two plausible replies and the reason for your choice. Check the printed continuation only after committing to an answer.

YOUR THIRD PASS

Use the middlegame laboratories and exercise book. These are original illustrative positions and engine-assisted continuations, not attributed master games. Switch colors in training so you experience the opponent's space, defensive resources and attacking chances.

WHAT COMPLETE MEANS HERE

This is a broad practical curriculum from basic rules to common opening decisions, middlegames and typical transitions. Chess has too many legal branches for a finite course to exhaust. The course teaches a decision process for unfamiliar replies and marks alternatives, warnings and entry-route boundaries explicitly.

The board and the object of the game

COORDINATES

Files are a through h from White's left to right. Ranks are 1 through 8 from White's side toward Black. A square such as e4 has one file letter and one rank number. White has a light square at the near right corner, h1. Black-oriented diagrams reverse the coordinate display, not the movement rules.

URNS AND CHECK

White moves first; the players alternate one move each. A move may not leave your own king attacked. Check means that the king is attacked; answer by moving the king, capturing the attacker or blocking a line attack when possible. A knight check cannot be blocked.

CHECKMATE AND STALEMATE

Checkmate means the player to move is in check and has no legal reply. Stalemate means the player has no legal move but is not in check; it is a draw. Before announcing mate, examine every king move, capture and possible block. Kings are never actually captured.

MATERIAL IS A GUIDE

For beginner decisions, a pawn is roughly 1, a knight or bishop 3, a rook 5 and a queen 9. These are rough comparisons, not a scoring rule. A king has no exchange value. Activity, safety, passed pawns and immediate tactics can outweigh a small material difference.

How the pieces move

ROOK AND BISHOP

A rook moves along a rank or file. A bishop moves diagonally and stays on its starting square color. Neither can jump over any piece. A sliding piece controls only as far as the first occupied square on each ray; do not count an attack through your own pawn.

QUEEN AND KNIGHT

A queen combines rook and bishop movement. A knight moves two squares in one direction and one at right angles, changing square color. The knight may jump over pieces. A knight on f3 can move to d2, d4, e1, e5, g1, g5, h2 or h4 if the destination and king-safety rules allow.

KING

A king moves one square in any direction and cannot enter an attacked square. The kings cannot stand next to each other. A pinned enemy piece can still restrict the king's legal squares; the rules about attacked squares are more subtle than whether that enemy piece could legally move away from its own king.

PAWN

White pawns move toward higher rank numbers; Black pawns toward lower. A pawn moves one square straight ahead into an empty square, or two from its starting rank if both squares are empty. It captures one square diagonally forward. It cannot move backward or capture straight ahead.

Castling, promotion and en passant

CASTLING

Castling moves the king two squares toward a rook and places that rook on the square the king crossed. The king and that rook must never have moved, the intervening squares must be empty, and the king must not be in check or cross or land on an attacked square. A rook being attacked does not by itself prevent castling.

RIGHTS DO NOT RETURN

If a king or rook moves out and back, the relevant castling right is still lost. A king moved to f1 in the King's Gambit must coordinate its rooks another way. In queenless positions the loss of castling may be less serious, but the legal right remains lost.

PROMOTION

A pawn reaching the last rank must promote to a queen, rook, bishop or knight of its color. It need not choose a previously captured piece. A second queen is legal. Underpromotion can avoid stalemate or create a knight fork, so inspect the exact position before always choosing a queen.

EN PASSANT

Immediately after an opposing pawn advances two squares from its starting rank and lands beside your pawn on your fifth rank, you may capture it as though it had advanced one square. The opportunity lasts only for your next move. The capture is illegal if removing those pawns exposes your own king to check.

Reading moves and navigating branches

ALGEBRAIC NOTATION

K means king, Q queen, R rook, B bishop and N knight. Pawns have no piece letter: e4 is a pawn move. Bc4 means a bishop moves to c4. Nxe5 captures on e5. exd5 is an e-file pawn capturing on d5. A plus sign is check; # is checkmate; O-O is kingside castling and O-O-O queenside castling.

WHICH PIECE MOVED

If two identical pieces can legally reach the same square, notation distinguishes them: Nbd2 means the knight from the b-file; R1e2 means the rook from rank 1. The board, not the notation alone, determines which capture or check is legal. Promotion is written e8=Q, with + or # when appropriate.

MOVE NUMBERS

1.e4 e5 is White's first move and Black's first reply. A line beginning 7...Nf6 starts with Black's seventh move. All main opening lines in this course begin at the initial position; laboratory continuations display their starting diagram and exact move number.

ONE LINE IS NOT FORCED

An example to move ten is one route through the position. It is not a claim that every reply is compulsory. The authored anchor and its illustrative continuation are distinguished. Each line has an ID that also appears in the PGN files and exercises.

Your thinking routine on every move

1. INSPECT THE LAST MOVE

Ask what the opponent's move changed. Did it attack a piece, unmask a bishop, release a rook file, threaten mate or leave something undefended? A remembered opening move is only a candidate until it survives this inspection.

2. EXAMINE FORCING MOVES

Check all checks, serious captures and direct threats for both sides. Calculate the opponent's best reply, not the reply you hope for. Stop the line at a position you can assess: material, king safety and the resulting pawn structure.

3. GENERATE CANDIDATES

Usually compare two or three useful moves: one forcing move, one developing or improving move, and one central response if relevant. In a cramped position ask which exchange or pawn break creates room. In an attacking position ask whether the center can open against your king.

4. BLUNDER CHECK

Before moving, visualize the new position. Is your queen or another piece loose? Have you removed a defender or opened a diagonal to your king? Can the opponent answer with a check, fork or intermediate capture? A ten-second check often saves more points than memorizing another opening branch.

Center, development and time

OCCUPY AND INFLUENCE

Pawns on d4 and e4 occupy central space; bishops and knights can influence those squares from a distance. A restrained setup needs a plan to challenge the opponent's center. Space becomes useful when it gives your pieces safe squares and restricts the opponent.

DEVELOPMENT

Bring knights and bishops into useful play, protect the king and connect the rooks. Avoid moving the same piece repeatedly without a concrete gain. An exception must be explained: a queen retreat in the Scandinavian or a knight escape in the King's Gambit can be compulsory.

A TEMPO

A tempo is one move of useful time. Attacking a queen while developing often gains time, but a check that helps the opponent develop can fail to do so. Count actual useful moves and threats instead of assuming every attack is a gain.

OPENING THE CENTER

If your king is safer and your pieces are ready, opening files can exploit a development lead. If your king is exposed, central exchanges may be dangerous. A closed center often allows maneuvering or a wing attack, but first verify that the opponent cannot open it with a pawn break.

Pawn structures and planning vocabulary

BREAK AND TENSION

A pawn break challenges an enemy pawn structure: c4 against d5 or ...c5 against d4. Tension exists when pawns can capture each other but neither side has committed. Before exchanging, ask which pieces become active, which file opens and which pawn becomes weak.

CHAIN AND BASE

A pawn chain is a diagonal line of mutually supporting pawns. In a white d4-e5 chain, d4 is the base and e5 the head. An attack on either end may work, but the calculation differs: ...c5 usually challenges d4, while ...f6 challenges e5.

WEAK SQUARES AND OUTPOSTS

A square is a useful outpost when a piece can occupy it securely and create meaningful pressure, often because enemy pawns cannot chase it. An outpost with no targets may be less valuable than a flexible central piece. Check whether exchanges eliminate its support.

FILES, DIAGONALS AND LEVERS

A file without pawns is open; one with no pawn of your color is half-open for you. A fianchetto bishop can be excellent on an open diagonal and restricted behind blocked pawns. A lever changes that reality. Name the pawn move that makes your plan possible.

Playing, recording and analyzing a game

CHOOSE A USEFUL TIME CONTROL

For course practice use at least 15 minutes with an increment, or a longer control if available. Blitz is useful for pattern recognition after the basic decisions are learned. It is a poor substitute for calculating an unfamiliar sharp opening carefully.

ANALYZE YOURSELF FIRST

After the game, mark the first unfamiliar position and write your candidates without an engine. Identify the first important mistake, not only the final blunder. Separate opening memory, tactical calculation, strategic judgment and time-management errors.

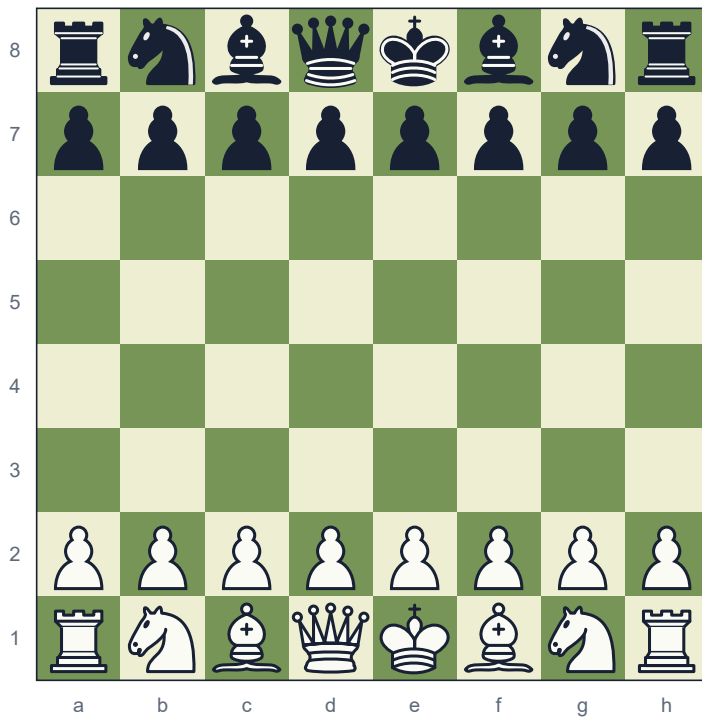
THEN USE THE TOOLS

Compare the game with the matching line ID. Use an engine to test forcing variations and examine a stronger defensive reply. An engine number is evidence from a finite search, not a verbal explanation. Write one sentence that tells you what to do differently next time.

BUILD A SMALL ERROR NOTEBOOK

Keep the position, your move, a better candidate, the opponent's key reply and one lesson. Revisit it after one day, three days, a week and a month. Add the position to your repertoire only when you can explain it without the answer visible.

Read the diagram before the moves



White to move

A RELIABLE FIRST SCAN

Find both kings, name the side to move and locate all pawns in the center. Then inspect checks, captures and direct threats.

ORIENTATION

Your course side is at the bottom. On a Black-oriented board, files read h to a along the bottom; pawns still move according to their color and rank numbers.

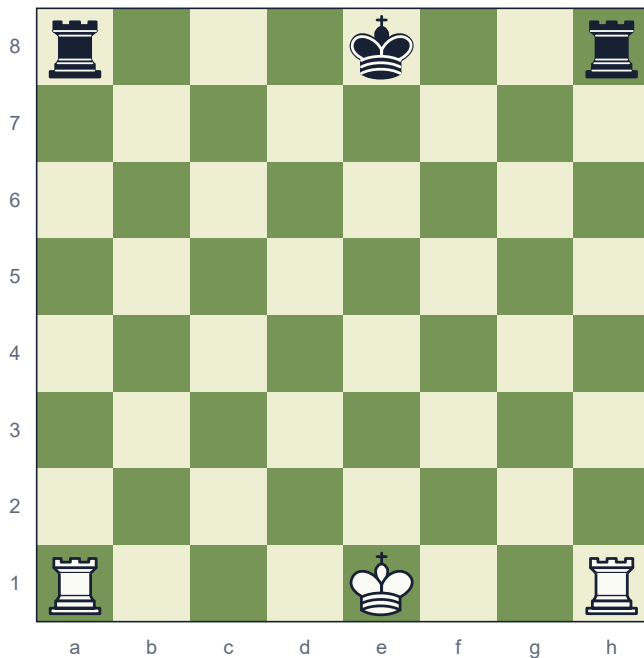
PRACTICE WITHOUT MOVING

Find e4, d5, f7 and b2. Name the piece that begins on each of b1, c1, f8 and g8. From the initial position, count White's legal pawn moves and knight moves: 16 pawn moves and 4 knight moves.

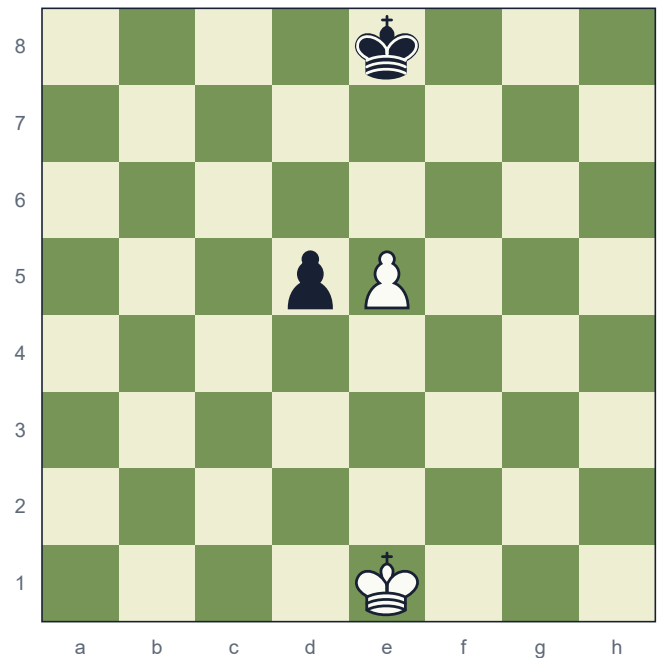
ANSWER THE REAL POSITION

A board caption always states whose move it is and whether the king is in check. You may not ignore check to finish development. In the initial position, bishops and rooks are blocked by friendly pieces.

Castling and en passant on a board



White to move - castling geometry



White to move - en passant available

LEFT: CASTLING GEOMETRY

With the rights recorded in this teaching position, White may castle O-O or O-O-O. The king crosses f1 or d1 and lands on g1 or c1; the rook lands on f1 or d1. Empty squares alone are not enough in a real game: check previous king/rook moves and attacked king squares.

RIGHT: IMMEDIATE EN PASSANT

Black has just played ...d7-d5. White can play exd6 en passant: the white pawn lands on d6 and the black pawn is removed from d5. If White plays another move, the special capture is no longer available.

TRAINING QUESTION

Why can a knight jump over a piece but a bishop cannot? Why can a rook be attacked during legal castling while the king cannot cross an attacked square? Explain the movement rule before using it in an opening.

Your first moves, explained

1. G3

Prepares a fianchetto and changes the long diagonal. Check the bishop and corner rook before assuming the next developing move is safe.

2. BG2

Completes the kingside fianchetto. Trace the diagonal to its first blocker; the bishop cannot attack through friendly pawns or pieces.

3. D3

Supports a restrained central formation and opens one bishop diagonal while possibly blocking another. Plan the later pawn break.

4. E3

Supports a restrained central formation and opens one bishop diagonal while possibly blocking another. Plan the later pawn break.

5. B3

Prepares a fianchetto and changes the long diagonal. Check the bishop and corner rook before assuming the next developing move is safe.

BEFORE YOU MEMORIZE

The reference route is one example. Reconstruct it, then change one opposing move and explain why the next automatic setup move might need to change.

Your first moves, explained / continued

6. BB2

Completes the queenside fianchetto and points toward the central e5 region. Check the opposing long diagonal and the rook behind the bishop.

7. ND2

Develops a knight to support e4 and leave the c-pawn flexible. Check that it does not unnecessarily obstruct the queen bishop.

8. NE2

Develops the king knight without fixing the f-pawn. Compare its onward route with the immediate central influence of Nf3.

9. A3

Controls nearby wing squares and may restrain a piece or pawn. Compare this useful purpose with the time lost to central development.

10. H3

Controls nearby wing squares and may restrain a piece or pawn. Compare this useful purpose with the time lost to central development.

BEFORE YOU MEMORIZE

The reference route is one example. Reconstruct it, then change one opposing move and explain why the next automatic setup move might need to change.

Repertoire map / 1

BUILDING A REVERSED HIPPO

Start with HW-01. Then add the remaining branches one at a time. The IDs connect this map, the theory booklet and the PGN files.

HW-01 The complete formation as a study position

Completing a formation is not the same as gaining an advantage.

HW-02 Black develops Be7

Use flexibility to choose a break, not to postpone every decision.

HW-03 Black fianchettoes

Open the diagonal that helps your pieces most.

HW-04 Black uses ...e6 and ...d5

A restrained opponent still needs to be challenged.

HW-05 Black chooses a ...d6 ...e5 center

Watch the break the supporting pawn can eventually make.

HW-06 Black also plays a Hippo

Block the long diagonal before exposing the corner rook.

Repertoire map / 2

RESPONDING TO CENTRAL SPACE

Start with HW-07. Then add the remaining branches one at a time. The IDs connect this map, the theory booklet and the PGN files.

HW-07 Black grabs space with ...c5

A three-pawn center calls for a timely lever.

HW-08 Black adds ...f5

Development comes before decorative symmetry.

HW-09 Black advances ...d4 early

Deal with the wedge before finishing the formation.

HW-10 Black advances ...e4 early

Exchanging a pawn can replace it with a stronger piece.

HW-11 Black plays ...d4 before e3

Use the knight square the position needs.

HW-12 Black plays an early ...c6

A blocked diagonal is potential, not present pressure.

Repertoire map / 3

FLANK ATTACKS AND EARLY TACTICS

Start with HW-13. Then add the remaining branches one at a time. The IDs connect this map, the theory booklet and the PGN files.

HW-13 An immediate ...h5

A premature flank attack may be met by a developing move.

HW-14 The supported h-pawn attack

A defensive pawn move creates a future target too.

HW-15 The ...g5 expansion

Test a wing expansion before it becomes supported.

HW-16 An early ...Bh3 attempt

A queen recapture depends on the knight's exact square.

HW-17 Queenside expansion with ...a5

Defend pieces behind the pawn contact.

HW-18 Black develops ...Bb4+

Respond to the check with the best developing move.

Repertoire map / 4

USEFUL DEPARTURES FROM THE COMPLETE FORMATION

Start with HW-19. Then add the remaining branches one at a time. The IDs connect this map, the theory booklet and the PGN files.

HW-19 Choose c4 before the complete shell

The best Hippo lesson may be when to leave it.

HW-20 Choose e4 for a KIA transition

Transition by pawn structure, not by a preferred name.

HW-21 Choose d4 against a restrained center

Take central space when your pieces can support it.

HW-22 Trade queens when the file opens

Evaluate the position after the queens disappear.

HW-23 Use Nf3 against a Dutch center

Choose active development when the opponent has a clear attack.

HW-24 Against early ...b6: occupy the center

Use central space and inspect undefended fianchetto bishops.

Building a reversed Hippo

HOW TO STUDY THIS FAMILY

First reconstruct the main branch from the initial position. Explain the central structure, each side's king safety and the most urgent threat. Then compare the alternatives one at a time.

MAIN BRANCH

HW-01 - White reaches the familiar two-rank formation while Black occupies the center. This quiet illustrative route is not a claim that all ten setup moves are best in every position.

A PRACTICAL PLAN

Resolve king safety and choose c4, d4 or e4 as a central challenge. Identify which bishop will become active after the chosen break.

THE OPPONENT GETS A VOTE

Black has more space and can prepare ...e4 or ...d4. White's extra tempo has not prevented a central bind.

RECOGNITION TEST

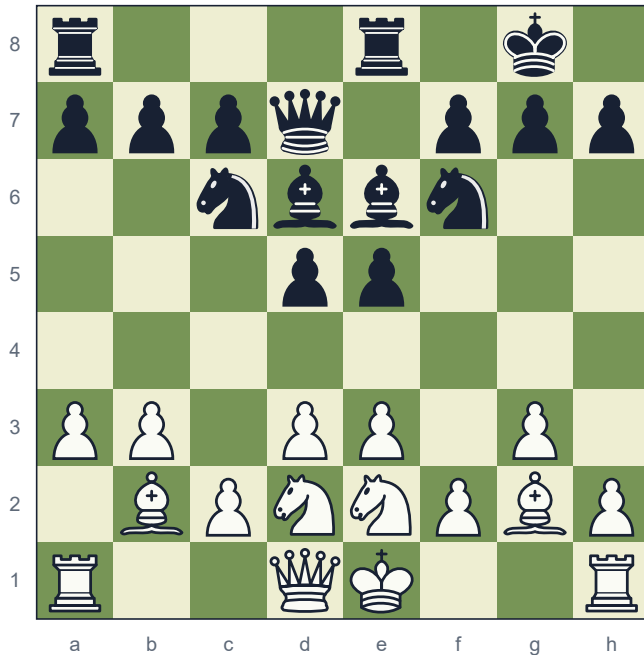
For each alternative, name the move that changes the plan. If you cannot identify that decision, return to the board rather than memorizing the last three moves.

HW-01 / The complete formation as a study position

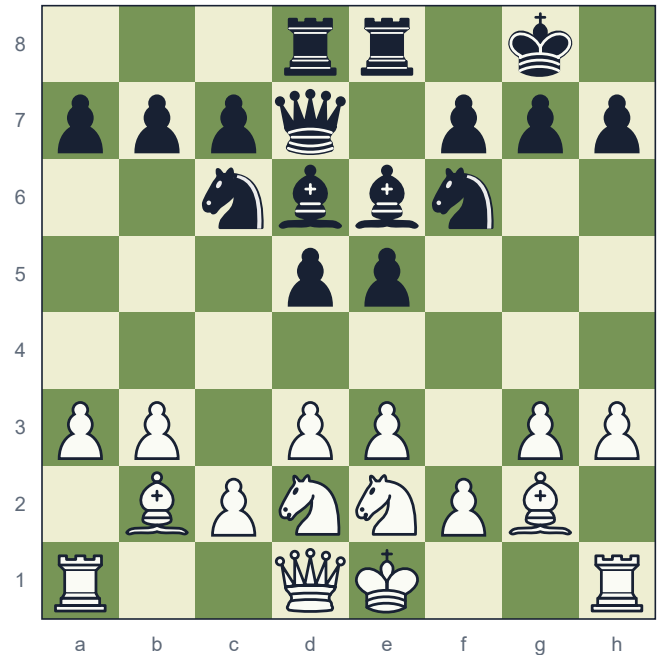
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. g3 d5 2. Bg2 e5 3. d3 Nc6 4. e3 Nf6 5. b3 Bd6 6. Bb2 O-O 7. Nd2 Re8 8. Ne2 Be6 9. a3 Qd7 10. h3 Rad8

The anchor is the complete printed sequence.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

White reaches the familiar two-rank formation while Black occupies the center. This quiet illustrative route is not a claim that all ten setup moves are best in every position.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Resolve king safety and choose c4, d4 or e4 as a central challenge. Identify which bishop will become active after the chosen break.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black has more space and can prepare ...e4 or ...d4. White's extra tempo has not prevented a central bind.

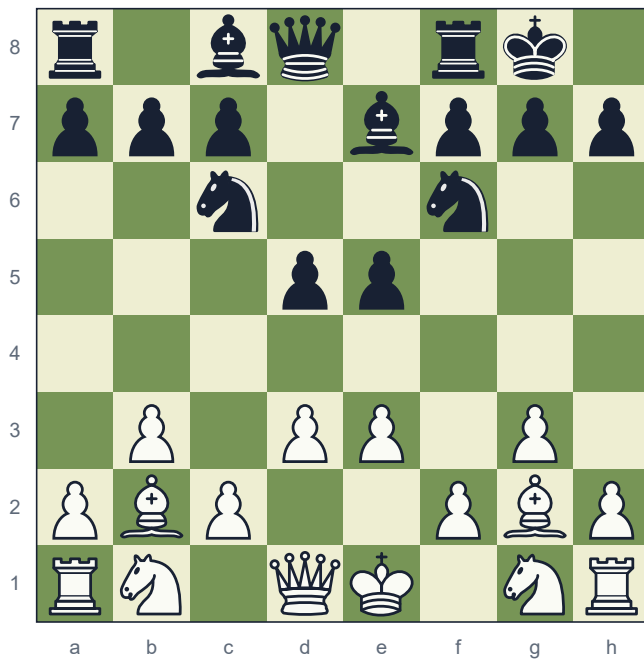
REMEMBER Completing a formation is not the same as gaining an advantage.

HW-02 / Black develops Be7

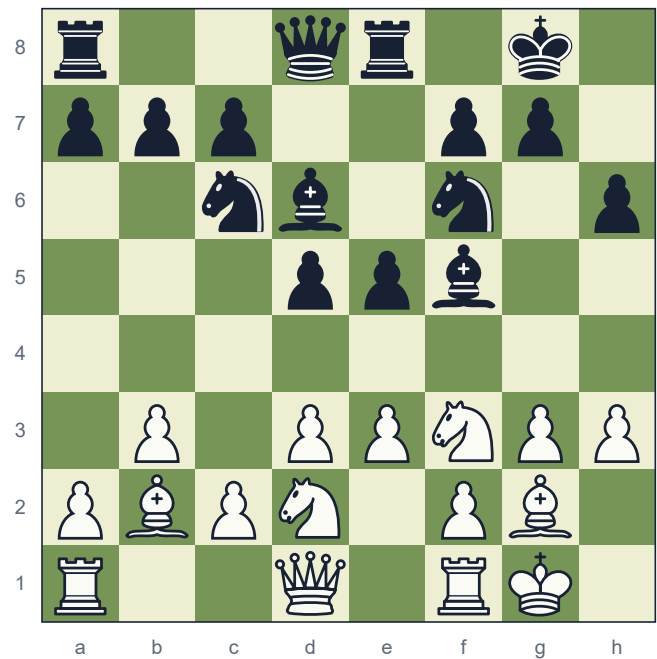
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. g3 d5 2. Bg2 e5 3. d3 Nf6 4. e3 Be7 5. b3 O-O 6. Bb2 Nc6 7. Nd2 Re8 8. h3 Bd6 9. Ngf3 h6 10. O-O Bf5

Authored anchor ends after 7. Nd2. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Black develops modestly and keeps the center intact. White preserves flexibility while the bishops watch long diagonals.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Choose Ne2 or Ngf3 according to the desired break, then castle when safe. c4 can question d5 without first building a large center.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black may use ...Re8 and ...Bf8 to prepare central expansion. Quiet development can support a serious squeeze.

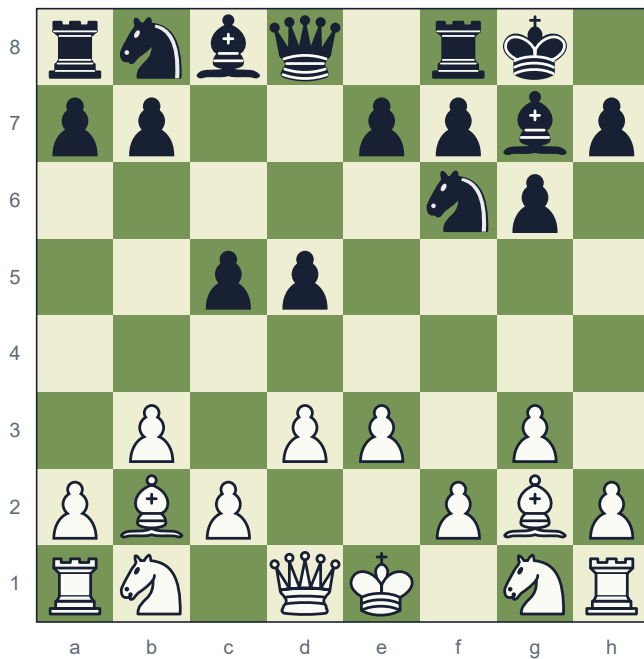
REMEMBER Use flexibility to choose a break, not to postpone every decision.

HW-03 / Black fianchettoes

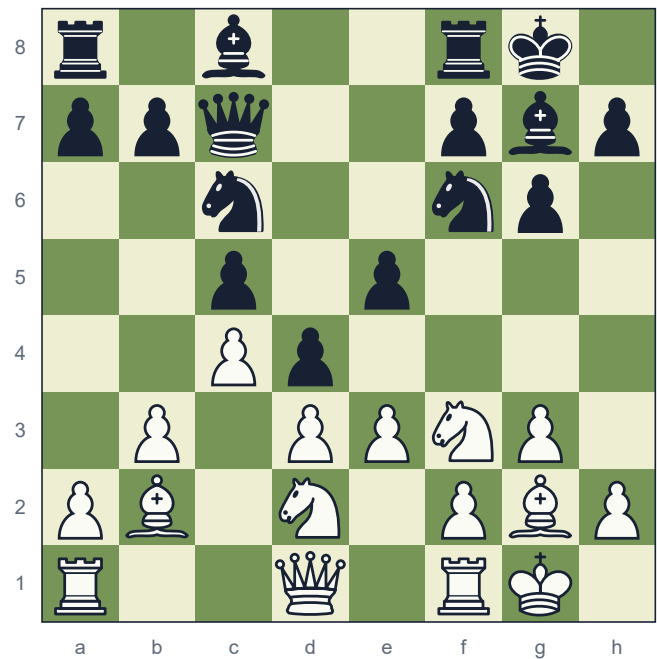
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. g3 d5 2. Bg2 Nf6 3. d3 g6 4. e3 Bg7 5. b3 O-O 6. Bb2 c5 7. Nd2 Qc7 8. Ngf3 Nc6 9. O-O e5 10. c4 d4

Authored anchor ends after 7. Nd2. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Black combines central space with a fianchetto. White's b2 bishop points toward the opposing king side, but central pawns may block its influence.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Complete development and decide whether c4 or e4 best opens your bishops. Count the pressure on b2 after the center clears.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black can advance ...d4 and restrict the b1 knight. The g7 bishop may become stronger than its white counterpart after exchanges.

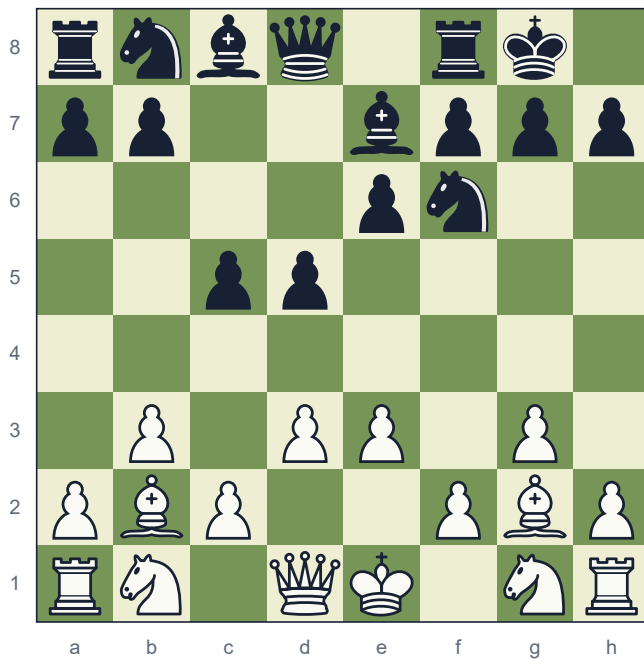
REMEMBER Open the diagonal that helps your pieces most.

HW-04 / Black uses ...e6 and ...d5

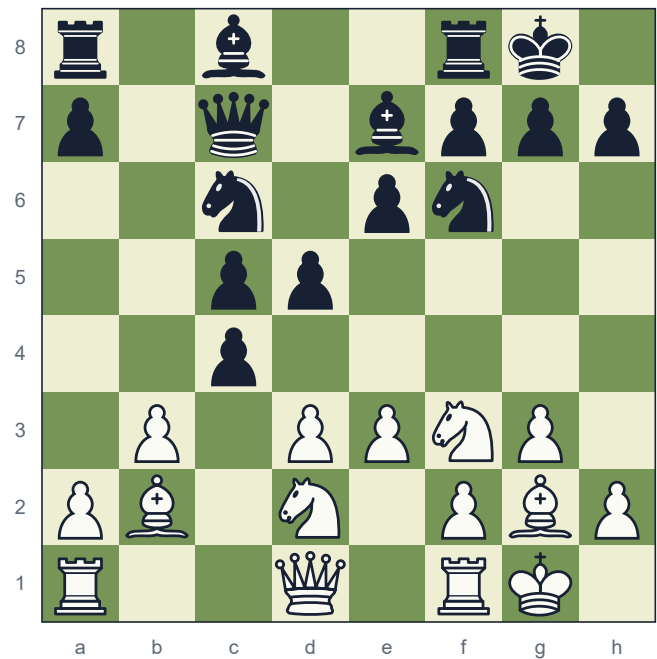
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. g3 d5 2. Bg2 e6 3. d3 Nf6 4. e3 Be7 5. b3 O-O 6. Bb2 c5 7. Nd2 Nc6 8. Ngf3 b5 9. O-O Qc7 10. c4 bxc4

Authored anchor ends after 7. Nd2. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Black has a stable d5-e6 center but has not occupied e5. White has time to prepare a direct central challenge.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Consider Ngf3 and e4, or Ne2 and c4. Choose one coherent route rather than moving both knights repeatedly without a central goal.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

...Nc6 and ...e5 can gain more space. Do not wait for Black to complete every central ambition before responding.

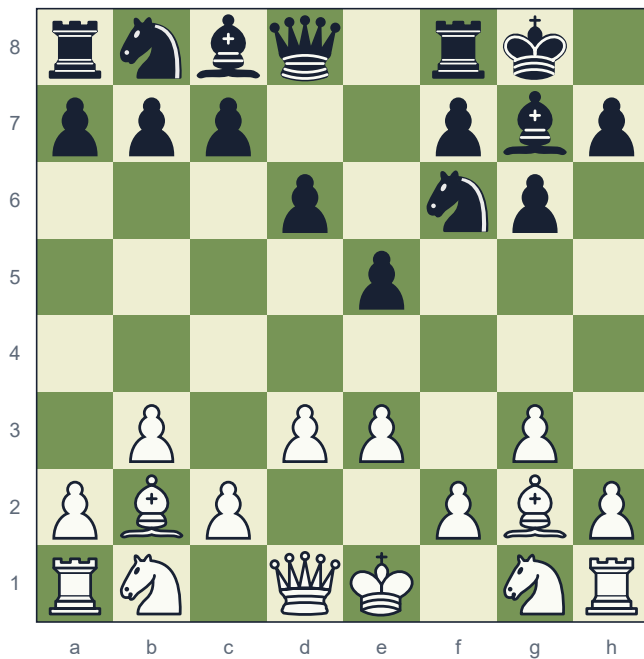
REMEMBER A restrained opponent still needs to be challenged.

HW-05 / Black chooses a ...d6 ...e5 center

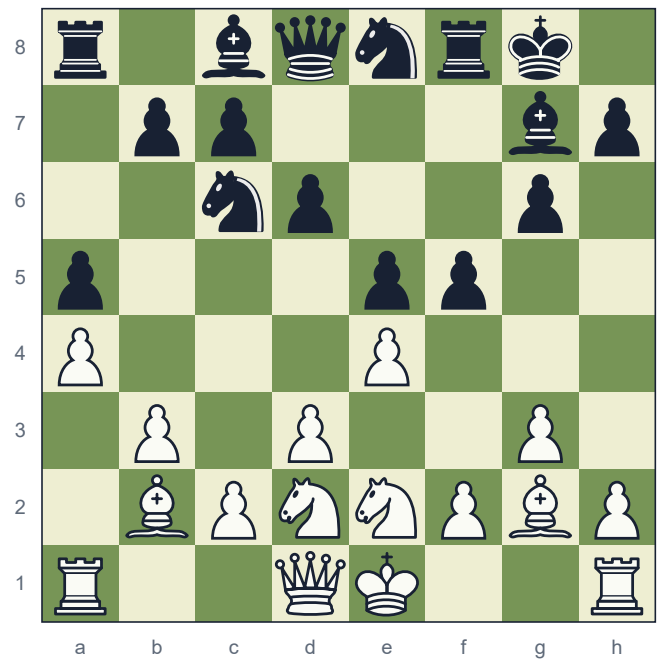
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. g3 e5 2. Bg2 d6 3. d3 Nf6 4. e3 g6 5. b3 Bg7 6. Bb2 O-O 7. Nd2 a5 8. a4 Nc6 9. e4 Ne8 10. Ne2 f5

Authored anchor ends after 7. Nd2. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Black's d6 pawn supports e5 and keeps the center flexible. White can choose a partial Hippo or a more active King's Indian Attack structure.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Compare e4 with c4 and develop the king knight to support that choice. Decide whether the b2 bishop has useful pressure before exchanging e-pawns.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black can use ...Nc6 and ...Be6 to develop with central influence. A later ...d5 may seize the initiative if White waits too long.

REMEMBER Watch the break the supporting pawn can eventually make.

HW-06 / Black also plays a Hippo

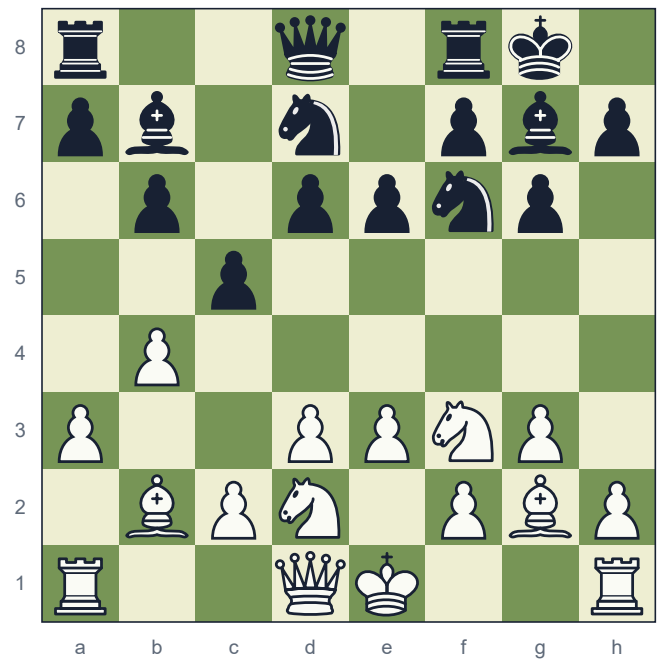
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. g3 g6 2. Bg2 Bg7 3. d3 d6 4. Nf3 Nf6 5. e3 e6 6. b3 b6 7. Bb2 Bb7 8. Nbd2 Nbd7 9. b4 c5 10. a3 O-O

Authored anchor ends after 8... Nbd7. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Both sides restrain the center, but the knights on f3 and f6 block the opposing fianchetto diagonals before b-pawn moves expose the corner rooks. This detail prevents a tactical accident.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Use the first move to develop and choose a central claim such as e4 or c4. Castling may be more valuable than automatically adding a3 and h3.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Without a blocker on the long diagonal, b3 or ...b6 can expose a corner rook to the enemy bishop. Never build this formation without tracing the diagonal.

REMEMBER Block the long diagonal before exposing the corner rook.

Work through HW-01

7. ND2

Develops a knight to support e4 and leave the c-pawn flexible. Check that it does not unnecessarily obstruct the queen bishop.

8. NE2

Develops the king knight without fixing the f-pawn. Compare its onward route with the immediate central influence of Nf3.

9. A3

Controls nearby wing squares and may restrain a piece or pawn. Compare this useful purpose with the time lost to central development.

10. H3

Controls nearby wing squares and may restrain a piece or pawn. Compare this useful purpose with the time lost to central development.

EXPLAIN THE POSITION

White reaches the familiar two-rank formation while Black occupies the center. This quiet illustrative route is not a claim that all ten setup moves are best in every position. Resolve king safety and choose c4, d4 or e4 as a central challenge. Identify which bishop will become active after the chosen break.

PRACTICE TASK

Replay this branch without looking. Stop at the first move you cannot explain. Then play the endpoint for ten moves against a partner or engine, switching sides for a second game. Judge your decisions, not just the result.

Responding to central space

HOW TO STUDY THIS FAMILY

First reconstruct the main branch from the initial position. Explain the central structure, each side's king safety and the most urgent threat. Then compare the alternatives one at a time.

MAIN BRANCH

HW-07 - Black establishes c5-d5-e5. White must challenge the center before completing every wing pawn move.

A PRACTICAL PLAN

Develop a knight to support c4 or e4, and calculate the resulting exchanges. Consider whether a partial formation gives more active play than the complete shell.

THE OPPONENT GETS A VOTE

...d4 can close the center with a large space advantage. If every white piece lacks squares, the setup has become too slow.

RECOGNITION TEST

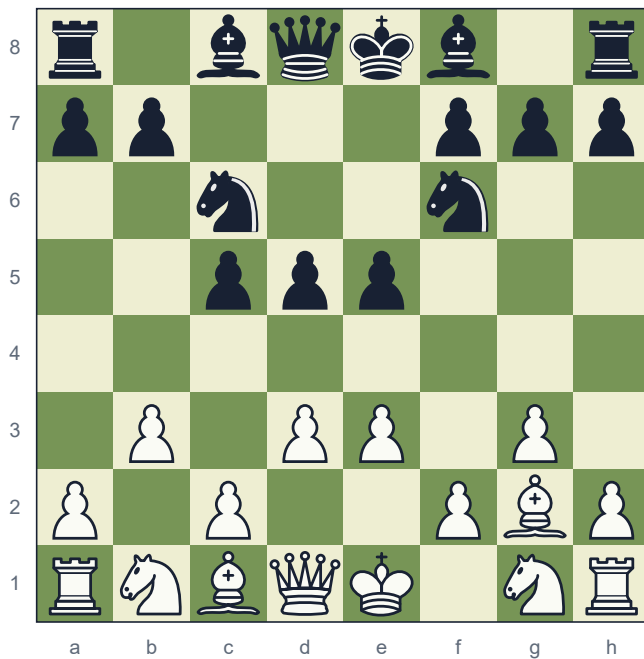
For each alternative, name the move that changes the plan. If you cannot identify that decision, return to the board rather than memorizing the last three moves.

HW-07 / Black grabs space with ...c5

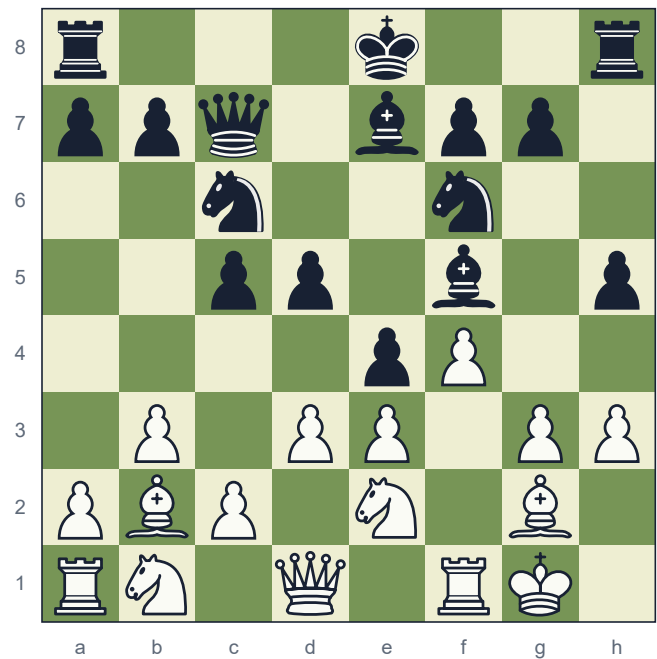
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. g3 d5 2. Bg2 e5 3. d3 c5 4. e3 Nc6 5. b3 Nf6 6. Bb2 Be7 7. Ne2 h5 8. h3 Qc7 9. O-O Bf5 10. f4 e4

Authored anchor ends after 6... Be7. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Black establishes c5-d5-e5. White must challenge the center before completing every wing pawn move.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop a knight to support c4 or e4, and calculate the resulting exchanges. Consider whether a partial formation gives more active play than the complete shell.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

...d4 can close the center with a large space advantage. If every white piece lacks squares, the setup has become too slow.

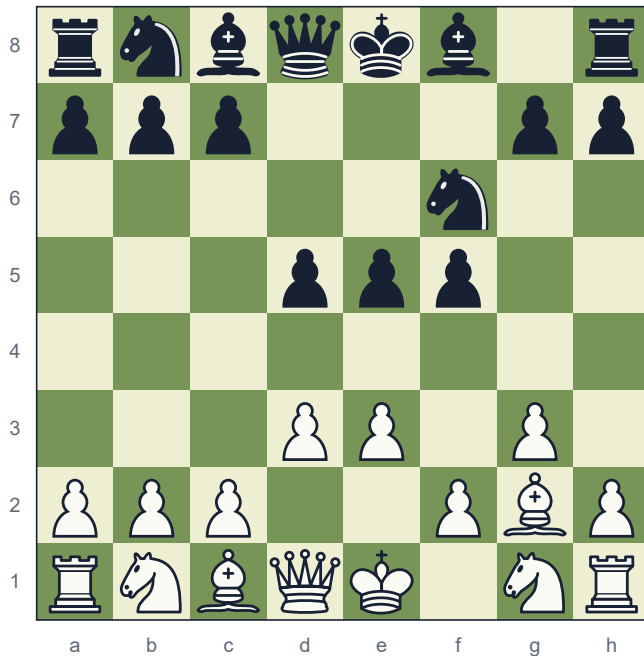
REMEMBER A three-pawn center calls for a timely lever.

HW-08 / Black adds ...f5

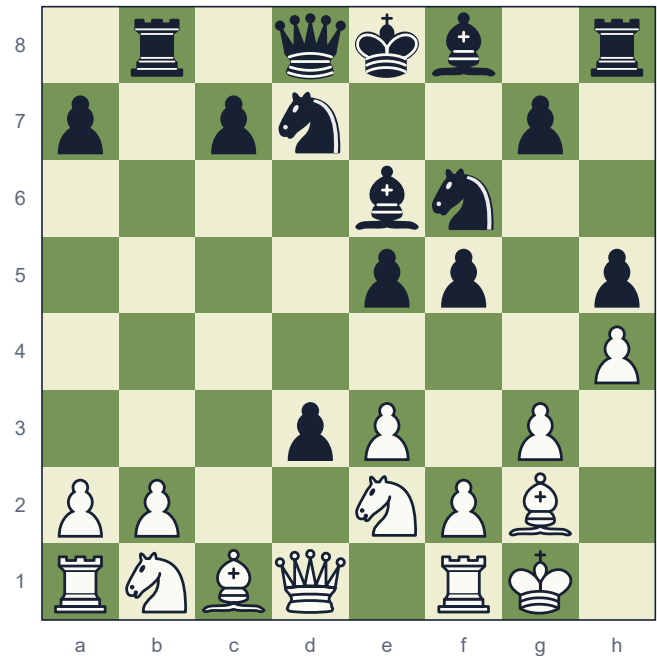
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. g3 e5 2. Bg2 d5 3. d3 f5 4. e3 Nf6 5. Ne2 Be6 6. O-O h5 7. c4 dxc4 8. Bxb7 Nbd7 9. h4 Rb8 10. Bg2 cxd3

Authored anchor ends after 5. Ne2. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

White develops the king knight and prepares king safety against Black's ambitious center. Delaying b3 can be sensible when the center needs urgent attention.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Compare c4 and f4 only after calculating captures and king exposure. A supported e4 break may also change the central balance.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black may push ...e4 or ...f4 with tempo. A slow double fianchetto can become a target if the center opens before White castles.

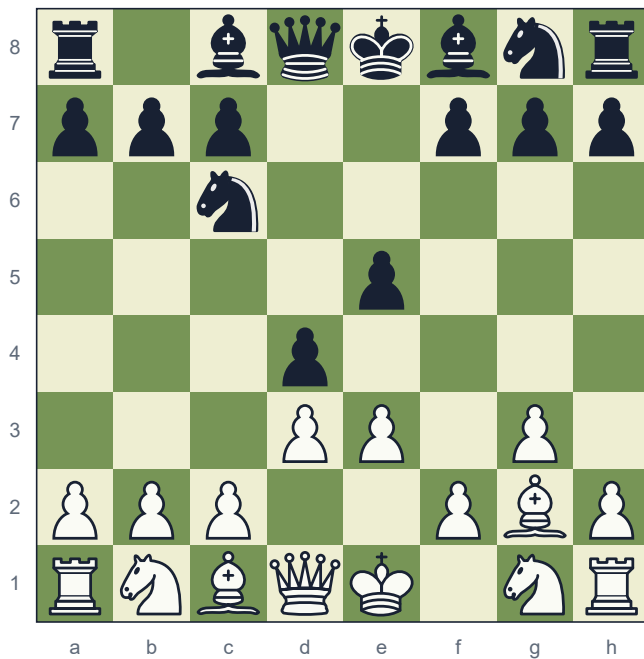
REMEMBER Development comes before decorative symmetry.

HW-09 / Black advances ...d4 early

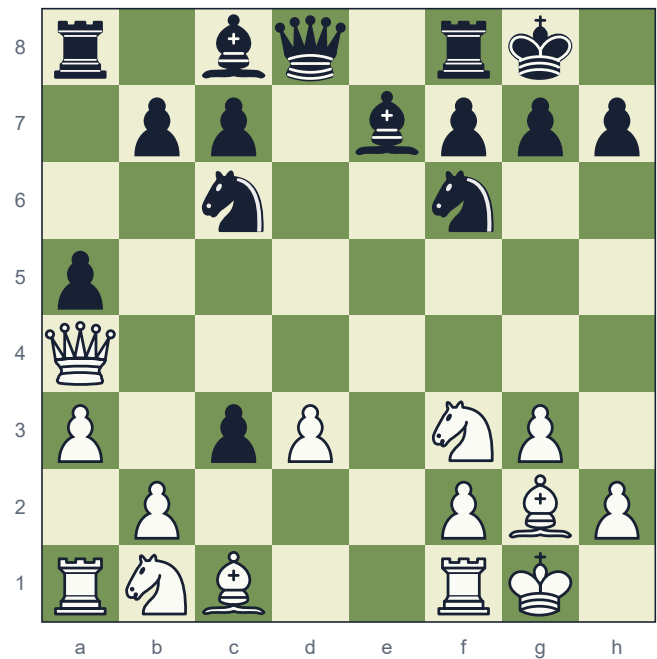
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. g3 d5 2. Bg2 e5 3. d3 Nc6 4. e3 d4 5. exd4 exd4 6. Nf3 Nf6 7. O-O Be7 8. a3 a5 9. c3 O-O 10. Qa4 dxc3

Authored anchor ends after 5... exd4. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

White exchanges the invading pawn and changes the structure. Black retains a d4 wedge, but White has opened a diagonal and can attack the pawn.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop Ne2 or Nf3 and target d4 with c3 when safe. Decide whether the queen bishop belongs on b2 or a more direct square.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

The d4 pawn restricts Nc3 and may support a central outpost. Do not place a knight where an enemy pawn can simply capture it.

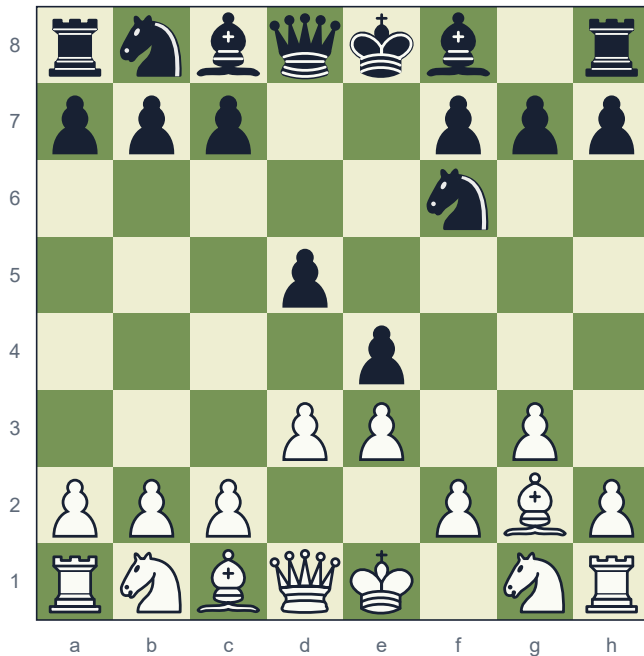
REMEMBER Deal with the wedge before finishing the formation.

HW-10 / Black advances ...e4 early

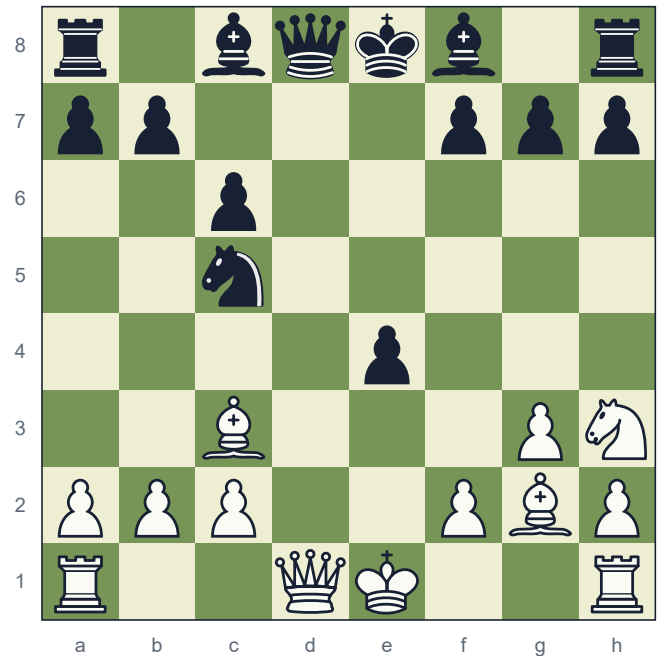
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. g3 d5 2. Bg2 e5 3. d3 Nf6 4. e3 e4 5. dxe4 Nxe4 6. Nd2 Nxd2 7. Bxd2 c6 8. Bc3 Nd7 9. e4 dxe4 10. Nh3 Nc5

Authored anchor ends after 5... Nxe4. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

The central exchange releases Black's knight onto e4. White has prevented a permanent pawn wedge but must now address the active piece.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop with pressure on e4 and keep the queen and king safe along opened files. Choose a knight square that helps challenge the outpost.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

A central knight can threaten forks on c3 or f2 depending on the position. Check its concrete attacks before making another pawn move.

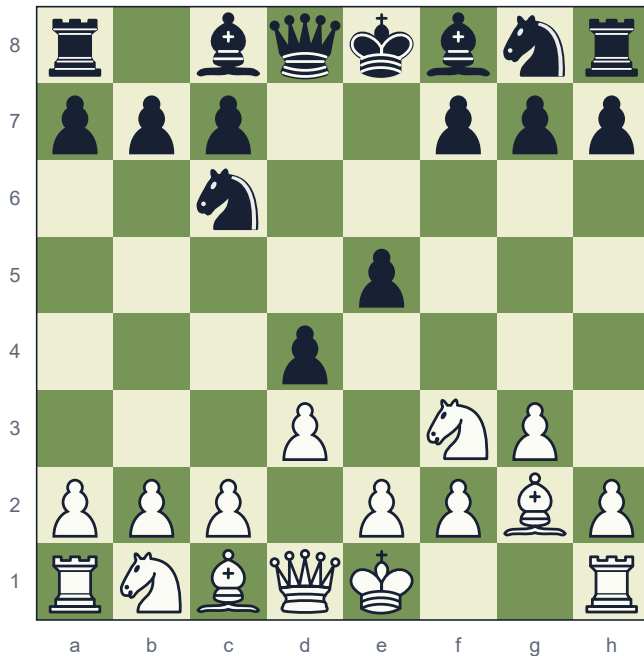
REMEMBER Exchanging a pawn can replace it with a stronger piece.

HW-11 / Black plays ...d4 before e3

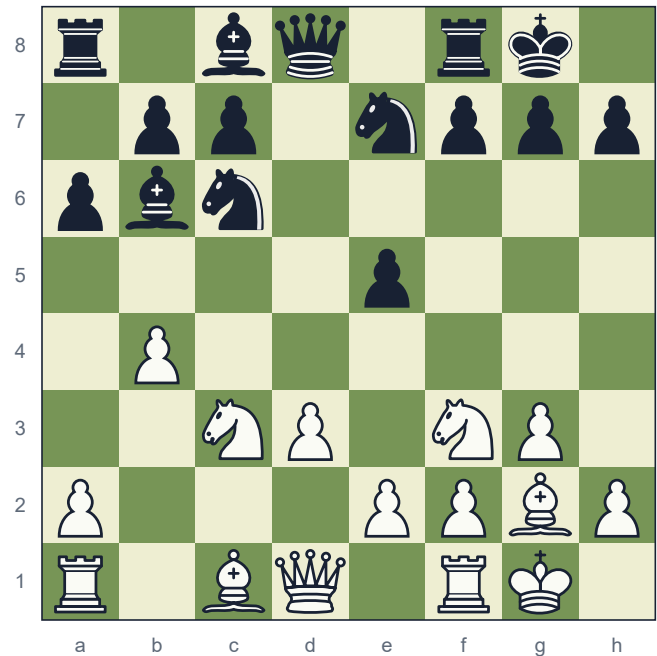
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. g3 d5 2. Bg2 e5 3. d3 d4 4. Nf3 Nc6 5. O-O Bc5 6. Nbd2 Nge7 7. Ne4 Bb6 8. b4 a6 9. c3 dxc3 10. Nxc3 O-O

Authored anchor ends after 5. O-O. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

White abandons the strict Ne2 formation and develops quickly against Black's space. Nf3 is a practical adaptation when central pressure matters more than symmetry.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Use e3 or c3 to undermine d4, and bring out the queen knight to support the chosen break.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black can consolidate with ...Nf6 and ...Be7. Further waiting can let the d4 pawn become a permanent restriction.

REMEMBER Use the knight square the position needs.

HW-12 / Black plays an early ...c6

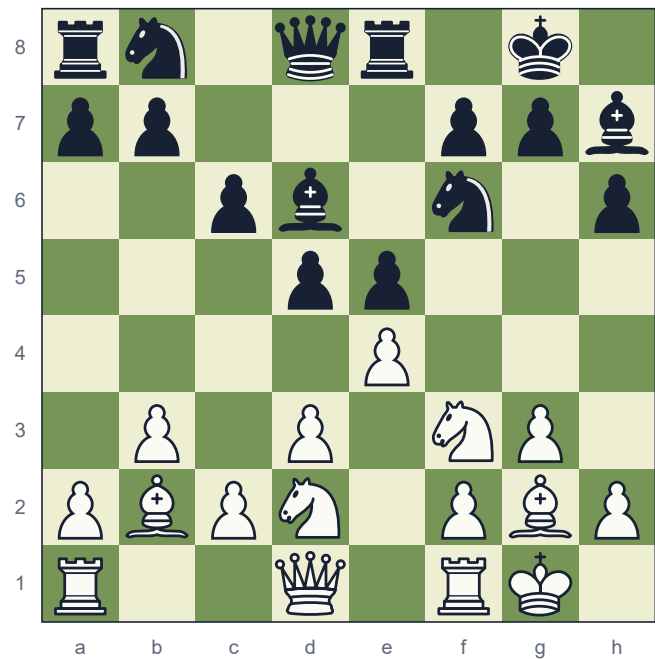
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. g3 d5 2. Bg2 c6 3. d3 e5 4. e3 Nf6 5. b3 Bd6 6. Bb2 O-O 7. Nd2 Re8 8. Ngf3 h6 9. O-O Bf5 10. e4 Bh7

Authored anchor ends after 6. Bb2. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Black supports d5 and may expand with ...e4. White's b2 bishop puts indirect pressure on e5, but that pressure depends on the central pawn contacts.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop a knight and calculate c4 as a challenge to d5. Complete king safety before opening the center widely.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

...e4 can gain space and attack useful squares. Do not count a bishop as attacking through your own e3 pawn.

REMEMBER A blocked diagonal is potential, not present pressure.

Work through HW-07

7. NE2

Develops the king knight without fixing the f-pawn. Compare its onward route with the immediate central influence of Nf3.

8. H3

Controls nearby wing squares and may restrain a piece or pawn. Compare this useful purpose with the time lost to central development.

9. O-O

Moves the king toward shelter and brings a rook toward the center. Check the resulting open lines before assuming the king is safe.

10. F4

Creates a wing or central pawn contact and changes king shelter. Calculate captures and the opponent's central counterplay before extending the advance.

EXPLAIN THE POSITION

Black establishes c5-d5-e5. White must challenge the center before completing every wing pawn move. Develop a knight to support c4 or e4, and calculate the resulting exchanges. Consider whether a partial formation gives more active play than the complete shell.

PRACTICE TASK

Replay this branch without looking. Stop at the first move you cannot explain. Then play the endpoint for ten moves against a partner or engine, switching sides for a second game. Judge your decisions, not just the result.

Flank attacks and early tactics

HOW TO STUDY THIS FAMILY

First reconstruct the main branch from the initial position. Explain the central structure, each side's king safety and the most urgent threat. Then compare the alternatives one at a time.

MAIN BRANCH

HW-13 - Black attacks the g3 pawn before building a center. Nf3 develops and can capture on h4 when Black advances without support.

A PRACTICAL PLAN

Return the knight to a useful square if attacked and complete development. Accepting a pawn is useful only if it does not cost excessive time or king safety.

THE OPPONENT GETS A VOTE

Black may strike in the center while the knight sits on the rim. Do not keep chasing pawns instead of developing.

RECOGNITION TEST

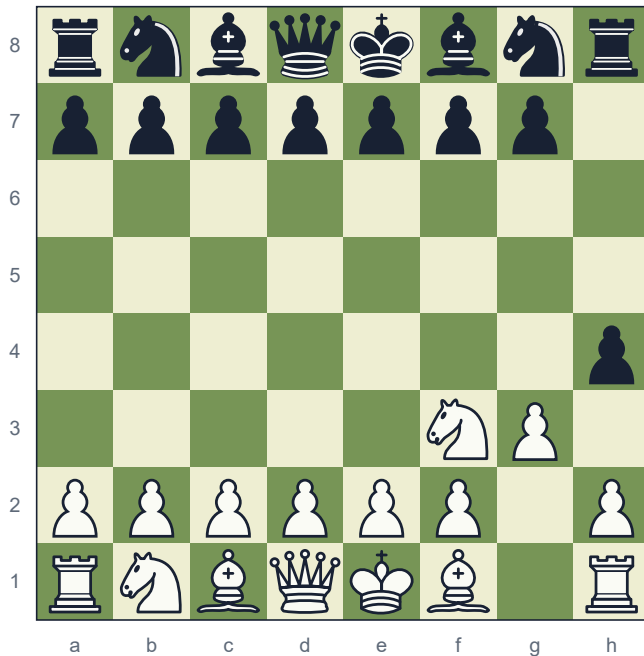
For each alternative, name the move that changes the plan. If you cannot identify that decision, return to the board rather than memorizing the last three moves.

HW-13 / An immediate ...h5

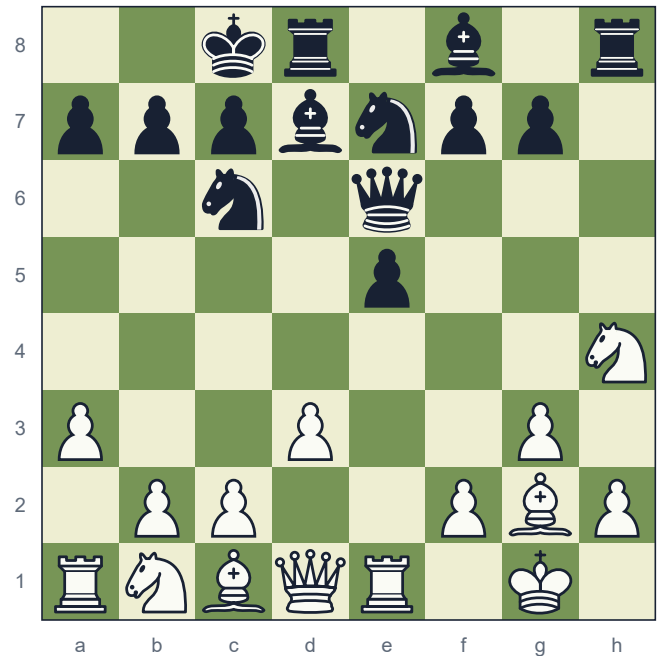
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. g3 h5 2. Nf3 h4 3. Nxh4 e5 4. e4 Nc6 5. d3 d5 6. exd5 Qxd5 7. Bg2 Qe6 8. a3 Bd7 9. O-O O-O-O 10. Re1 Nge7

Authored anchor ends after 3. Nxh4. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Black attacks the g3 pawn before building a center. Nf3 develops and can capture on h4 when Black advances without support.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Return the knight to a useful square if attacked and complete development. Accepting a pawn is useful only if it does not cost excessive time or king safety.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black may strike in the center while the knight sits on the rim. Do not keep chasing pawns instead of developing.

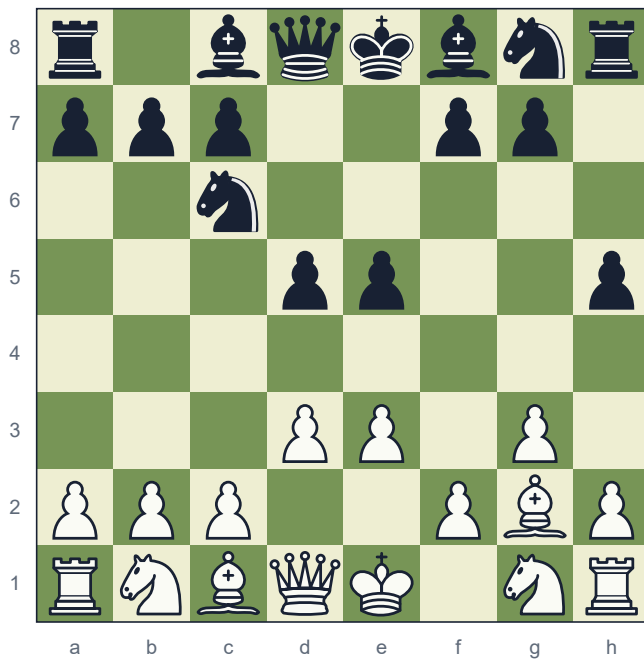
REMEMBER A premature flank attack may be met by a developing move.

HW-14 / The supported h-pawn attack

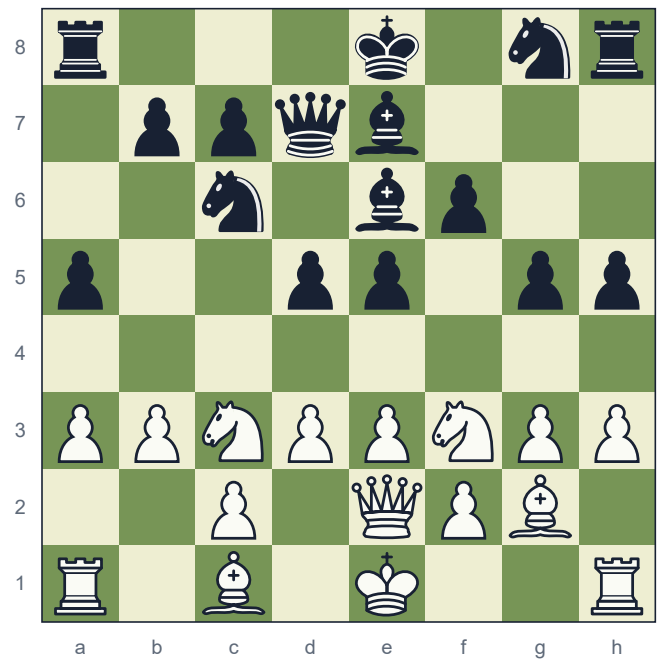
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. g3 d5 2. Bg2 e5 3. d3 Nc6 4. e3 h5 5. h3 Be6 6. a3 a5 7. Nc3 Qd7 8. b3 Be7 9. Nf3 f6 10. Qe2 g5

Authored anchor ends after 5. h3. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

White restrains ...h4 by preparing to meet the pawn contact on favorable terms. This is a specific defensive decision, not a requirement to play h3 in every Hippo.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop quickly and consider central counterplay. If ...h4 arrives, calculate gxh4 and exchanges rather than assuming the wing is locked.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black can prepare ...g5 or castle long. A pawn on h3 can become a hook if the rest of the position is neglected.

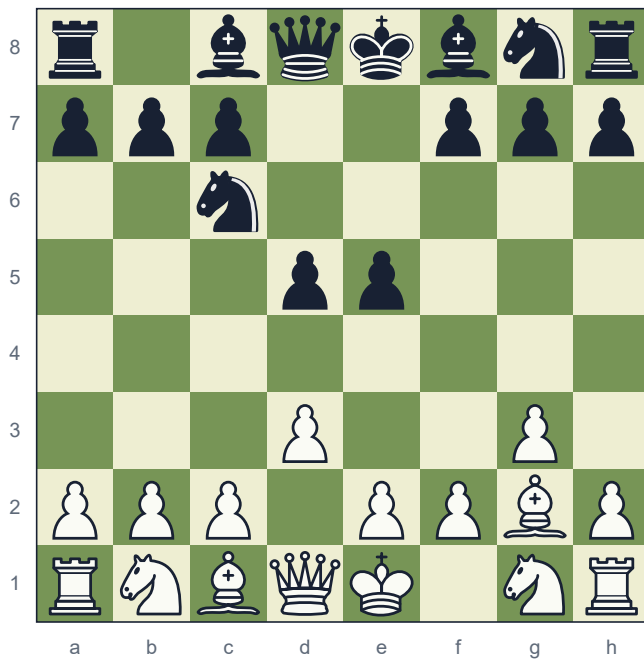
REMEMBER A defensive pawn move creates a future target too.

HW-15 / The ...g5 expansion

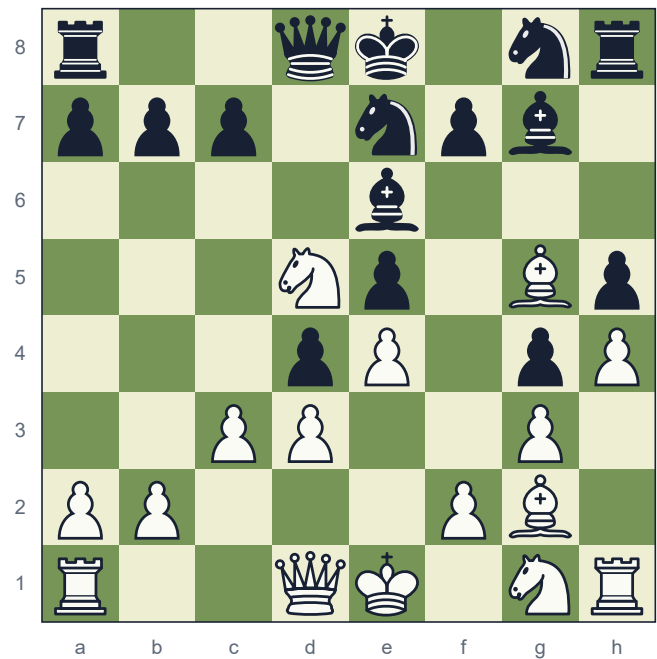
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. g3 d5 2. Bg2 e5 3. d3 Nc6 4. e3 g5 5. Nc3 Be6 6. e4 d4 7. Nd5 h5 8. h4 g4 9. c3 Nce7 10. Bg5 Bg7

Authored anchor ends after 4... g5. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Black gains kingside space while delaying development. White should look for central action and king safety rather than merely copying a pawn wall.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Examine c4 or h4 concretely and develop knights. Choose the king's destination after assessing whether the g- and h-files may open.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black can play ...h5-h4 and gain attacking tempi. A passive reply may turn a premature advance into a strong attack.

REMEMBER Test a wing expansion before it becomes supported.

HW-16 / An early ...Bh3 attempt

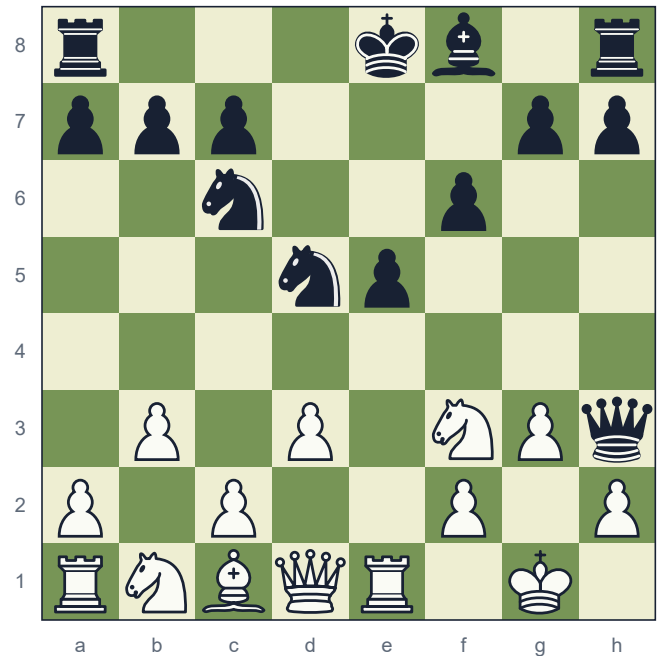
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. g3 d5 2. Bg2 e5 3. d3 Nc6 4. Nf3 Be6 5. O-O Qd7 6. b3 Bh3 7. Bxh3 Qxh3 8. e4 Nf6 9. exd5 Nxd5 10. Re1 f6

Authored anchor ends after 7... Qxh3. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Black exchanges the g2 bishop and brings the queen toward White's already castled king. White's knight has left g1, so the queen on h3 cannot simply be captured by that knight.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Inspect checks and dark-square threats, develop with tempo if available and look for central counterplay. The king is already on g1, so the task is defending the actual shelter.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

If White's knight were still on g1, ...Qxh3 would lose the queen to Nxh3. In this line its different square makes the attack a real concern.

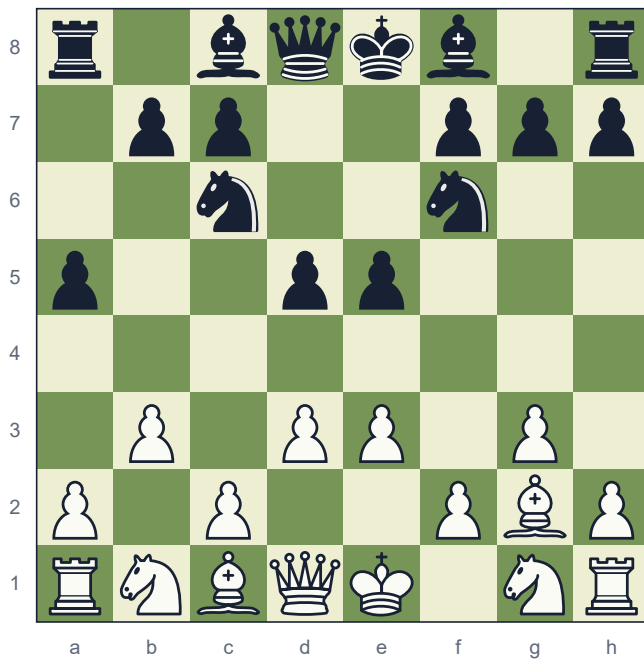
REMEMBER A queen recapture depends on the knight's exact square.

HW-17 / Queenside expansion with ...a5

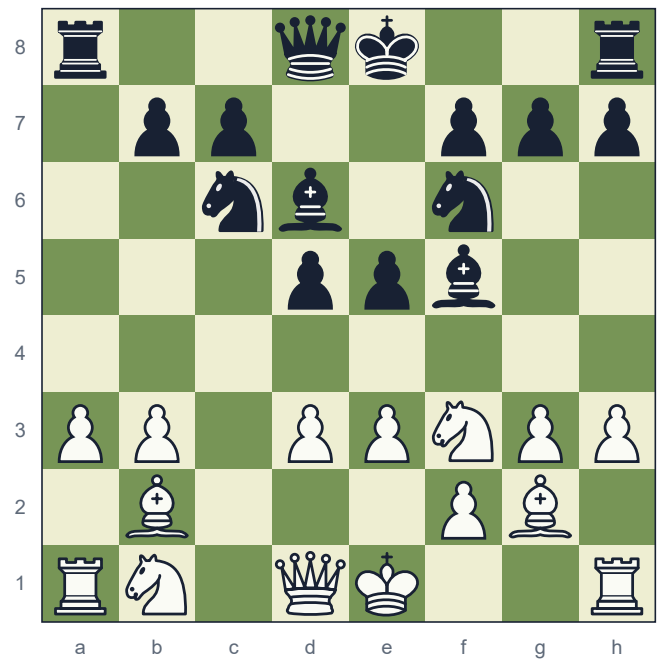
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. g3 d5 2. Bg2 e5 3. d3 Nc6 4. e3 Nf6 5. b3 a5 6. Bb2 a4 7. a3 axb3 8. cxb3 Bg4 9. Nf3 Bd6 10. h3 Bf5

Authored anchor ends after 6... a4. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Black attacks the b3 structure and seeks open queenside lines. White must calculate the pawn contact before adding a routine knight move.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Compare bxa4 with a3 and central counterplay, including rook files and bishop activity after the exchanges.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

The b2 bishop and a1 rook can become targets when files open. A queenside attack may matter even if your king plans to castle short.

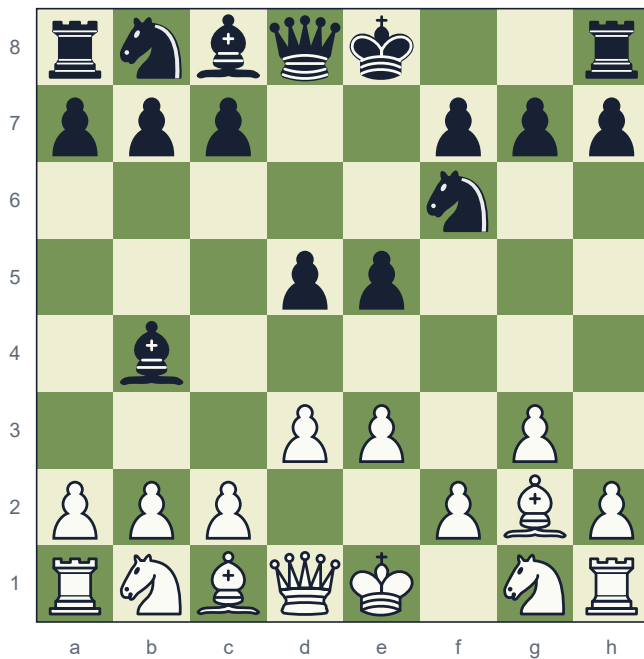
REMEMBER Defend pieces behind the pawn contact.

HW-18 / Black develops ...Bb4+

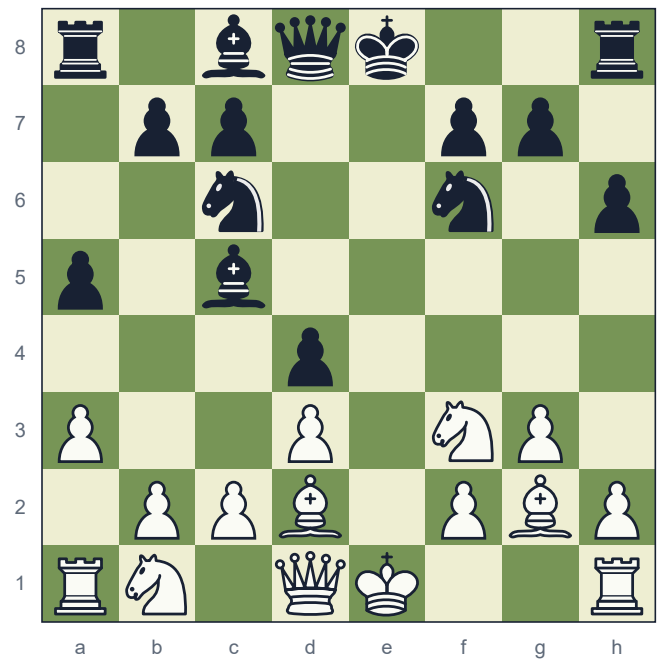
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. g3 e5 2. Bg2 d5 3. d3 Nf6 4. e3 Bb4+ 5. Bd2 a5 6. a3 Bc5 7. Nf3 Nc6 8. Bc3 d4 9. exd4 exd4 10. Bd2 h6

Authored anchor ends after 5. Bd2. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move - in check



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

The bishop check interrupts the setup. Bd2 develops while blocking; the queen bishop does not have to reach b2 in every game.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Complete development and decide whether a later bishop exchange improves coordination. Keep the central pawns supported and castle when safe.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Moving a pawn to block without checking the resulting weaknesses may cost time. A fixed formation is no reason to choose an inferior response to check.

REMEMBER Respond to the check with the best developing move.

Work through HW-13

7. BG2

Places the bishop on g2, attacking queen on d5. A legal capture may still be unsound if the target is defended.

8. A3

Controls nearby wing squares and may restrain a piece or pawn. Compare this useful purpose with the time lost to central development.

9. O-O

Moves the king toward shelter and brings a rook toward the center. Check the resulting open lines before assuming the king is safe.

10. RE1

Places the rook on the e-file, commonly supporting e4 or preparing pressure against an opposing king or central pawn.

EXPLAIN THE POSITION

Black attacks the g3 pawn before building a center. Nf3 develops and can capture on h4 when Black advances without support. Return the knight to a useful square if attacked and complete development. Accepting a pawn is useful only if it does not cost excessive time or king safety.

PRACTICE TASK

Replay this branch without looking. Stop at the first move you cannot explain. Then play the endpoint for ten moves against a partner or engine, switching sides for a second game. Judge your decisions, not just the result.

Useful departures from the complete formation

HOW TO STUDY THIS FAMILY

First reconstruct the main branch from the initial position. Explain the central structure, each side's king safety and the most urgent threat. Then compare the alternatives one at a time.

MAIN BRANCH

HW-19 - White challenges d5 with active development and a castled king. This useful departure resembles a Reti or reversed King's Indian structure more than a complete Hippo.

A PRACTICAL PLAN

Compare ...d4, ...dxc4 and maintaining tension. Develop the queen side according to the resulting pawn structure.

THE OPPONENT GETS A VOTE

If Black closes with ...d4, Nc3 may be restricted. Plan the knight route before fixing every pawn.

RECOGNITION TEST

For each alternative, name the move that changes the plan. If you cannot identify that decision, return to the board rather than memorizing the last three moves.

HW-19 / Choose c4 before the complete shell

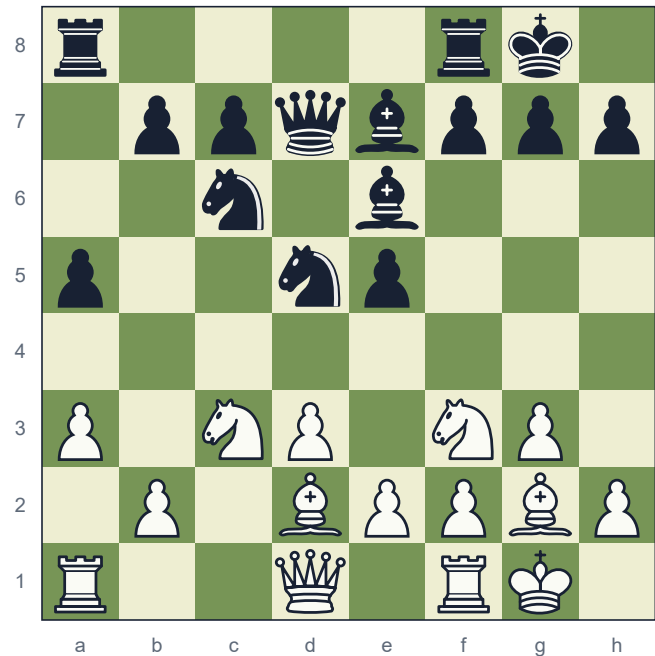
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. g3 d5 2. Bg2 e5 3. d3 Nf6 4. Nf3 Nc6 5. O-O Be7 6. c4 O-O 7. cxd5 Nxd5 8. Nc3 Be6 9. Bd2 Qd7 10. a3 a5

Authored anchor ends after 6. c4. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

White challenges d5 with active development and a castled king. This useful departure resembles a Reti or reversed King's Indian structure more than a complete Hippo.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Compare ...d4, ...dxc4 and maintaining tension. Develop the queen side according to the resulting pawn structure.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

If Black closes with ...d4, Nc3 may be restricted. Plan the knight route before fixing every pawn.

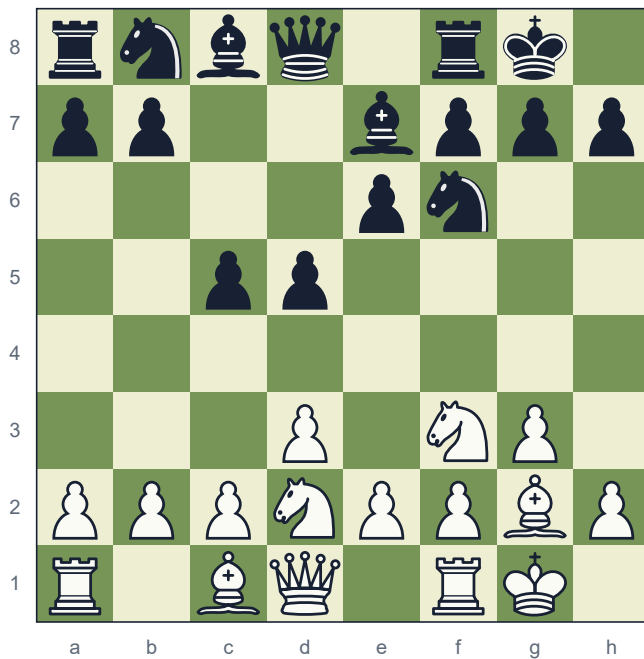
REMEMBER The best Hippo lesson may be when to leave it.

HW-20 / Choose e4 for a KIA transition

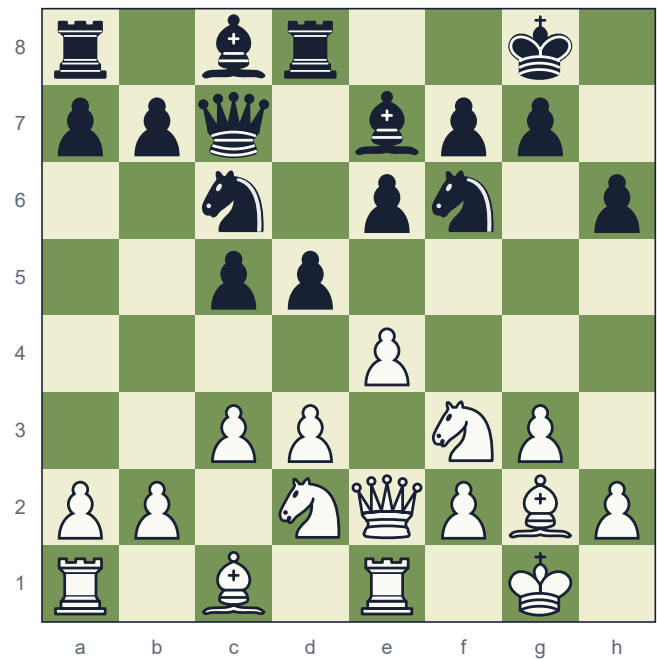
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. g3 d5 2. Bg2 Nf6 3. d3 e6 4. Nf3 Be7 5. O-O O-O 6. Nbd2 c5 7. e4 Nc6 8. Re1 Qc7 9. c3 h6 10. Qe2 Rd8

Authored anchor ends after 7. e4. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

White adopts a King's Indian Attack center because Black's structure makes it useful. The b-pawn remains flexible instead of being committed automatically.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Support e4, then assess e5 and the available knight routes. Use the KIA course for deeper study of this exact center.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black can exchange on e4 or advance ...d4. Do not assume the e5 attack is available in every branch.

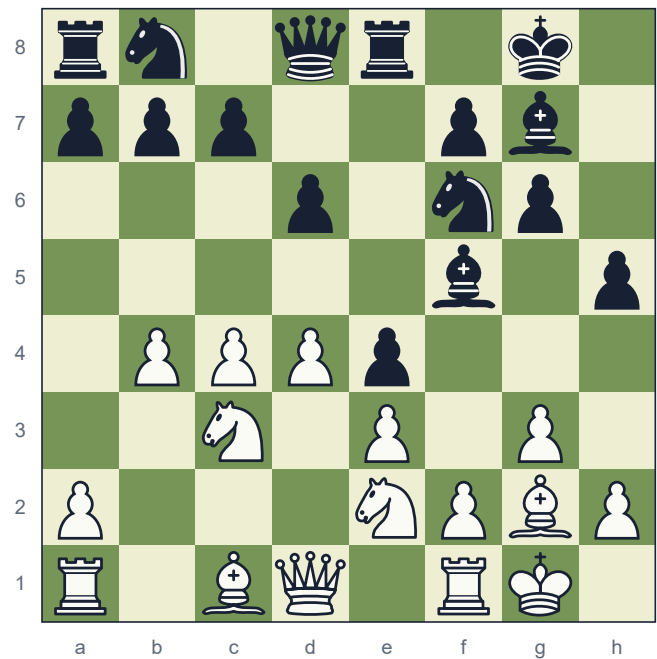
REMEMBER Transition by pawn structure, not by a preferred name.

HW-21 / Choose d4 against a restrained center

COURSE STUDY LINE

1. g3 g6 2. Bg2 Bg7 3. d3 d6 4. e3 Nf6 5. Ne2 O-O 6. O-O e5 7. d4 e4 8. b4 Re8 9. c4 h5 10. Nbc3 Bf5

Authored anchor ends after 7. d4. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



WHY THIS BRANCH

White uses development and king safety to justify a central claim. The d-pawn advances only after the pieces are ready to cope with exchanges.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Calculate ...exd4 and ...Nc6, then develop the queen side to useful squares. Compare the activity of the g2 bishop after the center opens.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Advancing d4 may leave e3 weak or open lines for Black too. A central gain is not free of structural consequences.

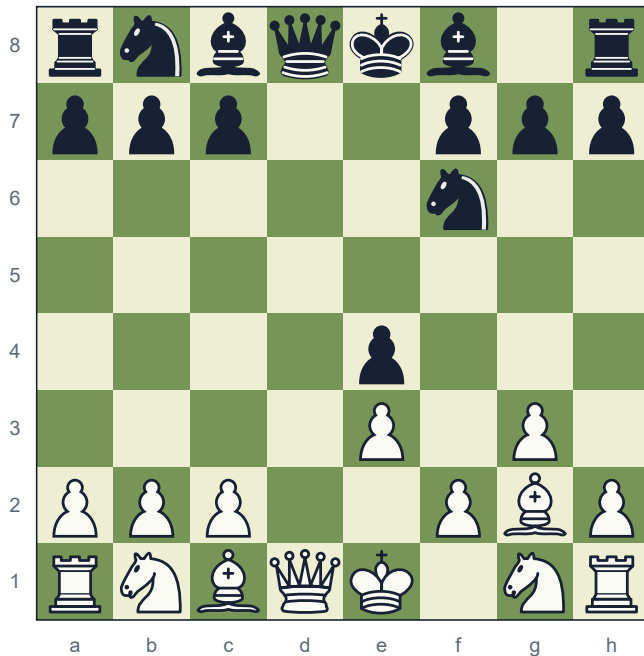
REMEMBER Take central space when your pieces can support it.

HW-22 / Trade queens when the file opens

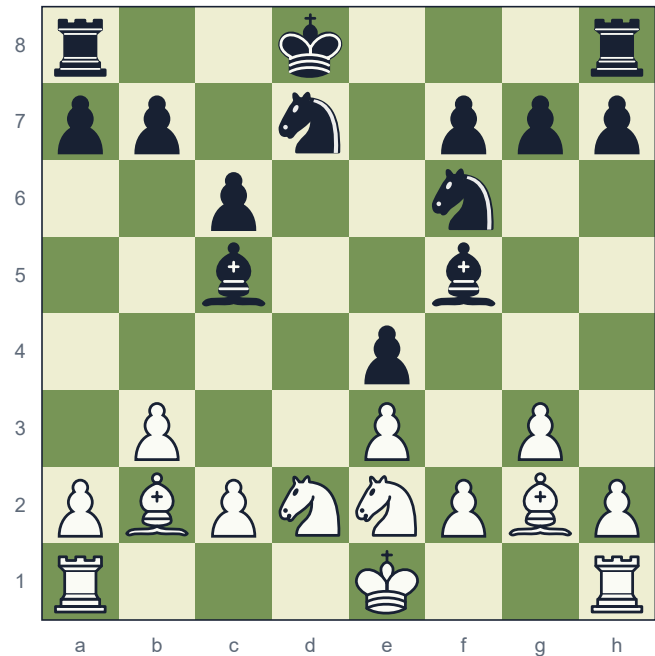
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. g3 e5 2. Bg2 d5 3. d3 Nf6 4. e3 e4 5. dxe4 dxe4 6. Qxd8+ Kxd8 7. Ne2 Bf5 8. Nd2 Bc5 9. b3 Nbd7 10. Bb2 c6

Authored anchor ends after 6... Kxd8. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

The exchanges open the d-file and allow White to remove queens. Black loses castling rights, but with queens gone the main issue is piece activity and pawn targets.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop the knights, assess the e4 pawn and activate the king when safe. Do not keep playing for a direct king attack without queens.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black's centralized king may become useful if the position simplifies further. A lost castling right alone does not prove an advantage.

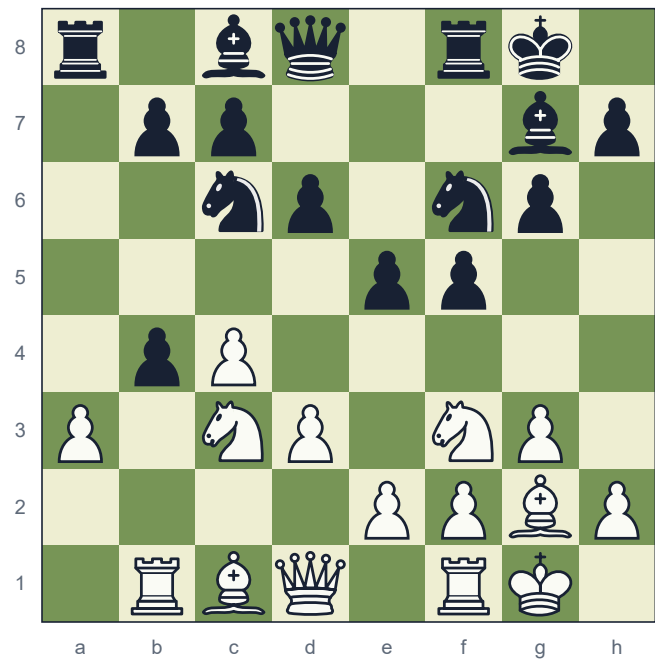
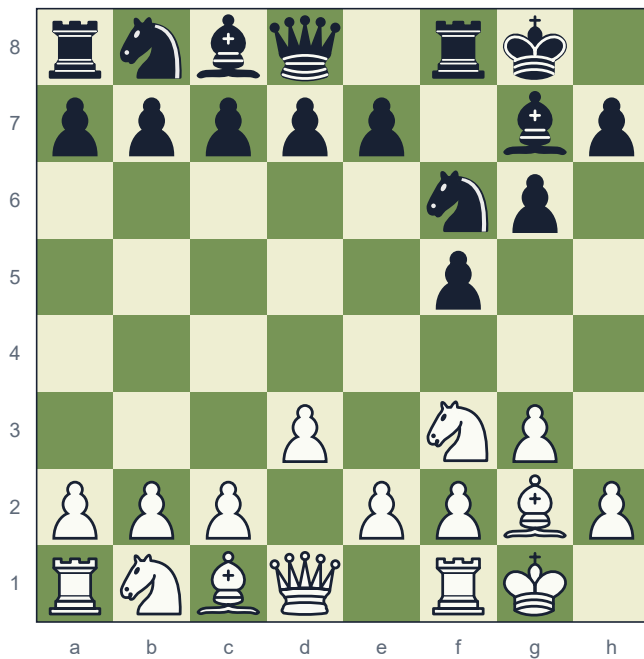
REMEMBER Evaluate the position after the queens disappear.

HW-23 / Use Nf3 against a Dutch center

COURSE STUDY LINE

1. g3 f5 2. Bg2 Nf6 3. d3 g6 4. Nf3 Bg7 5. O-O O-O 6. c4 d6 7. Nc3 Nc6 8. Rb1 a5 9. a3 e5 10. b4 axb4

Authored anchor ends after 6. c4. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



WHY THIS BRANCH

White develops actively and challenges the center with c4 rather than waiting for a full double fianchetto. Black's f-pawn commitment helps define the dark-square battle.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Prepare Nc3 and e4 if justified, or contest d5 directly. Keep an eye on the g7 bishop and Black's potential ...e5 break.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black can build a strong kingside attack if given too much time. Do not answer every threat with a small pawn move.

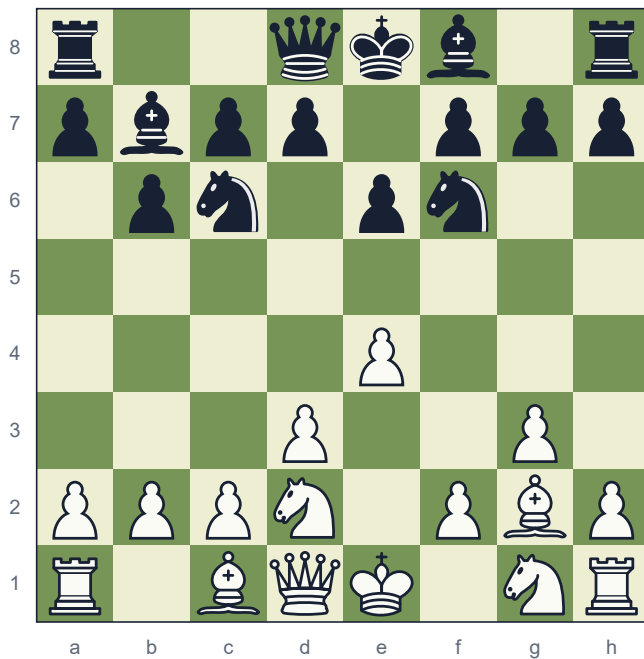
REMEMBER Choose active development when the opponent has a clear attack.

HW-24 / Against early ...b6: occupy the center

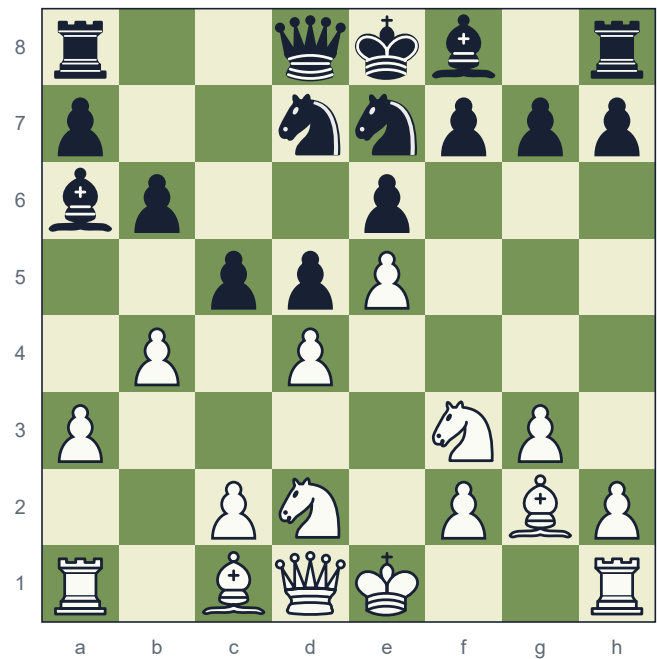
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. g3 b6 2. Bg2 Nc6 3. e4 Bb7 4. d3 e6 5. Nd2 Nf6 6. Ngf3 d5 7. e5 Nd7 8. d4 Ba6 9. a3 Ne7 10. b4 c5

Authored anchor ends after 6. Ngf3. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Black blocks the g2-b7 diagonal with Nc6 before putting the bishop on b7. White uses the flank development to establish a central foothold.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Castle, support e4 and compare central exchanges. The position may become a KIA-style game rather than a complete Hippo.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Immediate ...Bb7 without a blocker would leave that bishop available to Bxb7. Check the long diagonal before assuming a normal fianchetto is safe.

REMEMBER Use central space and inspect undefended fianchetto bishops.

Work through HW-19

7. CXD5

The pawn captures a pawn on d5. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

8. NC3

Places the knight on c3, attacking knight on d5. A legal capture may still be unsound if the target is defended.

9. BD2

Places the bishop on d2. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

10. A3

Controls nearby wing squares and may restrain a piece or pawn. Compare this useful purpose with the time lost to central development.

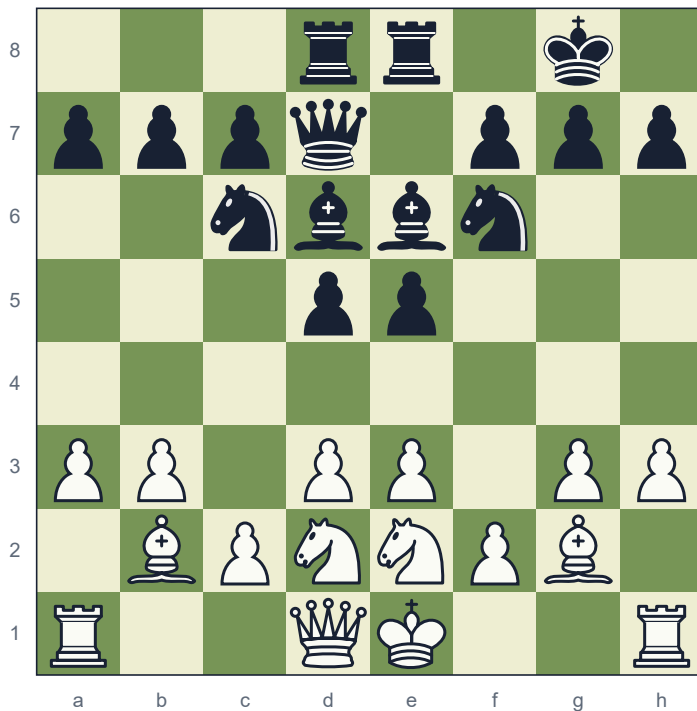
EXPLAIN THE POSITION

White challenges d5 with active development and a castled king. This useful departure resembles a Reti or reversed King's Indian structure more than a complete Hippo. Compare ...d4, ...dxc4 and maintaining tension. Develop the queen side according to the resulting pawn structure.

PRACTICE TASK

Replay this branch without looking. Stop at the first move you cannot explain. Then play the endpoint for ten moves against a partner or engine, switching sides for a second game. Judge your decisions, not just the result.

Use the extra move



HW-01 anchor - White to move

THE IDEA

White has the first move but can give away its value by making ten small setup moves while Black takes the center. A reversed Hippo is a practical choice with concessions, not a guaranteed initiative.

HOW TO DECIDE

Use flexibility to select an active central challenge. Compare a useful developing move or c4 with a3 and h3 before deciding that both wing pawn moves are needed.

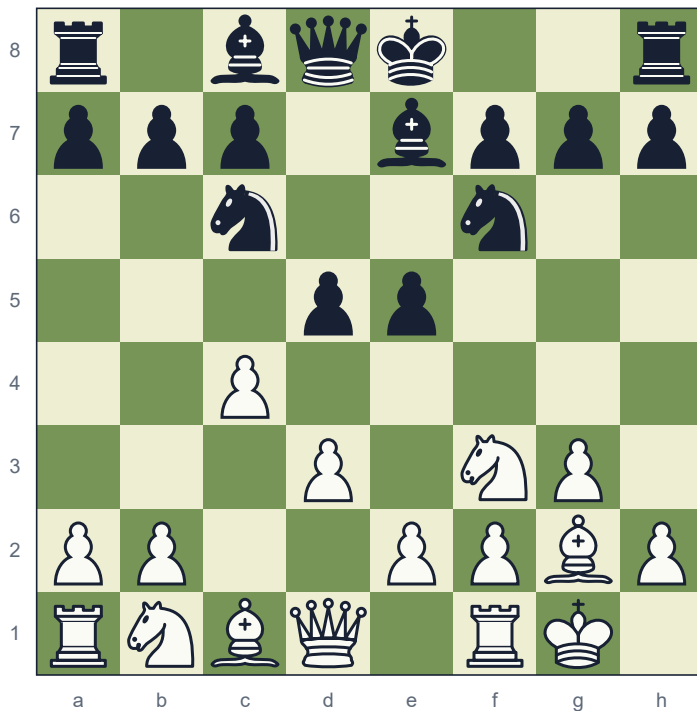
THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

Black can gain a broad center and a comfortable game. White should not rely on Black making an impatient attack.

BOARD DRILL

At a quiet endpoint, identify one setup move that could have been replaced by earlier central action.

c4, d4 or e4?



HW-19 anchor - Black to move

THE IDEA

c4 challenges d5; d4 contests central space directly; e4 may lead to a KIA structure. The best choice depends on Black's pawns and your knight squares.

HOW TO DECIDE

Calculate captures and advances before committing. Decide where the queen knight belongs afterward and whether the b2 or g2 bishop benefits from the change.

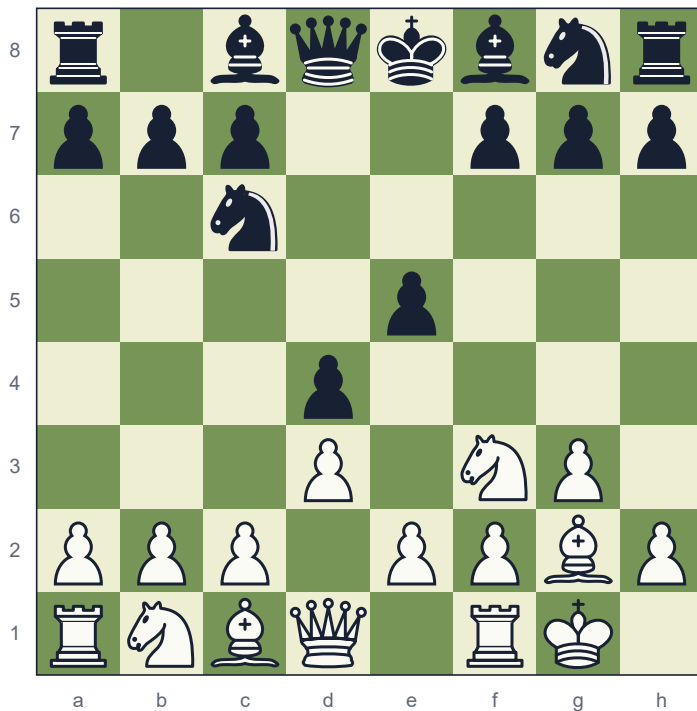
THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

Black can close the center and restrict a knight. A pawn break without a development plan can leave you with less room, not more.

BOARD DRILL

Compare the three adaptation branches and write the central pawn structure after the first exchange in each.

Ne2 versus Nf3



HW-11 anchor - Black to move

THE IDEA

Ne2 preserves some pawn flexibility and avoids blocking the g2 bishop's immediate diagonal, but Nf3 contests e5 and may be more urgent against a large center.

HOW TO DECIDE

Choose the knight square from its next useful job. If Black threatens ...e4, calculate whether Nf3 would be attacked; if d4 needs pressure, compare the available support.

THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

A rigid insistence on Ne2 can leave the center uncontested. A careless Nf3 can allow a pawn gain with tempo.

BOARD DRILL

Use two branches with different knight routes and explain the concrete central difference.

The bishop on b2 is not always best



HW-18 anchor - Black to move

THE IDEA

A check from ...Bb4+ may be best met with Bd2. A central opening may give the bishop a useful diagonal elsewhere. Double fianchettoing is an option, not an obligation.

HOW TO DECIDE

Choose a developing response that answers the actual threat. After an exchange, identify which diagonals remain useful and whether relocating the bishop costs too much time.

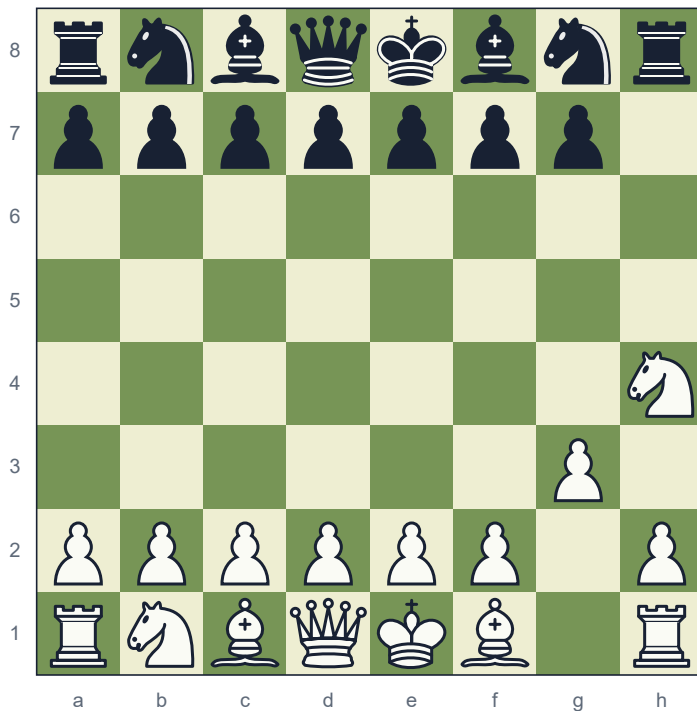
THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

Black can open the center before you complete the setup. Moving the bishop twice to preserve an image can waste valuable tempi.

BOARD DRILL

Replay the ...Bb4+ branch and compare Bd2 with a pawn block using legal moves and resulting development.

When Black attacks with h-pawns



HW-13 anchor - Black to move

THE IDEA

The g3 pawn gives the king bishop a square but offers a target for ...h5-h4. White must judge whether the advance is supported and whether central counterplay is available.

HOW TO DECIDE

Against an unsupported rush, development may permit a capture. Against a prepared attack, compare restraint, exchanges and a central break. Count rook lines before castling.

THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

A pawn on h3 can become a hook for ...g4 or ...h4. Stopping one move is not the same as solving the whole attack.

BOARD DRILL

Compare the immediate ...h5 line with the supported ...h5 line. Explain why the same response is not automatic.

A missing fianchetto bishop



HW-16 anchor - White to move

THE IDEA

After ...Bh3 and an exchange on h3, the queen approaches dark squares near White's king. The bishop that used to defend those squares is gone.

HOW TO DECIDE

Inspect checks, queen entry squares and pawn levers. Develop with tempo if possible and consider whether a central challenge is faster than a passive defense.

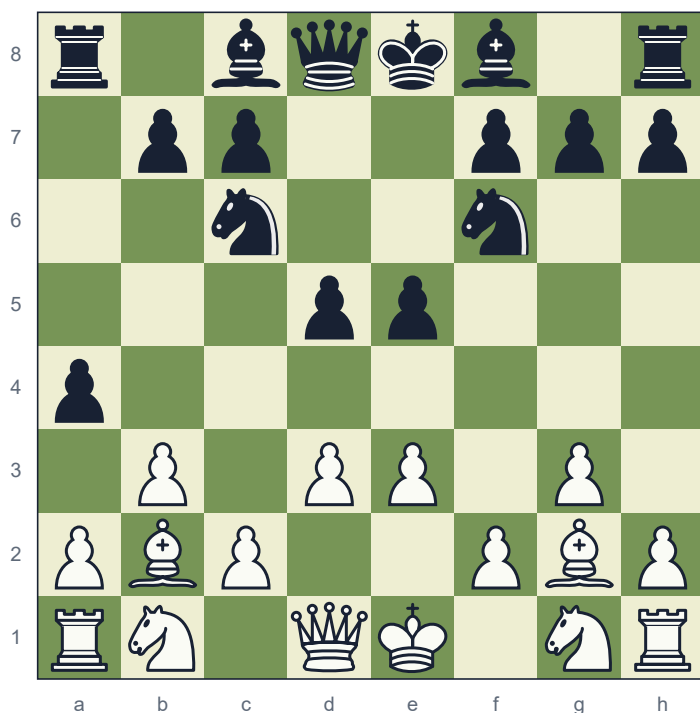
THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

Black may combine ...h5 with queen pressure. Castling short into a concrete attack can be worse than keeping the king central temporarily.

BOARD DRILL

Point to three squares the g2 bishop used to cover and examine which become relevant after the exchange.

Queenside pawn contacts



HW-17 anchor - White to move

THE IDEA

With b3 and Bb2, a black ...a5-a4 advance challenges the pawn cover in front of the bishop and rook. This matters even if White plans to castle short.

HOW TO DECIDE

Calculate bxa4, a3 and maintaining tension. Trace opened files and count defenders of the bishop. Compare a central response if Black spends several wing tempi.

THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

The a1 rook can become exposed after exchanges, and the bishop may lose a safe retreat. A pawn contact can create a piece tactic.

BOARD DRILL

Set up the ...a4 endpoint and list the pieces behind the pawns before calculating any capture.

Transitioning to normal active play



HW-20 anchor - Black to move

THE IDEA

A KIA, Reti or central fianchetto position may be the best result of a flexible opening. The course deliberately includes these departures so the Hippo does not become a cage.

HOW TO DECIDE

Name the new pawn structure and use its plans. If e4 leads to a French-type KIA, support e5; if c4 opens the d-file, contest that file.

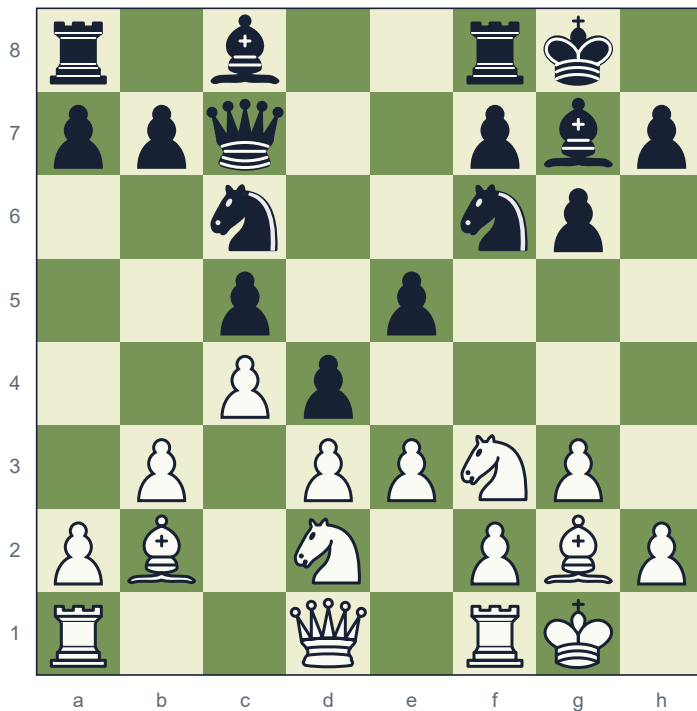
THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

Black can change the center again. A successful transition still requires the same threat and blunder checks on every move.

BOARD DRILL

Choose one adaptation as your default when the full setup looks too slow, and practice that endpoint for three games.

Loose pieces and forks



HW-03 audit position - White to move

AUDIT THIS REAL POSITION

Find two pieces that would be vulnerable if their defender moved. Calculate one legal forcing move that tests the relation. This is an analysis exercise; it does not assert that a winning tactic exists in the diagram.

CONNECT IT TO THIS OPENING

Black can advance ...d4 and restrict the b1 knight. The g7 bishop may become stronger than its white counterpart after exchanges.

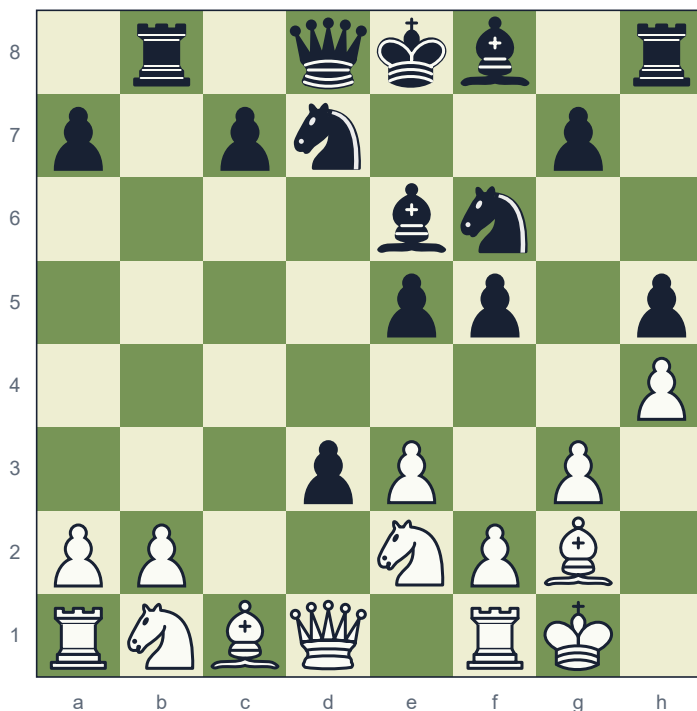
A USEFUL ANSWER

Give a short legal variation and an explanation of the resulting material and king safety. If there is no forcing gain, say so and choose a developing or improving move. Finding no combination can be the correct conclusion.

CALCULATION SKILL

Before calculating an attack, list undefended pieces. A knight fork attacks two targets that cannot both move away. A queen check may combine king pressure with a second target. If you remove a defender, inspect every piece it protected.

Pins and discovered attacks



HW-08 audit position - White to move

CALCULATION SKILL

An absolute pin prevents a piece from moving if doing so exposes its king. A relative pin involves a valuable piece behind it, usually the queen. A discovered attack appears when a blocking piece moves away. Always trace the entire line, including the piece behind the blocker.

AUDIT THIS REAL POSITION

Identify a line piece, its blocker and the target behind it. If no pin exists, explain which required element is missing. This is an analysis exercise; it does not assert that a winning tactic exists in the diagram.

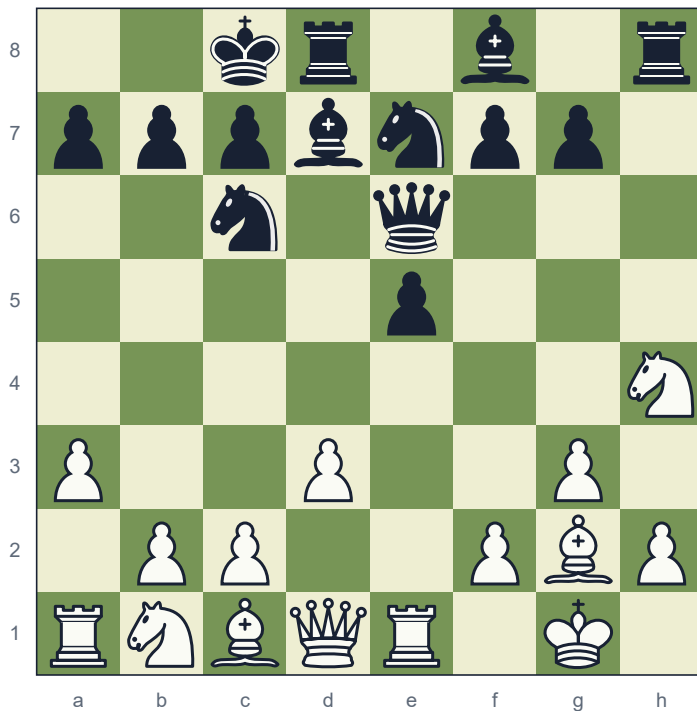
CONNECT IT TO THIS OPENING

Black may push ...e4 or ...f4 with tempo. A slow double fianchetto can become a target if the center opens before White castles.

A USEFUL ANSWER

Give a short legal variation and an explanation of the resulting material and king safety. If there is no forcing gain, say so and choose a developing or improving move. Finding no combination can be the correct conclusion.

Intermediate moves and defensive resources



HW-13 audit position - White to move

AUDIT THIS REAL POSITION

At a capture in your line, pause before the reply. List all legal checks, then compare them with the expected recapture. This is an analysis exercise; it does not assert that a winning tactic exists in the diagram.

CONNECT IT TO THIS OPENING

Black may strike in the center while the knight sits on the rim. Do not keep chasing pawns instead of developing.

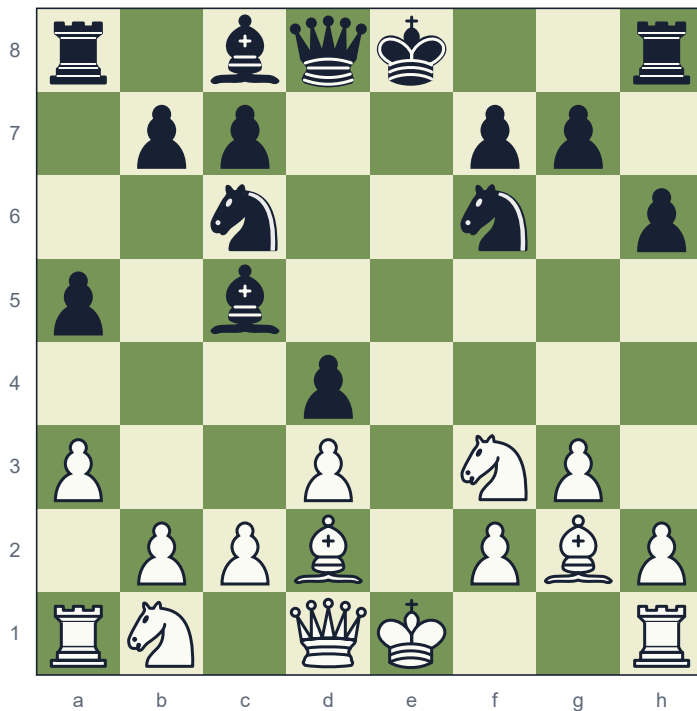
A USEFUL ANSWER

Give a short legal variation and an explanation of the resulting material and king safety. If there is no forcing gain, say so and choose a developing or improving move. Finding no combination can be the correct conclusion.

CALCULATION SKILL

A recapture is not compulsory unless it is the only legal response to check. Before recapturing, inspect checks, stronger captures and direct threats. When attacking, give the defender the same opportunity; do not assume automatic recaptures.

A sacrifice needs a stopping point



HW-18 audit position - White to move

CALCULATION SKILL

Calculate a sacrifice until the defender has a stable reply you can evaluate. Count material after the whole sequence, not after the first capture. If the line ends only with a vague promise of attack, compare a non-sacrificial candidate.

AUDIT THIS REAL POSITION

Choose a tempting sacrifice from a laboratory or your own game. Write the best defensive reply and the position where you stop calculating. This is an analysis exercise; it does not assert that a winning tactic exists in the diagram.

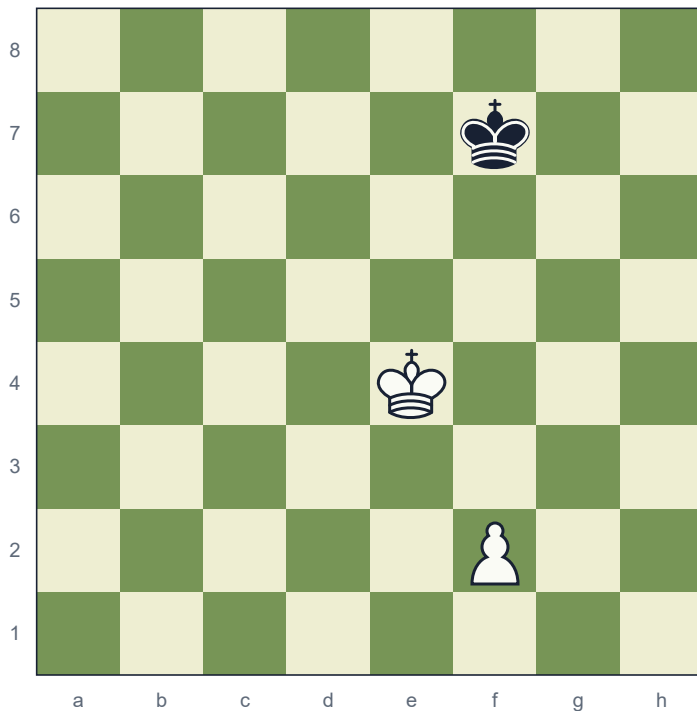
CONNECT IT TO THIS OPENING

Moving a pawn to block without checking the resulting weaknesses may cost time. A fixed formation is no reason to choose an inferior response to check.

A USEFUL ANSWER

Give a short legal variation and an explanation of the resulting material and king safety. If there is no forcing gain, say so and choose a developing or improving move. Finding no combination can be the correct conclusion.

Activate the king when queens are gone



Teaching position - White to move

READ THE BOARD

White to move: Kf5 is a legal active king move. Kf4 is also legal but less direct; compare plans rather than inventing a forcing win. The general lesson is to bring the king toward the pawn and useful squares while keeping the opposing king out.

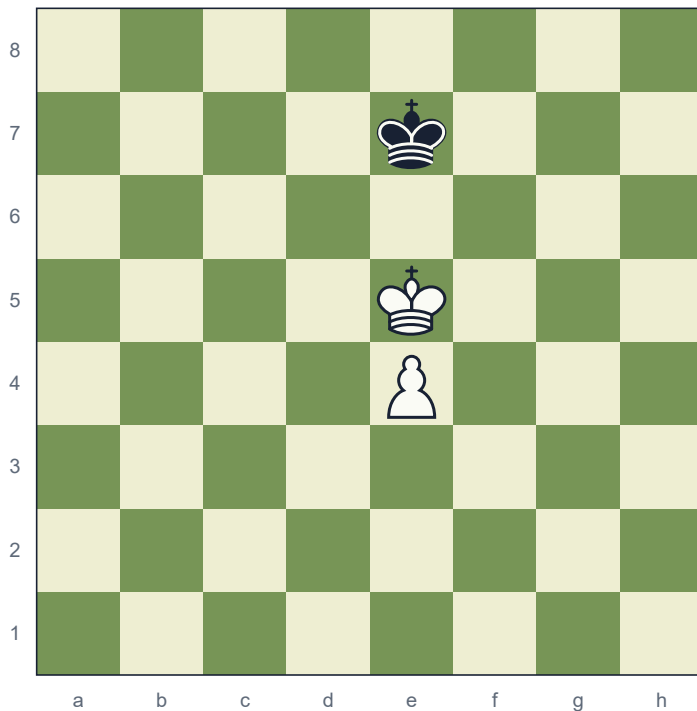
FROM YOUR OPENING TO THIS LESSON

In an opening-to-endgame transition, first inspect checks and pawn threats, then activate the king. Do not continue making shelter moves whose main purpose was defense against a queen. A rook ending may still require care about checks from behind.

PRACTICE

Reconstruct the diagram. Explain the legal moves and the role of each king before moving. Then return to a course endpoint and identify which feature of this simple lesson could matter after exchanges.

Opposition and the importance of the move



Teaching position - White to move

READ THE BOARD

The kings face each other on e5 and e7 with one square between. White to move must give way or move the pawn; the geometry changes if Black is to move. Opposition is a tool for gaining entry squares, not a rule that always wins.

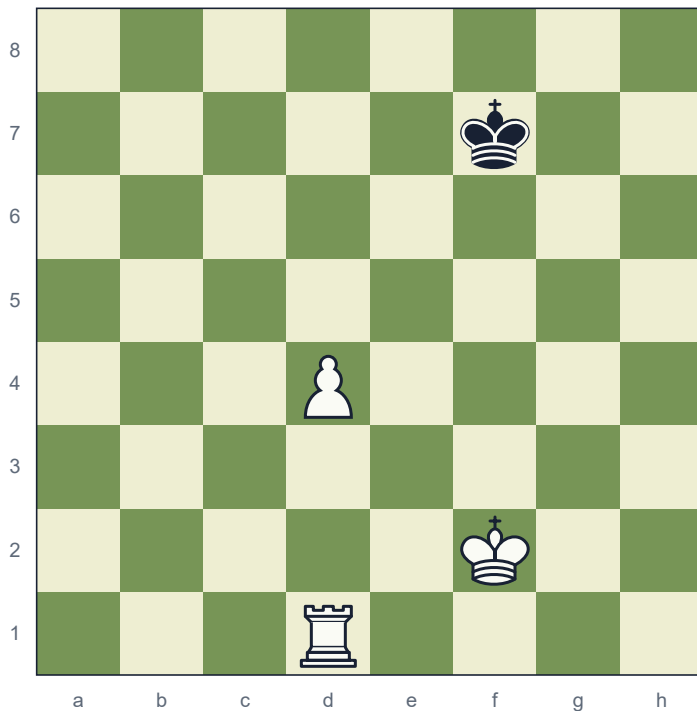
FROM YOUR OPENING TO THIS LESSON

Replay both side-to-move versions. Track the pawn's key squares and whether the attacking king can reach them. If you exchange into a pawn ending, calculate the actual king route and tempo rather than relying on the extra pawn alone.

PRACTICE

Reconstruct the diagram. Explain the legal moves and the role of each king before moving. Then return to a course endpoint and identify which feature of this simple lesson could matter after exchanges.

Rooks belong where they work



Teaching position - White to move

READ THE BOARD

The rook on d1 stands behind its own passed d-pawn. As the pawn advances, the rook can continue supporting it from behind. This is a teaching position, not a claim of a difficult theoretical win against a rook.

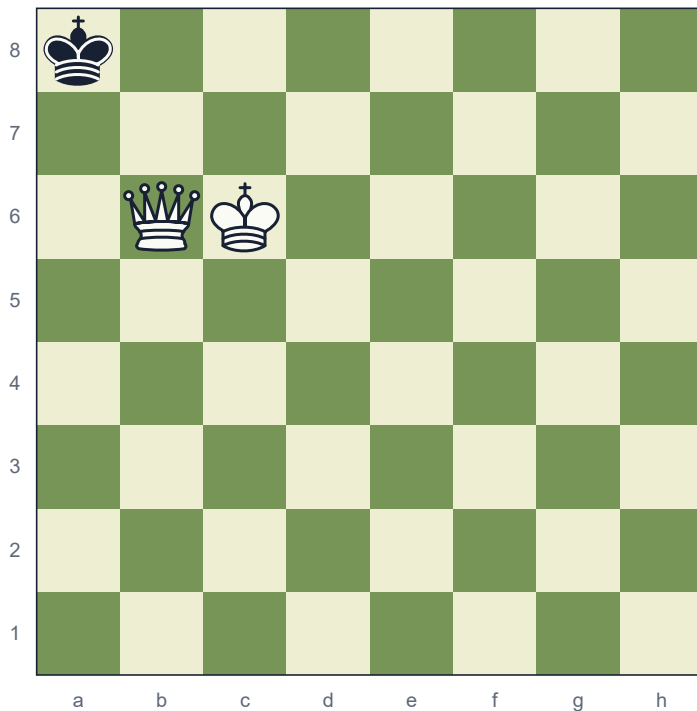
FROM YOUR OPENING TO THIS LESSON

In real rook endings compare activity, checking distance, king shelter and pawn races. Putting a rook behind a passed pawn is a useful default, but a tactical threat or a decisive lateral check can override it. Do not trade an active rook into a lost pawn ending.

PRACTICE

Reconstruct the diagram. Explain the legal moves and the role of each king before moving. Then return to a course endpoint and identify which feature of this simple lesson could matter after exchanges.

Recognize stalemate before promoting



Teaching position - Black to move

READ THE BOARD

Black to move is not in check and has no legal move: a7 and b8 are controlled by Qb6, while b7 is controlled by the queen and Kc6. This is stalemate, so the position is a draw despite White's extra queen.

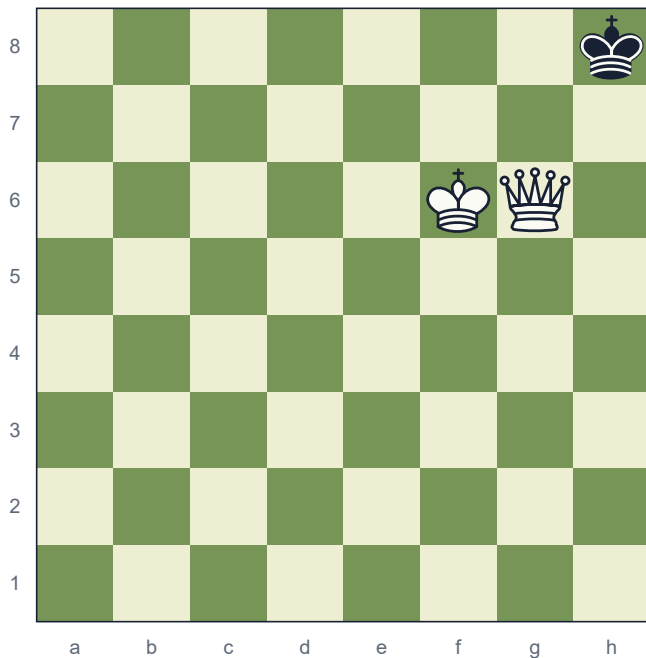
FROM YOUR OPENING TO THIS LESSON

Before delivering the final move of a won game, check whether the opponent has a legal reply if not in check. In queen-versus-king technique, restrict the king with the queen, approach with your king and preserve a legal waiting square until you can give mate.

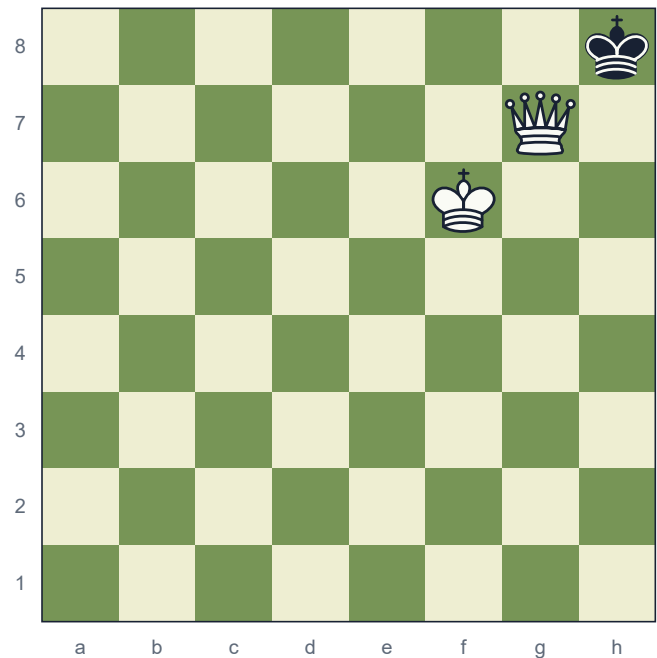
PRACTICE

Reconstruct the diagram. Explain the legal moves and the role of each king before moving. Then return to a course endpoint and identify which feature of this simple lesson could matter after exchanges.

Finish a won queen ending



White to move - find mate in one



After Qg7# - Black is checkmated

WHY THIS IS MATE

Qg7 gives check along the g7-h8 diagonal. The white king on f6 protects the queen, so ...Kxg7 is illegal. The queen controls g8 and h7, removing the remaining escape squares. This proof checks attacks and legal replies, not just the appearance of the diagram.

TECHNIQUE BEFORE THE FINAL MOVE

Use the queen to reduce the enemy king's space, bring your king close enough to support the mate, and keep a legal waiting square until you can give checkmate. A queen alone can accidentally stalemate; review the previous lesson before repeating this drill.

Choosing the right exchanges

DO NOT TRADE BY HABIT

When offered a trade, compare the activity of the pieces leaving the board, the resulting pawn weaknesses and the king positions. A player with less space may welcome exchanges, but trading the only active piece can make the position worse.

PAWN ENDING TEST

Before exchanging the last pieces, calculate king activity, passed-pawn races and the side to move. Opposition is one tool; it is not a substitute for counting legal tempi. A pawn ending is often less forgiving than a rook ending.

OPENING-SPECIFIC QUESTION

A KIA, Reti or central fianchetto position may be the best result of a flexible opening. The course deliberately includes these departures so the Hippo does not become a cage.

PRACTICAL CONVERSION

When ahead, neutralize counterplay and improve the least active piece before collecting another pawn. When defending, seek active checks, pawn breaks and useful exchanges rather than passive waiting.

A STUDY HABIT

After every practice game, keep one transition position. Record which exchange you chose, which alternative you considered and how the pawn structure changed.

How the six laboratories work

ORIGINAL ILLUSTRATIVE PLAY

These are original engine-assisted study continuations from this course's positions. They are not historical master games and no invented players or tournament results are assigned. The continuations reach roughly move twenty and stop for further practice.

THINK BEFORE REVEALING

At each checkpoint, name the opponent's threat, compare two candidates and calculate a forcing reply. Use a board to replay the sequence. The engine comparison supplies concrete evidence, while the opening explanation supplies a plan.

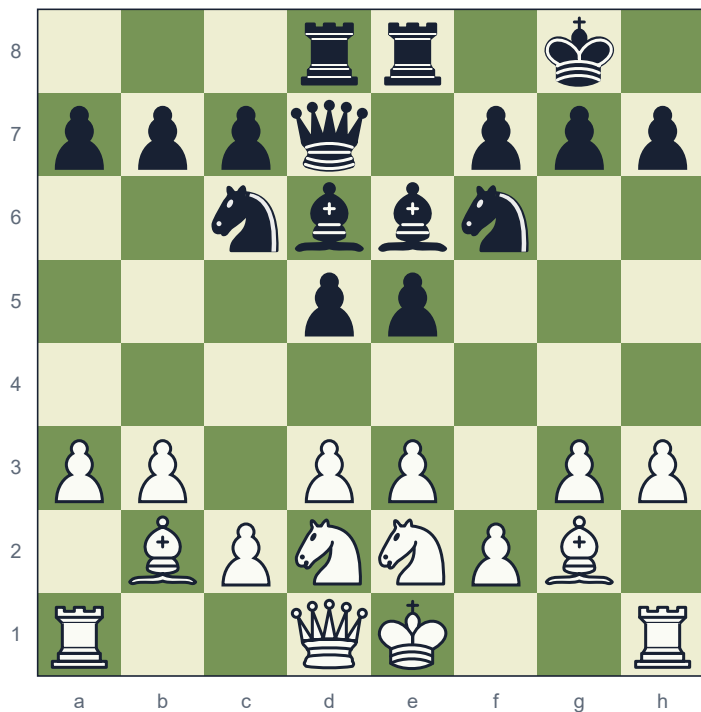
MORE THAN ONE GOOD MOVE

Close engine scores do not establish a unique answer. The finite search can prefer a different move when run longer. Accept another candidate if you can support it with a sound variation and a coherent explanation.

PRACTICE FROM BOTH SIDES

Play each starting position twice, switching colors. Record the first decision you could not explain and compare it with the branch lesson after the game.

HW-LAB-01 / The complete formation as a study position



Laboratory start - White to move

OPENING BACKGROUND

White reaches the familiar two-rank formation while Black occupies the center. This quiet illustrative route is not a claim that all ten setup moves are best in every position.

READ THE CURRENT POSITION

White king e1; central-file pawns c2, f2, d3, e3. Black king g8; central-file pawns d5, e5, c7, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

OPENING CONCERN TO RECHECK

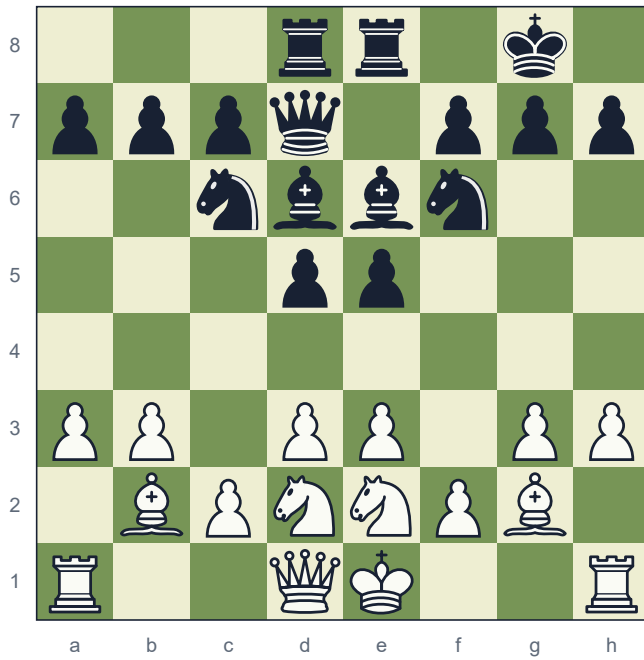
Black has more space and can prepare ...e4 or ...d4. White's extra tempo has not prevented a central bind. Decide which parts still apply after the moves already played.

BEFORE PLAYING

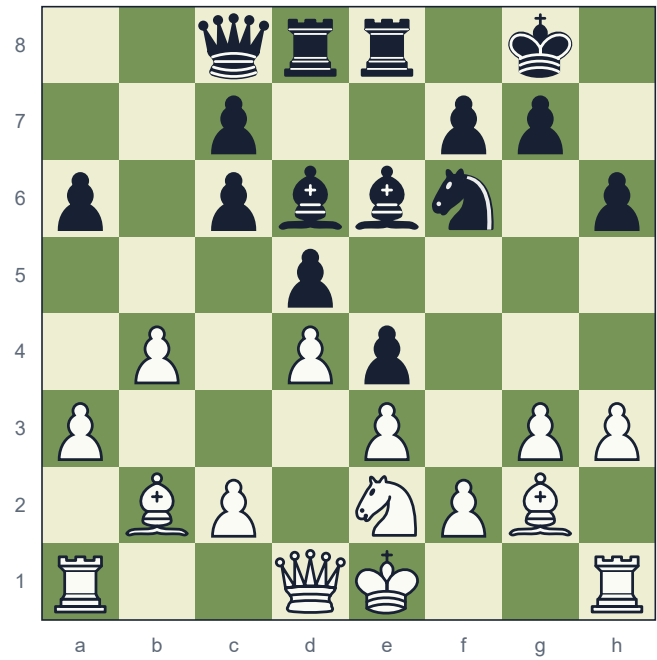
Write a candidate move and a reply for the opponent. Name the pawn break each side would like to achieve. The continuation on the following pages is one checked illustration, not a forced script.

HW-LAB-01 / play and explain 1

11. Nf3 h6 12. b4 a6 13. d4 e4 14. Ne5 Qc8 15. Nxc6 bxc6



Before this segment - White to move



After this segment - White to move

11. Nf3

Develops the king knight toward e5 and d4. In the King's Gambit it also controls h4, making an immediate queen check there unattractive.

13. d4

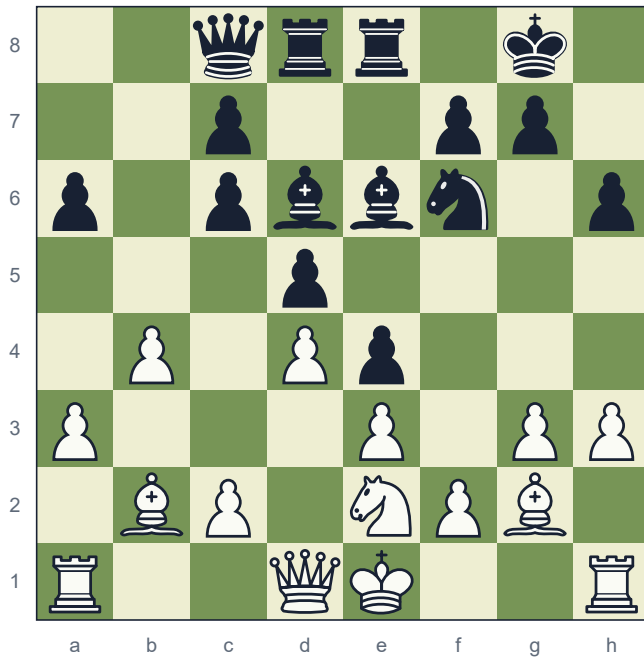
Changes central space and pawn contacts. Calculate captures, advances and maintaining tension before choosing the next piece plan.

REASSESS

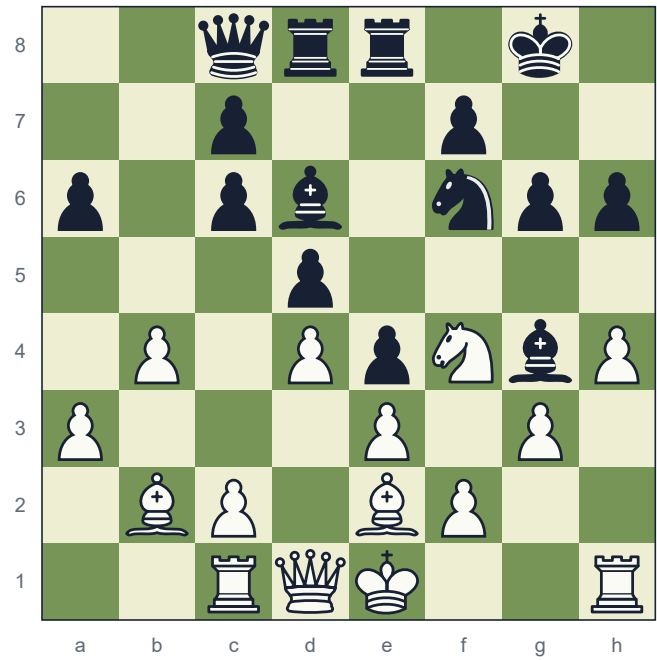
Name the material balance, the most active piece and the next pawn break. If the center changed, explain why the original plan may need to change too.

HW-LAB-01 / play and explain 2

16. Nf4 Bf5 17. Bf1 Nh7 18. h4 Nf6 19. Be2 g6 20. Rc1 Bg4



Before this segment - White to move



After this segment - White to move

16. Nf4

Places the knight on f4, attacking bishop on e6. A legal capture may still be unsound if the target is defended.

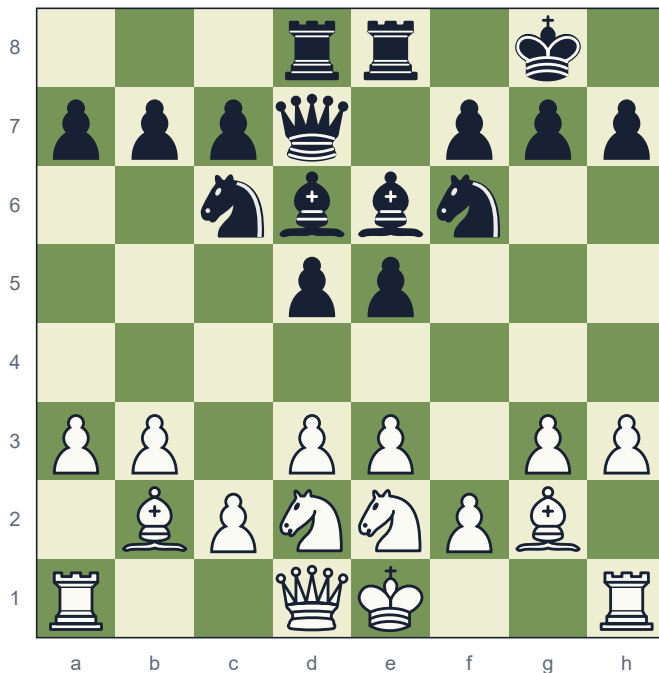
18. H4

Creates a wing or central pawn contact and changes king shelter. Calculate captures and the opponent's central counterplay before extending the advance.

REASSESS

Name the material balance, the most active piece and the next pawn break. If the center changed, explain why the original plan may need to change too.

HW-LAB-01 / decision 1



White to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

Nf3 and g4. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king e1; central-file pawns c2, f2, d3, e3. Black king g8; central-file pawns d5, e5, c7, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE NF3

11. Nf3 h6 12. d4 Bf5 13. dxe5 Nxe5 14. Nxe5 Bxe5 Search estimate: -0.95 from White's perspective.

CANDIDATE G4

11. g4 h6 12. Ng3 Ne7 13. Nf3 d4 14. g5 Nfd5 Search estimate: -1.01 from White's perspective.

EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

Develops the king knight toward e5 and d4. In the King's Gambit it also controls h4, making an immediate queen check there unattractive.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

HW-LAB-01 / decision 2



White to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

Nxc6 and Nf4. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king e1; central-file pawns c2, f2, e3, d4. Black king g8; central-file pawns e4, d5, c7, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE NXC6

15. Nxc6 bxc6 16. Nf4 Bf5 17. Qe2 Qb7 18. O-O Qc8 Search estimate: -1.15 from White's perspective.

CANDIDATE NF4

15. Nf4 Bf5 16. Nxc6 bxc6 17. Qe2 Qb7 18. Bc3 Nh7 Search estimate: -1.16 from White's perspective.

EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

The knight captures a knight on c6. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

HW-LAB-01 / decision 3



COMPARE CANDIDATES

Be2 and c4. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king e1; central-file pawns c2, f2, e3, d4. Black king g8; central-file pawns e4, d5, c6, c7, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE BE2

19. Be2 g6 Search estimate: -1.07 from White's perspective.

CANDIDATE C4

19. c4 Bg4 20. Be2 dxc4 21. Bxg4 Nxg4 22. Rc1 a5 Search estimate: -1.37 from White's perspective.

EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

Places the bishop on e2. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

HW-LAB-02 / Black grabs space with ...c5



Laboratory start - White to move

OPENING BACKGROUND

Black establishes c5-d5-e5. White must challenge the center before completing every wing pawn move.

READ THE CURRENT POSITION

White king g1; central-file pawns c2, d3, e3, f4. Black king e8; central-file pawns e4, c5, d5, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

OPENING CONCERN TO RECHECK

...d4 can close the center with a large space advantage. If every white piece lacks squares, the setup has become too slow. Decide which parts still apply after the moves already played.

BEFORE PLAYING

Write a candidate move and a reply for the opponent. Name the pawn break each side would like to achieve. The continuation on the following pages is one checked illustration, not a forced script.

HW-LAB-02 / play and explain 1

11. dxe4 dxe4 12. Nec3 Qc8 13. Kh2 h4 14. g4 Bxg4 15. hxg4 Nxg4+



Before this segment - White to move



After this segment - White to move - in check

11. DXE4

The pawn captures a pawn on e4. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

13. KH2

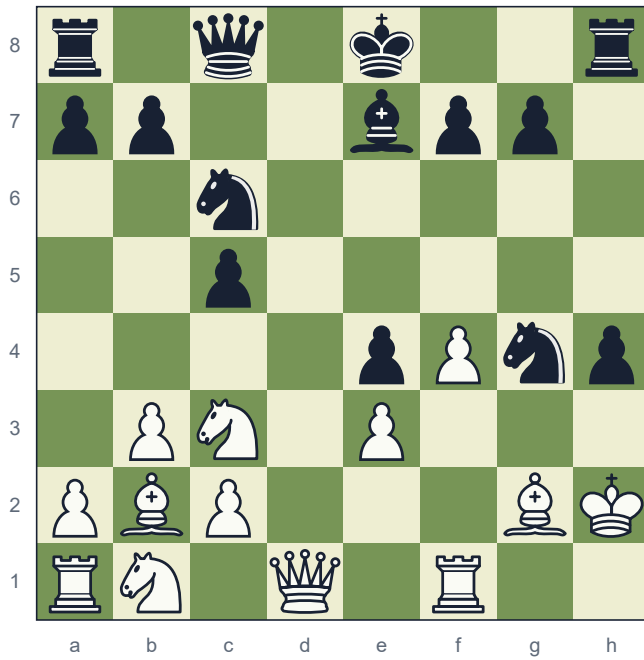
Places the king on h2. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

REASSESS

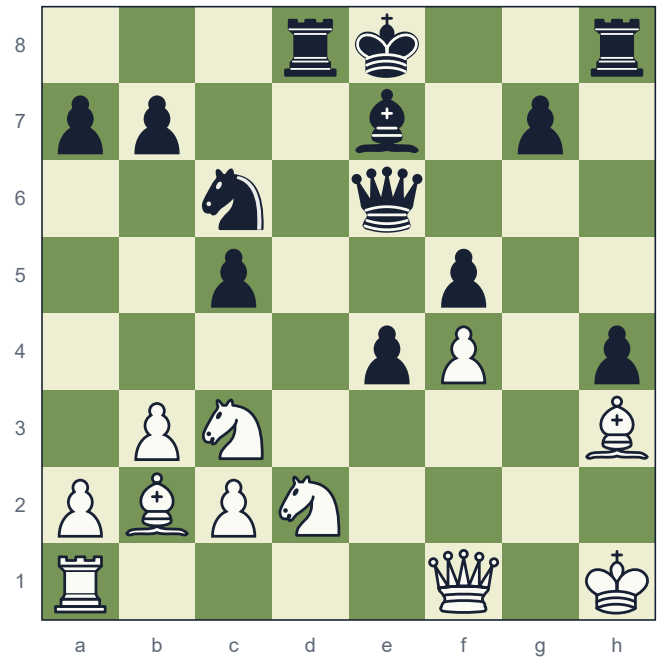
Name the material balance, the most active piece and the next pawn break. If the center changed, explain why the original plan may need to change too.

HW-LAB-02 / play and explain 2

16. Kh1 Nxe3 17. Qe2 Nxf1 18. Qxf1 f5 19. Bh3 Qe6 20. Nd2 Rd8



Before this segment - White to move - in check



After this segment - White to move

16. KH1

Places the king on h1. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

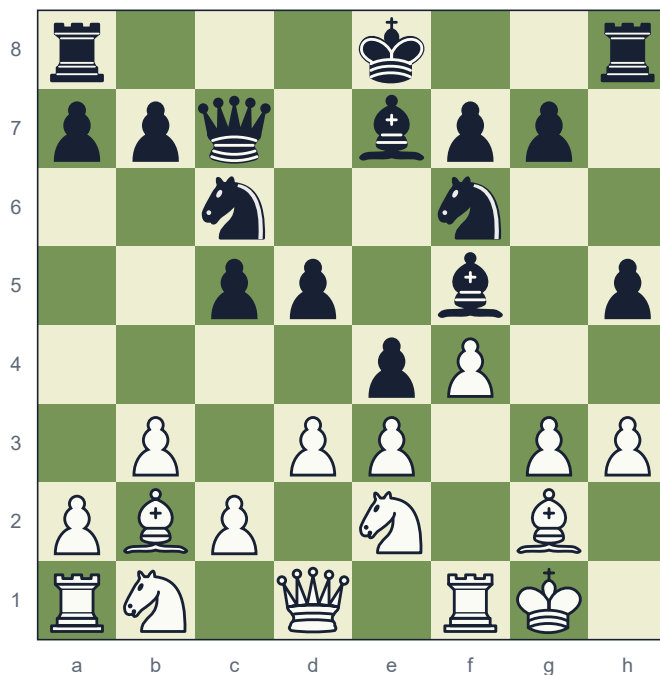
18. QXF1

The queen captures a knight on f1. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

REASSESS

Name the material balance, the most active piece and the next pawn break. If the center changed, explain why the original plan may need to change too.

HW-LAB-02 / decision 1



White to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

dxe4 and Bxf6. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king g1; central-file pawns c2, d3, e3, f4. Black king e8; central-file pawns e4, c5, d5, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE DXE4

11. dxe4 dxe4 12. Nec3 Rd8 13. Nd2 Qc8 14. Qe2 Bxh3 Search estimate: -0.60 from White's perspective.

CANDIDATE BXF6

11. Bxf6 Bxf6 Search estimate: -1.37 from White's perspective.

EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

The pawn captures a pawn on e4. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

HW-LAB-02 / decision 2



White to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

hxc4 and Qd2. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king h2; central-file pawns c2, e3, f4. Black king e8; central-file pawns e4, c5, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE HXG4

15. hxc4 Nxc4+ Search estimate: -0.39 from White's perspective.

CANDIDATE QD2

15. Qd2 Bf5 16. Nb5 O-O 17. Nd6 Bxd6 18. Bxf6 Be7 Search estimate: -1.24 from White's perspective.

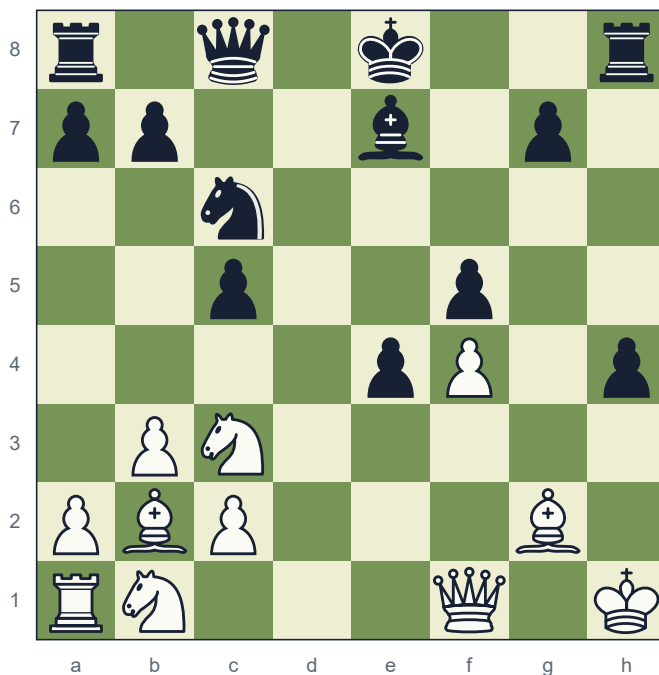
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

The pawn captures a bishop on g4. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

HW-LAB-02 / decision 3



White to move

CANDIDATE BH3

19. Bh3 Search estimate: -0.24 from White's perspective.

CANDIDATE QF2

19. Qf2 Nd4 20. Nd5 h3 21. Bf1 Qc6 22. Bxd4 Qxd5 Search estimate: -2.00 from White's perspective.

EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

Places the bishop on h3. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

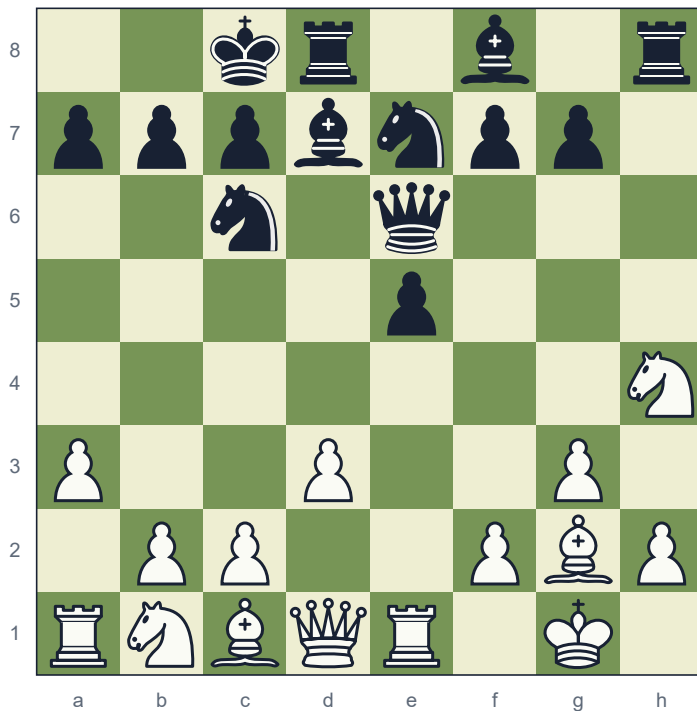
COMPARE CANDIDATES

Bh3 and Qf2. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king h1; central-file pawns c2, f4. Black king e8; central-file pawns e4, c5, f5. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

HW-LAB-03 / An immediate ...h5



Laboratory start - White to move

OPENING BACKGROUND

Black attacks the g3 pawn before building a center. Nf3 develops and can capture on h4 when Black advances without support.

READ THE CURRENT POSITION

White king g1; central-file pawns c2, f2, d3. Black king e8; central-file pawns e5, c7, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

OPENING CONCERN TO RECHECK

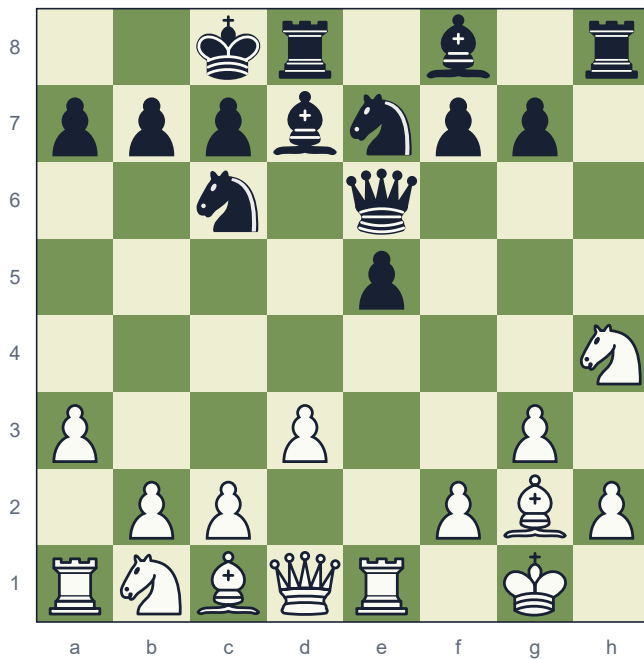
Black may strike in the center while the knight sits on the rim. Do not keep chasing pawns instead of developing. Decide which parts still apply after the moves already played.

BEFORE PLAYING

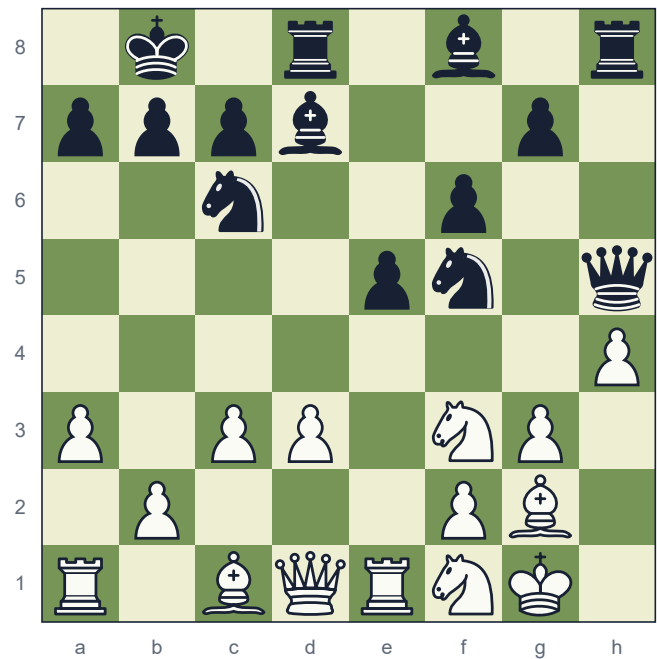
Write a candidate move and a reply for the opponent. Name the pawn break each side would like to achieve. The continuation on the following pages is one checked illustration, not a forced script.

HW-LAB-03 / play and explain 1

11. Nf3 Qf5 12. h4 Qh5 13. Nbd2 f6 14. Nf1 Nf5 15. c3 Kb8



Before this segment - White to move



After this segment - White to move

11. NF3

Develops the king knight toward e5 and d4. In the King's Gambit it also controls h4, making an immediate queen check there unattractive.

13. NBD2

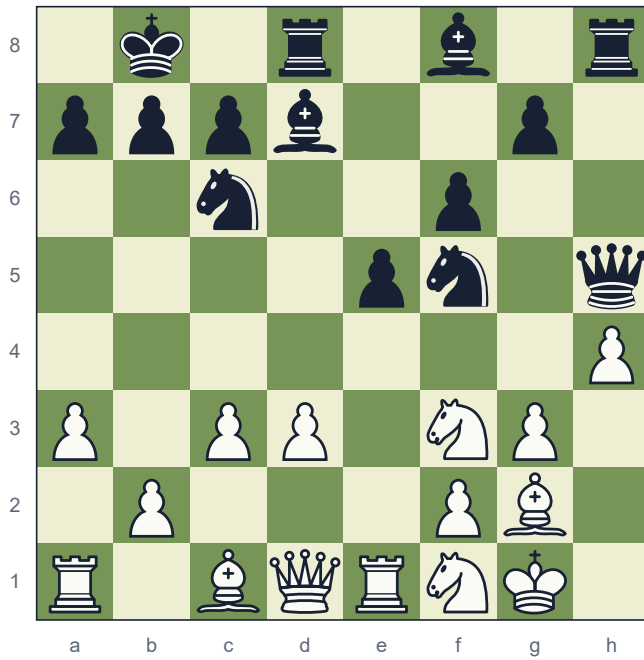
Develops the queen knight while leaving the c-pawn free. The knight supports e4 and may seek c4 or a route through f1.

REASSESS

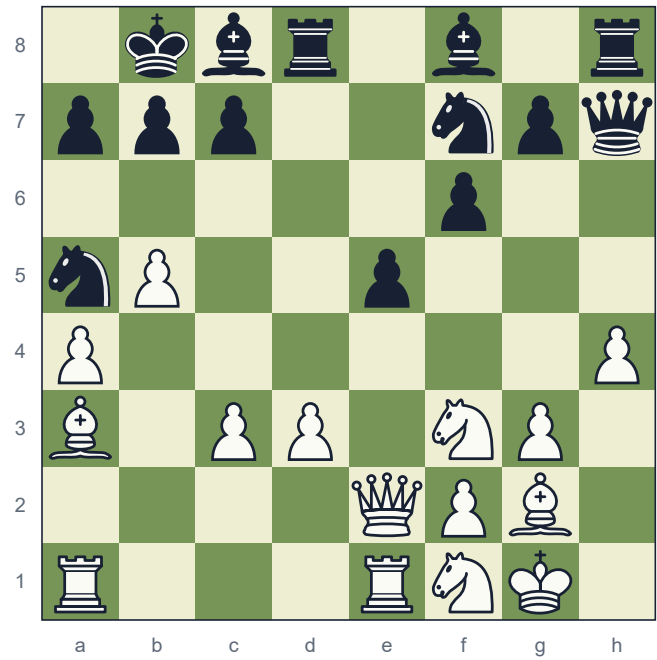
Name the material balance, the most active piece and the next pawn break. If the center changed, explain why the original plan may need to change too.

HW-LAB-03 / play and explain 2

16. b4 Nd6 17. a4 Bc8 18. Ba3 Qh7 19. b5 Na5 20. Qe2 Nf7



Before this segment - White to move



After this segment - White to move

16. B4

Places the pawn on b4. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

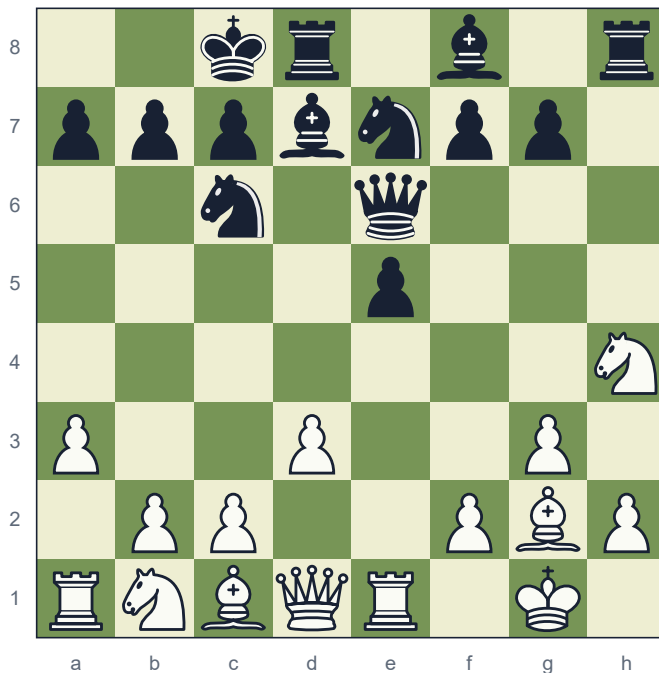
18. BA3

Places the bishop on a3. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

REASSESS

Name the material balance, the most active piece and the next pawn break. If the center changed, explain why the original plan may need to change too.

HW-LAB-03 / decision 1



White to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

Nf3 and b4. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king g1; central-file pawns c2, f2, d3. Black king c8; central-file pawns e5, c7, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE NF3

11. Nf3 Qf5 Search estimate: +0.68 from White's perspective.

CANDIDATE B4

11. b4 Rxh4 12. gxh4 Nf5 13. Re4 Nd6 14. Re1 Search estimate: +0.00 from White's perspective.

EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

Develops the king knight toward e5 and d4. In the King's Gambit it also controls h4, making an immediate queen check there unattractive.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

HW-LAB-03 / decision 2



COMPARE CANDIDATES

c3 and b4. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king g1; central-file pawns c2, f2, d3. Black king c8; central-file pawns e5, f6, c7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE C3

15. c3 Kb8 16. b4 Nd6 17. c4 Bf5 18. Ne3 Bc8 Search estimate: +1.09 from White's perspective.

CANDIDATE B4

15. b4 Ncd4 16. Be3 Nxf3+ 17. Qxf3 Qxf3 18. Bxf3 g6 Search estimate: +0.91 from White's perspective.

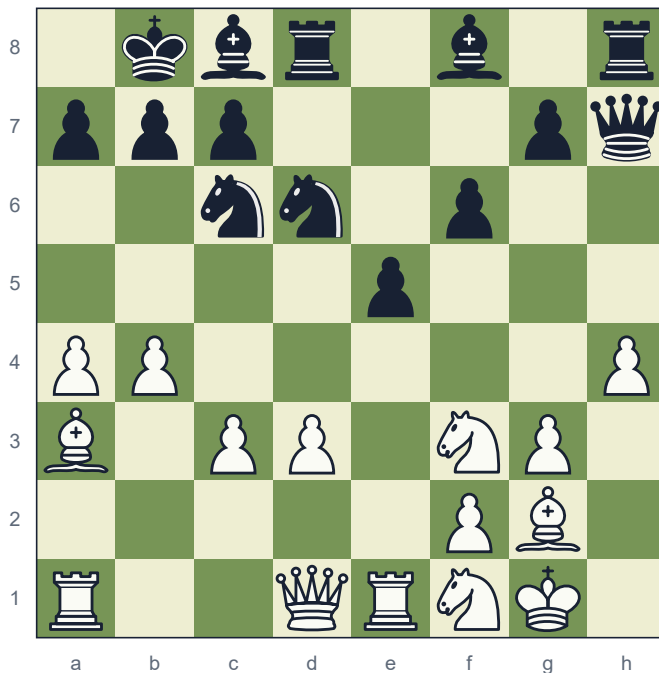
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

Places the pawn on c3. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

HW-LAB-03 / decision 3



White to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

b5 and Qe2. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king g1; central-file pawns f2, c3, d3. Black king b8; central-file pawns e5, f6, c7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE B5

19. b5 Search estimate: +1.06 from White's perspective.

CANDIDATE QE2

19. Qe2 Nf7 20. b5 Na5 21. Bxf8 Rdx8 22. d4 g5 Search estimate: +0.99 from White's perspective.

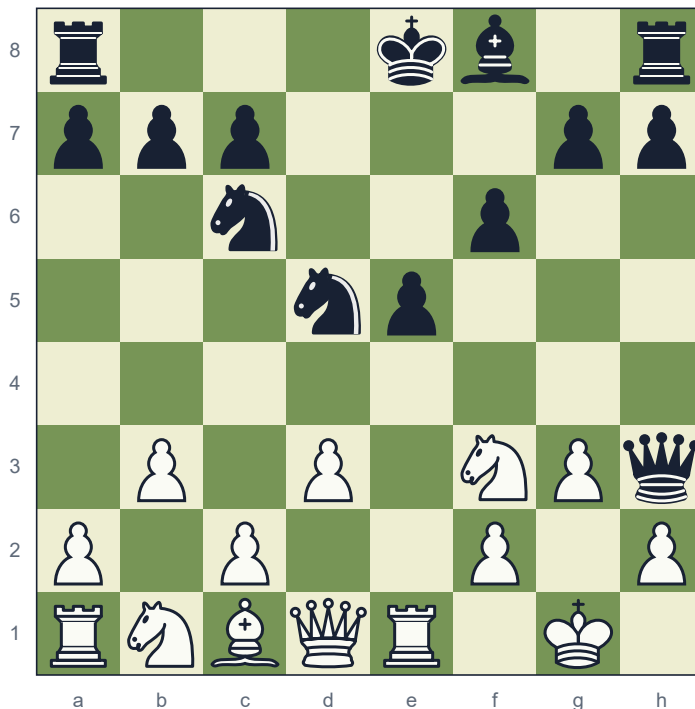
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

Places the pawn on b5, attacking knight on c6. A legal capture may still be unsound if the target is defended.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

HW-LAB-04 / An early ...Bh3 attempt



Laboratory start - White to move

OPENING BACKGROUND

Black exchanges the g2 bishop and brings the queen toward White's already castled king. White's knight has left g1, so the queen on h3 cannot simply be captured by that knight.

READ THE CURRENT POSITION

White king g1; central-file pawns c2, f2, d3. Black king e8; central-file pawns e5, f6, c7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

OPENING CONCERN TO RECHECK

If White's knight were still on g1, ...Qxh3 would lose the queen to Nxh3. In this line its different square makes the attack a real concern. Decide which parts still apply after the moves already played.

BEFORE PLAYING

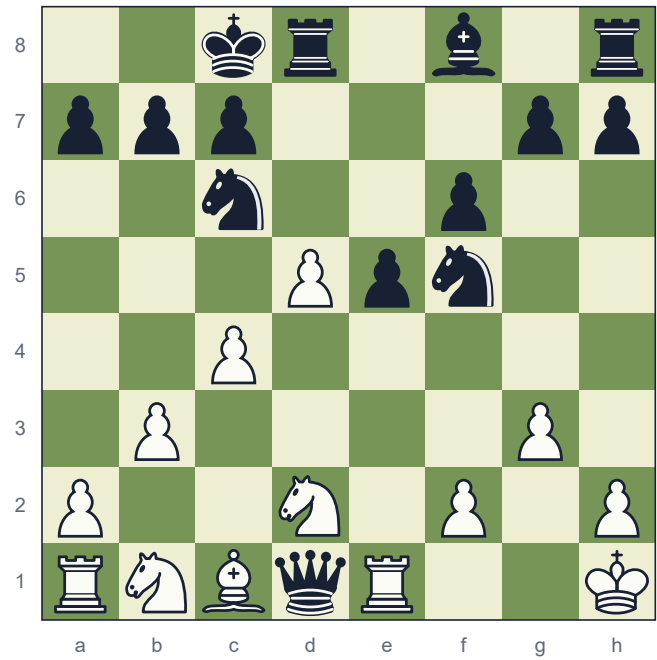
Write a candidate move and a reply for the opponent. Name the pawn break each side would like to achieve. The continuation on the following pages is one checked illustration, not a forced script.

HW-LAB-04 / play and explain 1

11. d4 O-O-O 12. c4 Nde7 13. d5 Nf5 14. Kh1 Qg4 15. Nfd2 Qxd1



Before this segment - White to move



After this segment - White to move

11. D4

Changes central space and pawn contacts. Calculate captures, advances and maintaining tension before choosing the next piece plan.

13. D5

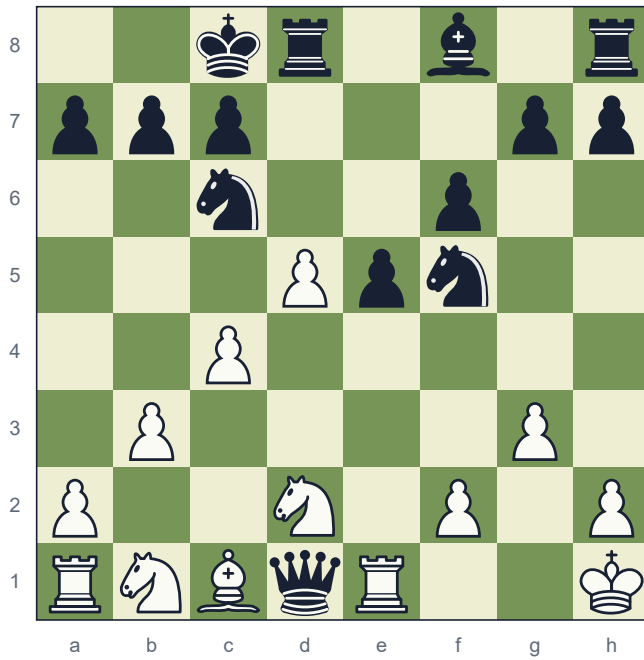
Places the pawn on d5, attacking knight on c6. A legal capture may still be unsound if the target is defended.

REASSESS

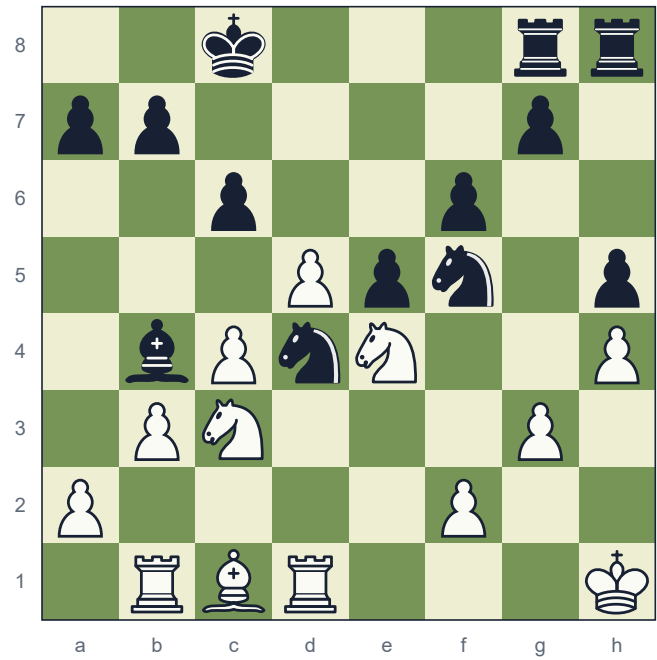
Name the material balance, the most active piece and the next pawn break. If the center changed, explain why the original plan may need to change too.

HW-LAB-04 / play and explain 2

16. Rxd1 Ncd4 17. Nc3 h5 18. Nde4 c6 19. Rb1 Bb4 20. h4 Rdg8



Before this segment - White to move



After this segment - White to move

16. RxD1

The rook captures a queen on d1. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

18. NDE4

Places the knight on e4. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

REASSESS

Name the material balance, the most active piece and the next pawn break. If the center changed, explain why the original plan may need to change too.

HW-LAB-04 / decision 1



COMPARE CANDIDATES

d4 and c4. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king g1; central-file pawns c2, f2, d3. Black king e8; central-file pawns e5, f6, c7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE D4

11. d4 Search estimate: -0.66 from White's perspective.

CANDIDATE C4

11. c4 Nde7 12. b4 Nf5 13. b5 Ncd4 14. Nxd4 Nxd4 Search estimate: -1.17 from White's perspective.

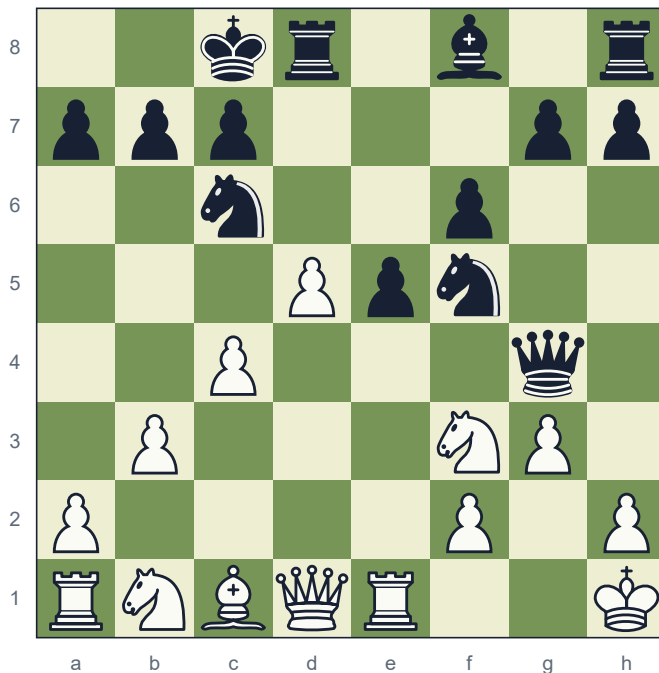
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

Changes central space and pawn contacts. Calculate captures, advances and maintaining tension before choosing the next piece plan.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

HW-LAB-04 / decision 2



White to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

Nfd2 and Nbd2. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king h1; central-file pawns f2, c4, d5. Black king c8; central-file pawns e5, f6, c7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE NFD2

15. Nfd2 Qxd1 16. Rxd1 Ncd4 17. Nc3 Be7 18. Rb1 h5 Search estimate: -0.38 from White's perspective.

CANDIDATE NBD2

15. Nbd2 Ncd4 Search estimate: -0.44 from White's perspective.

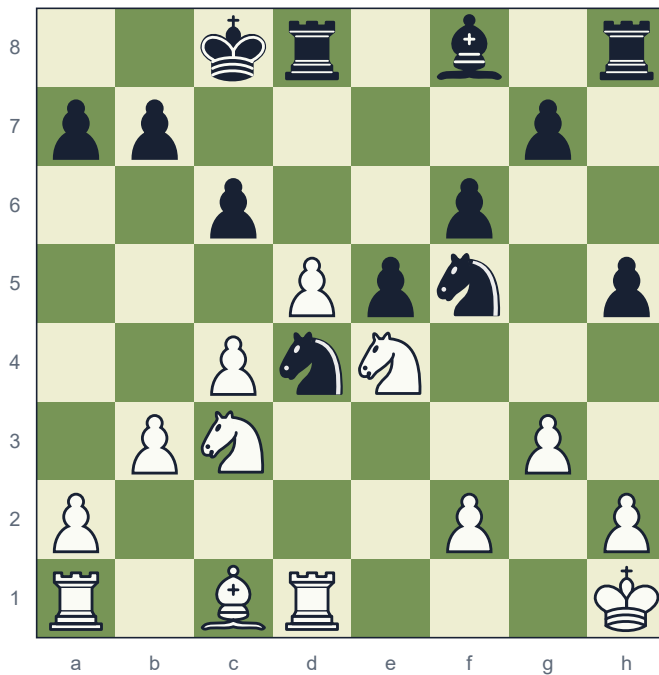
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

Places the knight on d2. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

HW-LAB-04 / decision 3



White to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

Rb1 and h4. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king h1; central-file pawns f2, c4, d5. Black king c8; central-file pawns e5, c6, f6. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE RB1

19. Rb1 Bb4 Search estimate: -0.28 from White's perspective.

CANDIDATE H4

19. h4 Bb4 20. Kg2 Bxc3 21. Nxc3 cxd5 22. Nxd5 Nc2 Search estimate: -0.26 from White's perspective.

EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

Places the rook on b1. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

HW-LAB-05 / Choose c4 before the complete shell



Laboratory start - White to move

OPENING BACKGROUND

White challenges d5 with active development and a castled king. This useful departure resembles a Reti or reversed King's Indian structure more than a complete Hippo.

READ THE CURRENT POSITION

White king g1; central-file pawns e2, f2, d3. Black king g8; central-file pawns e5, c7, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

OPENING CONCERN TO RECHECK

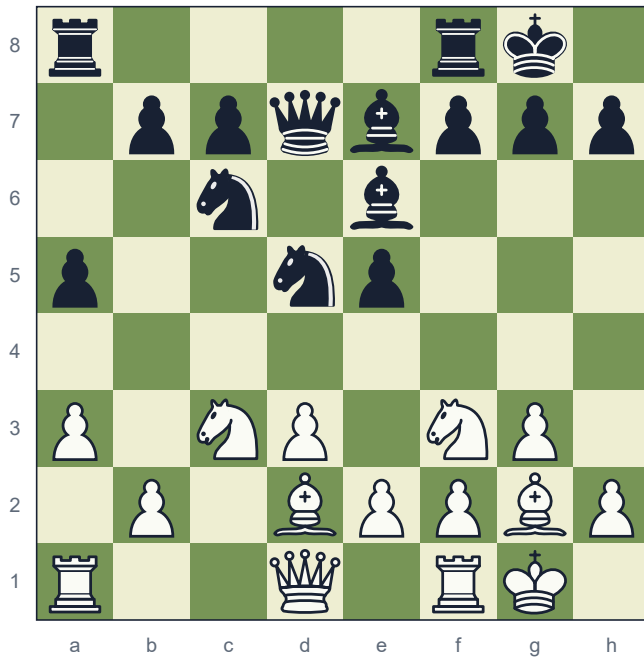
If Black closes with ...d4, Nc3 may be restricted. Plan the knight route before fixing every pawn. Decide which parts still apply after the moves already played.

BEFORE PLAYING

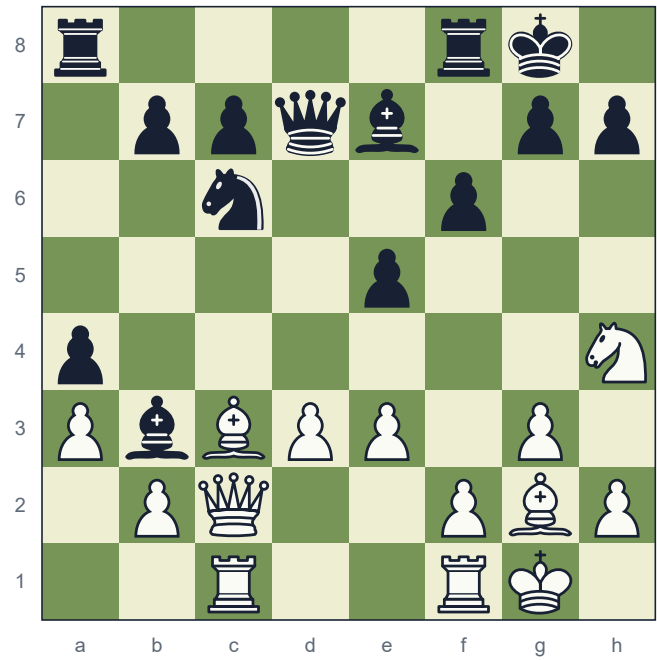
Write a candidate move and a reply for the opponent. Name the pawn break each side would like to achieve. The continuation on the following pages is one checked illustration, not a forced script.

HW-LAB-05 / play and explain 1

11. Rc1 Nxc3 12. Bxc3 f6 13. Qc2 a4 14. e3 Bd5 15. Nh4 Bb3



Before this segment - White to move



After this segment - White to move

11. RC1

Places the rook on c1. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

13. QC2

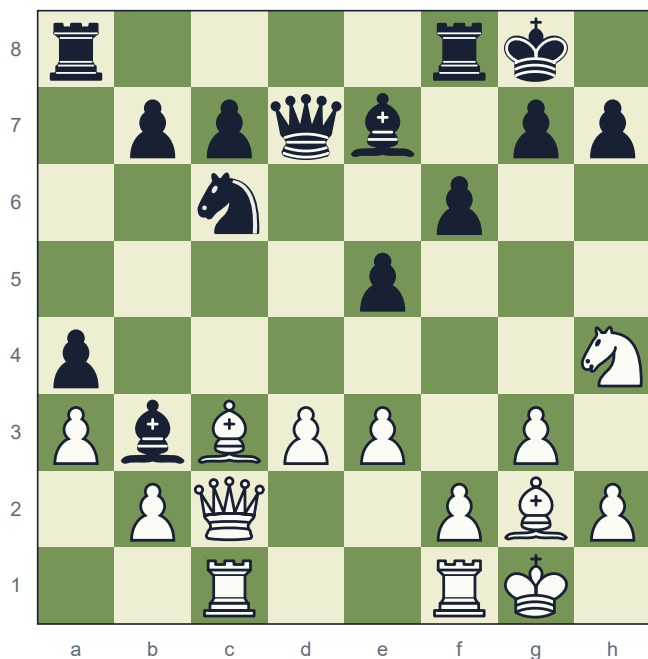
Places the queen on c2. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

REASSESS

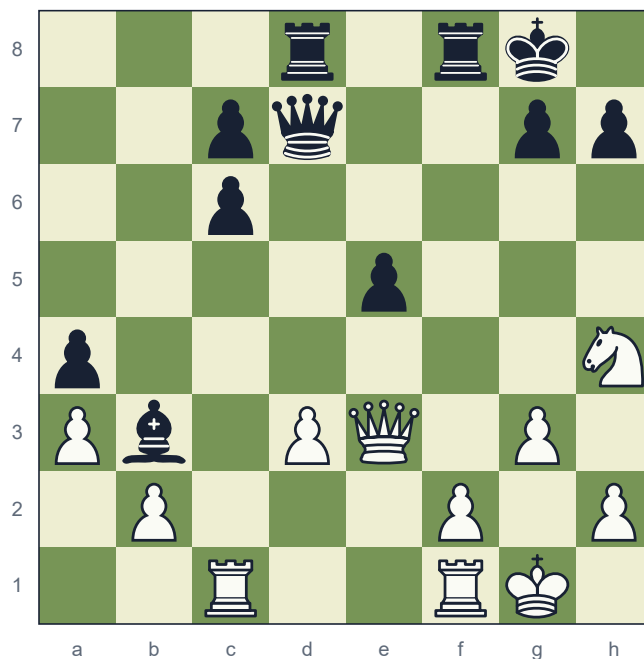
Name the material balance, the most active piece and the next pawn break. If the center changed, explain why the original plan may need to change too.

HW-LAB-05 / play and explain 2

16. Qe2 Rad8 17. Be4 Bc5 18. Bxe5 Bxe3 19. Bxc6 bxc6 20. Qxe3 fxe5



Before this segment - White to move



After this segment - White to move

16. QE2

Places the queen on e2. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

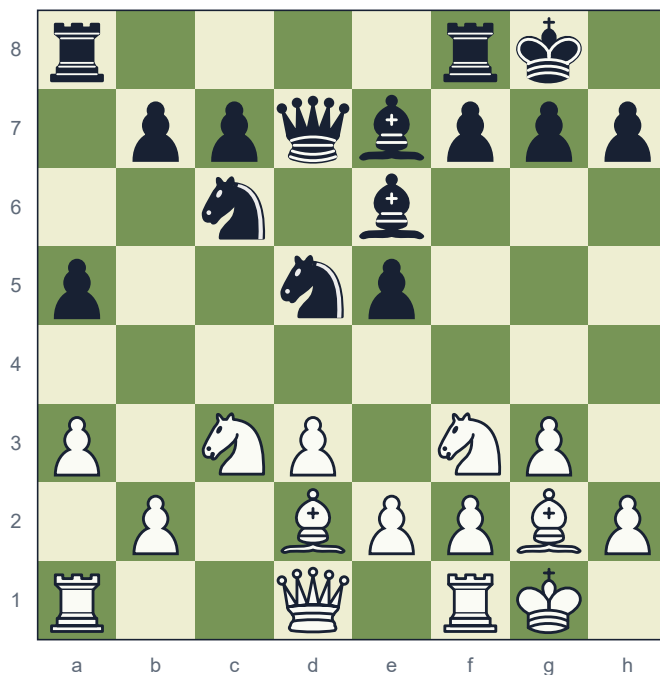
18. BXE5

The bishop captures a pawn on e5. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

REASSESS

Name the material balance, the most active piece and the next pawn break. If the center changed, explain why the original plan may need to change too.

HW-LAB-05 / decision 1



White to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

Rc1 and Re1. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king g1; central-file pawns e2, f2, d3. Black king g8; central-file pawns e5, c7, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE RC1

11. Rc1 Search estimate: -0.08 from White's perspective.

CANDIDATE RE1

11. Re1 Nxc3 12. Bxc3 f6 13. Qa4 Rfd8 14. Nd2 Nd4 Search estimate: -0.08 from White's perspective.

EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

Places the rook on c1. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

HW-LAB-05 / decision 2



COMPARE CANDIDATES

Nh4 and Rfe1. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king g1; central-file pawns f2, d3, e3. Black king g8; central-file pawns e5, f6, c7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE NH4

15. Nh4 Bb3 Search estimate: -0.10 from White's perspective.

CANDIDATE RFE1

15. Rfe1 Nd8 16. Nh4 Bxg2 17. Kxg2 g5 18. Nf3 g4 Search estimate: -0.16 from White's perspective.

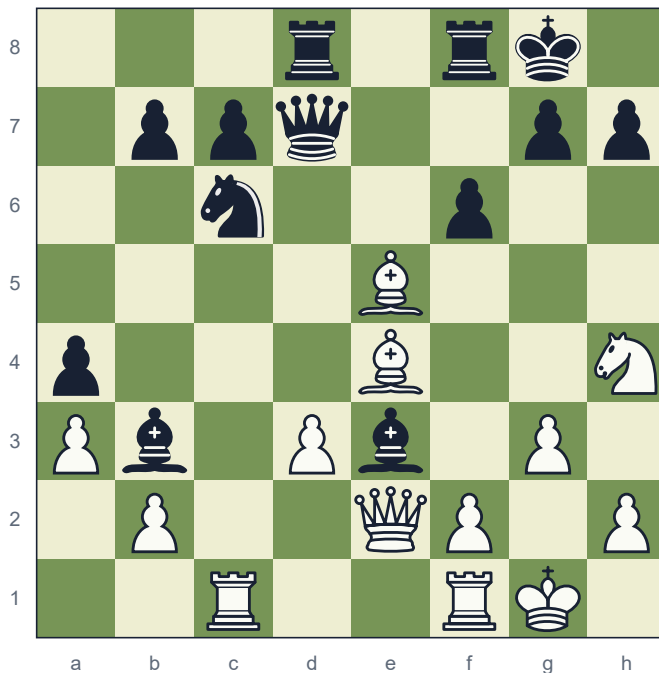
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

Places the knight on h4. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

HW-LAB-05 / decision 3



COMPARE CANDIDATES

Bxc6 and fxe3. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king g1; central-file pawns f2, d3. Black king g8; central-file pawns f6, c7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE BXC6

19. Bxc6 bxc6 Search estimate: +0.04 from White's perspective.

CANDIDATE FXE3

19. fxe3 Nxe5 20. d4 Nf7 21. Qd3 Ng5 22. Bxb7 c5 Search estimate: -0.24 from White's perspective.

EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

The bishop captures a knight on c6. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

HW-LAB-06 / Choose e4 for a KIA transition



Laboratory start - White to move

OPENING BACKGROUND

White adopts a King's Indian Attack center because Black's structure makes it useful. The b-pawn remains flexible instead of being committed automatically.

READ THE CURRENT POSITION

White king g1; central-file pawns f2, c3, d3, e4. Black king g8; central-file pawns c5, d5, e6, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

OPENING CONCERN TO RECHECK

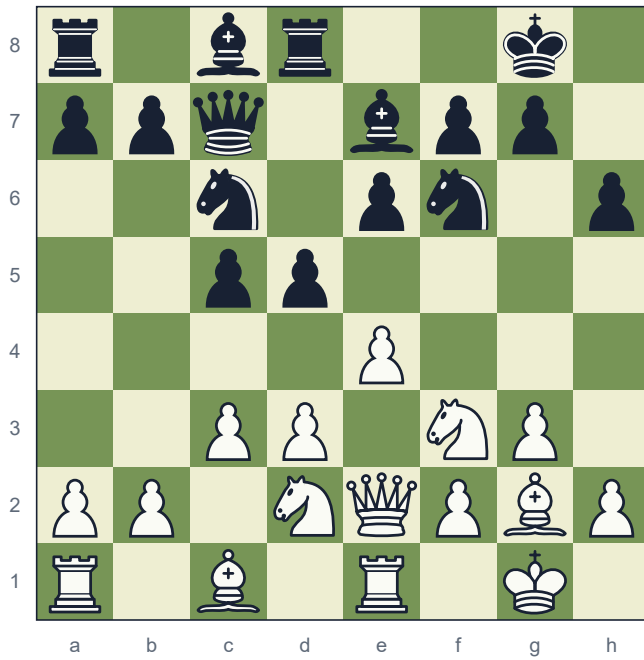
Black can exchange on e4 or advance ...d4. Do not assume the e5 attack is available in every branch. Decide which parts still apply after the moves already played.

BEFORE PLAYING

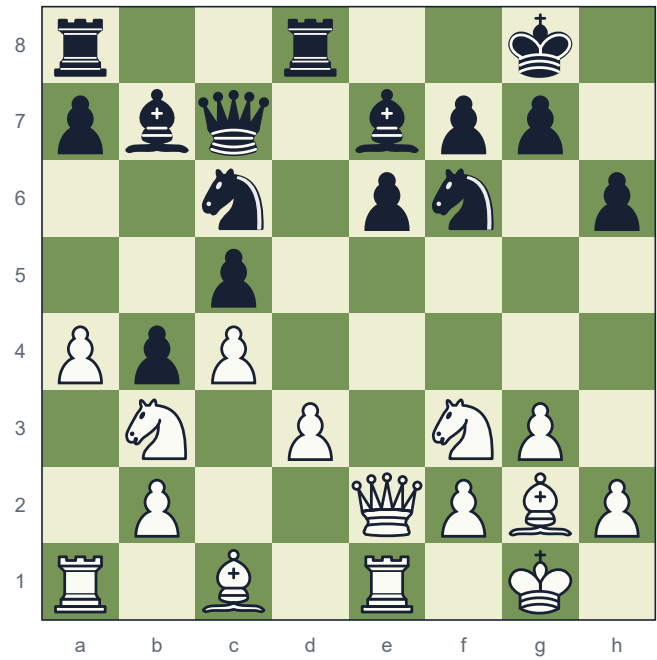
Write a candidate move and a reply for the opponent. Name the pawn break each side would like to achieve. The continuation on the following pages is one checked illustration, not a forced script.

HW-LAB-06 / play and explain 1

11. a3 b5 12. exd5 Nxd5 13. a4 b4 14. c4 Nf6 15. Nb3 Bb7



Before this segment - White to move



After this segment - White to move

11. A3

Controls nearby wing squares and may restrain a piece or pawn. Compare this useful purpose with the time lost to central development.

13. A4

Places the pawn on a4. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

REASSESS

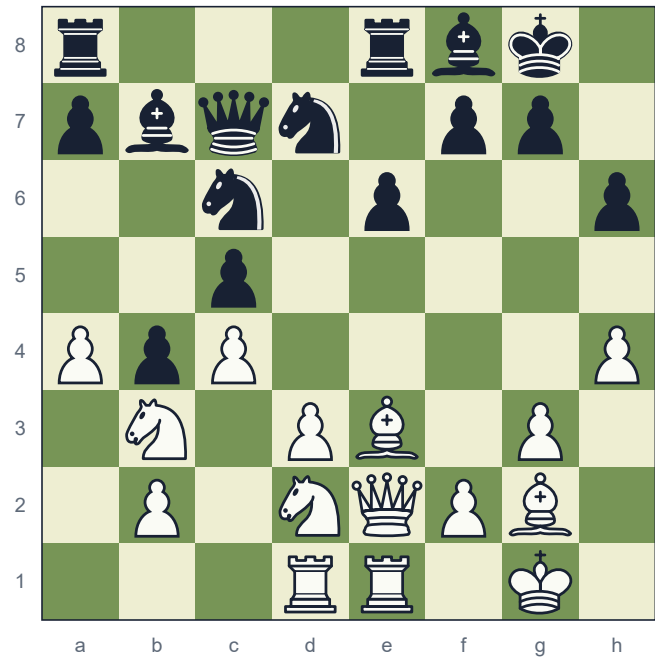
Name the material balance, the most active piece and the next pawn break. If the center changed, explain why the original plan may need to change too.

HW-LAB-06 / play and explain 2

16. Bf4 Qc8 17. Rad1 Re8 18. h4 Bf8 19. Be3 Nd7 20. Nfd2 Qc7



Before this segment - White to move



After this segment - White to move

16. Bf4

Places the bishop on f4, attacking queen on c7. A legal capture may still be unsound if the target is defended.

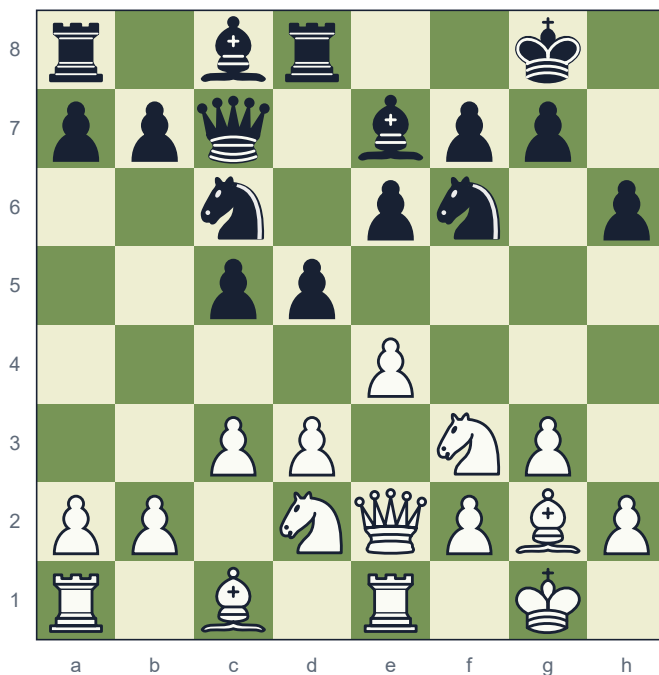
18. H4

Creates a wing or central pawn contact and changes king shelter. Calculate captures and the opponent's central counterplay before extending the advance.

REASSESS

Name the material balance, the most active piece and the next pawn break. If the center changed, explain why the original plan may need to change too.

HW-LAB-06 / decision 1



White to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

a3 and a4. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king g1; central-file pawns f2, c3, d3, e4. Black king g8; central-file pawns c5, d5, e6, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE A3

11. a3 b5 12. exd5 exd5 13. d4 c4 14. Ne5 Re8 Search estimate: +0.10 from White's perspective.

CANDIDATE A4

11. a4 Rb8 Search estimate: +0.03 from White's perspective.

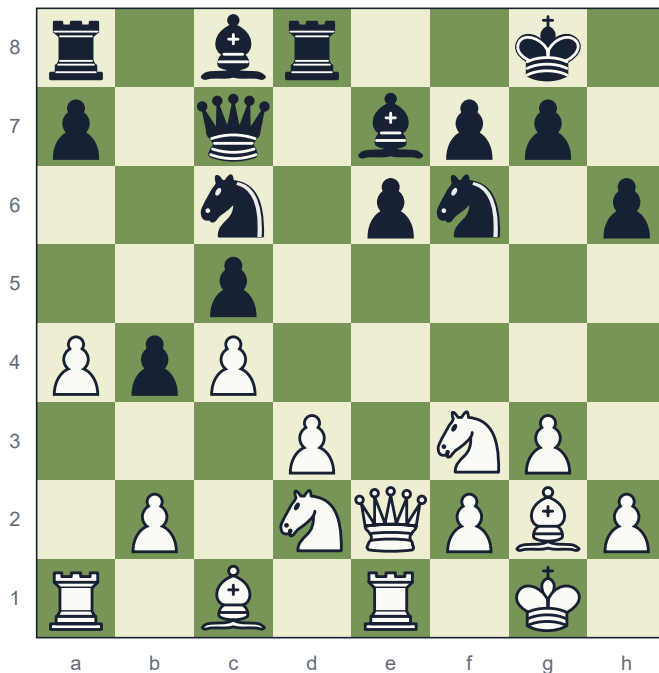
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

Controls nearby wing squares and may restrain a piece or pawn. Compare this useful purpose with the time lost to central development.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

HW-LAB-06 / decision 2



White to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

Nb3 and a5. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king g1; central-file pawns f2, d3, c4. Black king g8; central-file pawns c5, e6, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE NB3

15. Nb3 Bb7 16. Bf4 Qc8 17. a5 a6 18. Rad1 Bf8 Search estimate: +0.18 from White's perspective.

CANDIDATE A5

15. a5 Nxa5 Search estimate: +0.04 from White's perspective.

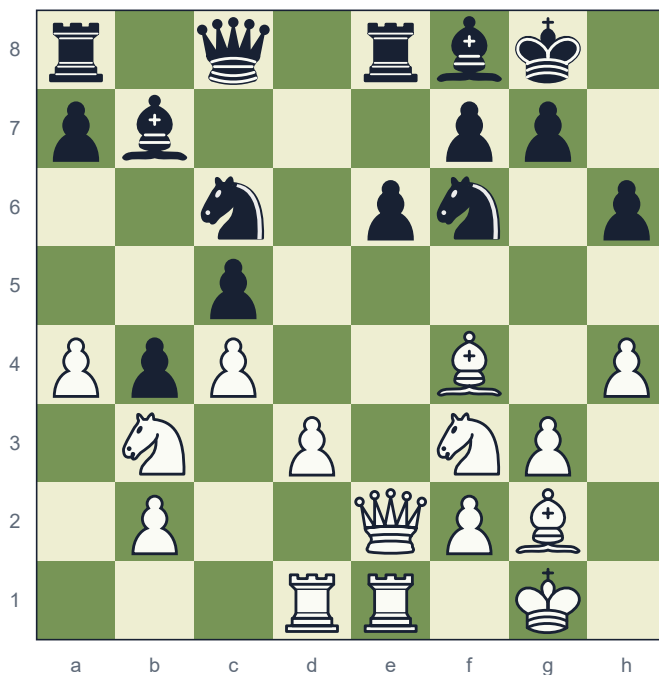
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

Places the knight on b3. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

HW-LAB-06 / decision 3



White to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

Be3 and d4. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king g1; central-file pawns f2, d3, c4. Black king g8; central-file pawns c5, e6, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE BE3

19. Be3 Nd7 20. Nfd2 f5 21. Nf3 a5 22. h5 Nd8 Search estimate: +0.06 from White's perspective.

CANDIDATE D4

19. d4 cxd4 Search estimate: -0.04 from White's perspective.

EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

Places the bishop on e3. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

48 exercises / instructions

THREE KINDS OF QUESTION

Questions 1-24 test opening recall, 25-36 test plans and defense, and 37-48 compare concrete candidates from the laboratories. These are not all tactical puzzles and do not all have one uniquely best move.

WORK WITHOUT THE ANSWER

Use a board and write your answer. Spend two to five minutes on a recall question and five to ten on a candidate comparison. Name the opponent's threat before choosing your own move.

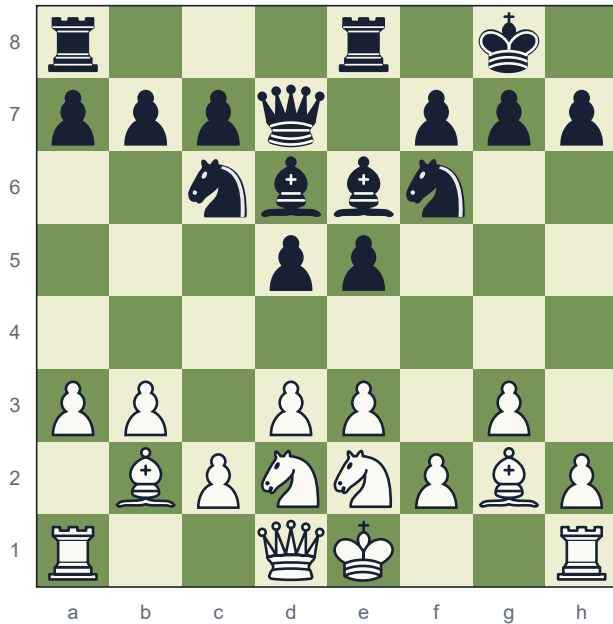
MARKING

Award one point for a legal, relevant choice or plan; one for a clear reason; one for recognizing the opponent's resource; and one for a supporting variation or accurate description of the structure. Maximum: 192. Do not reward memorized notation that you cannot explain.

ANSWERS ARE LATER

The question pages come first, followed by explained answers and sample continuations. In planning questions the sample answer is a guide, not an exhaustive list of reasonable plans.

Exercises 1-2



White to move

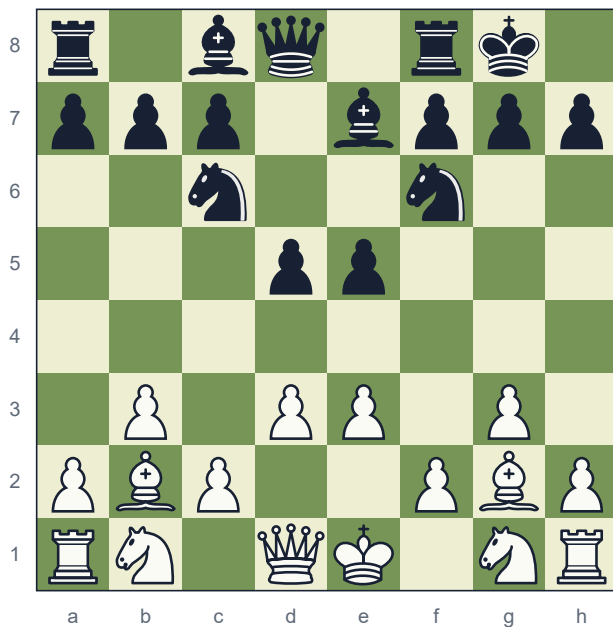
01 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

02 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 3-4



White to move

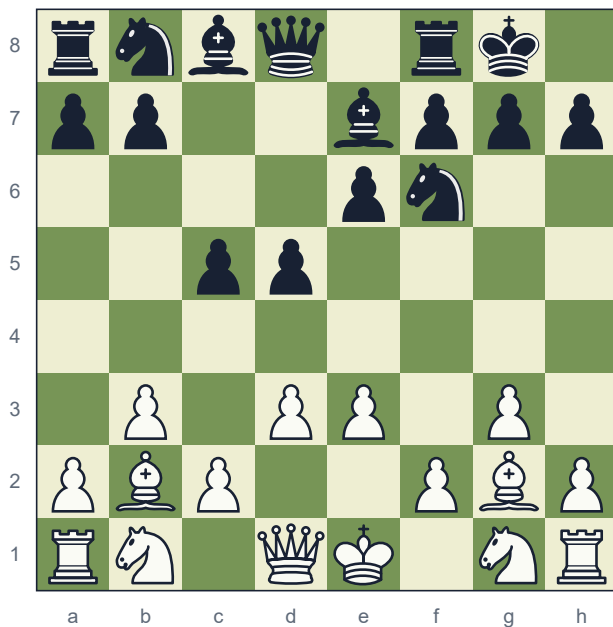
03 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

04 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 5-6



White to move

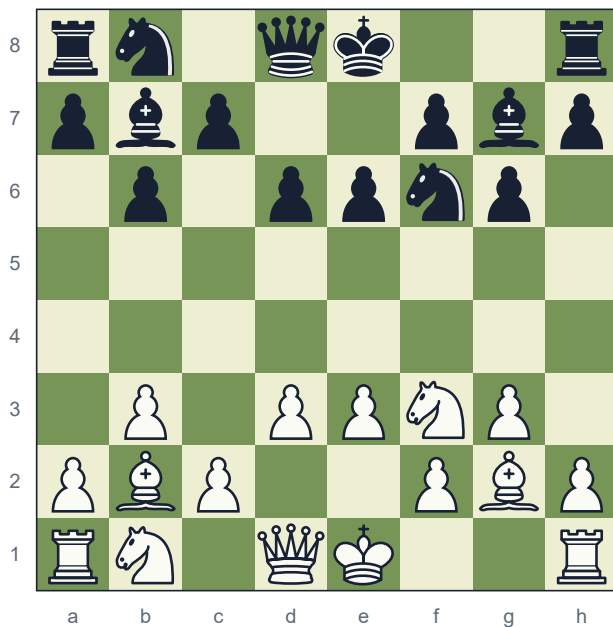
05 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

06 / OPENING RECALL

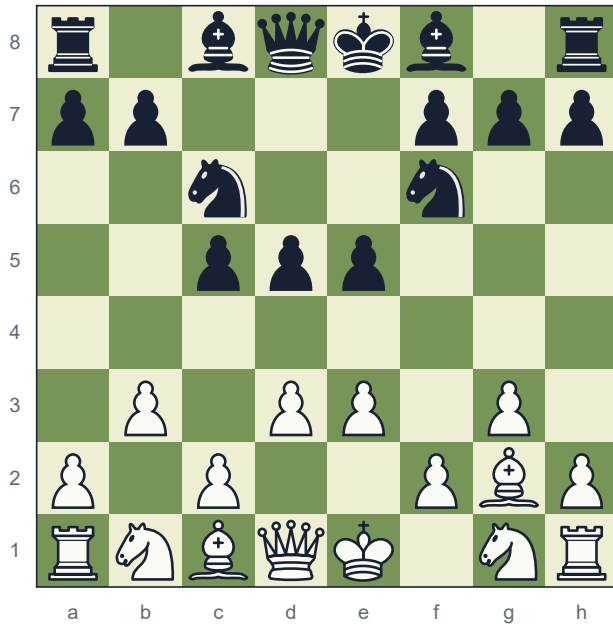
Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 7-8



White to move

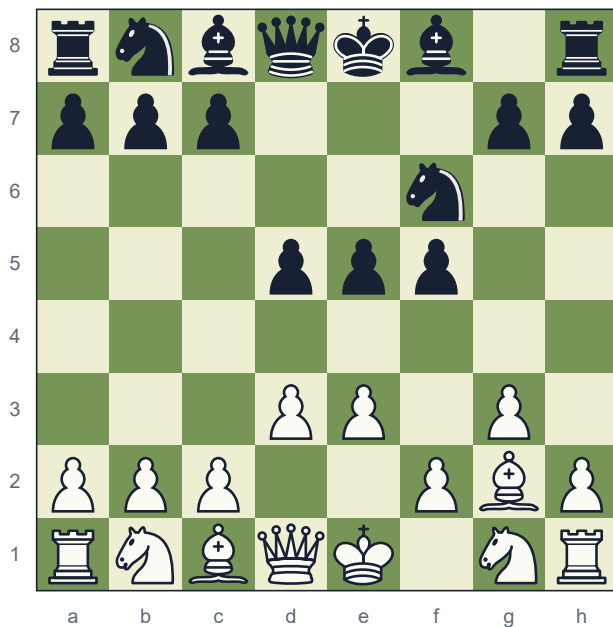
07 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

08 / OPENING RECALL

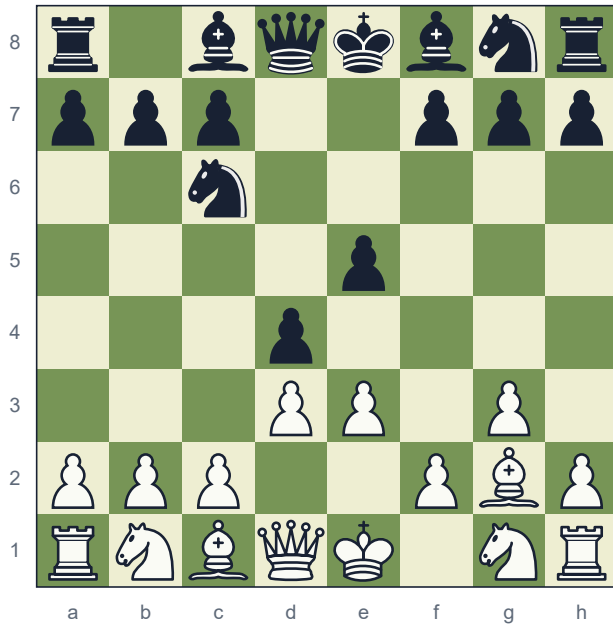
Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 9-10



White to move

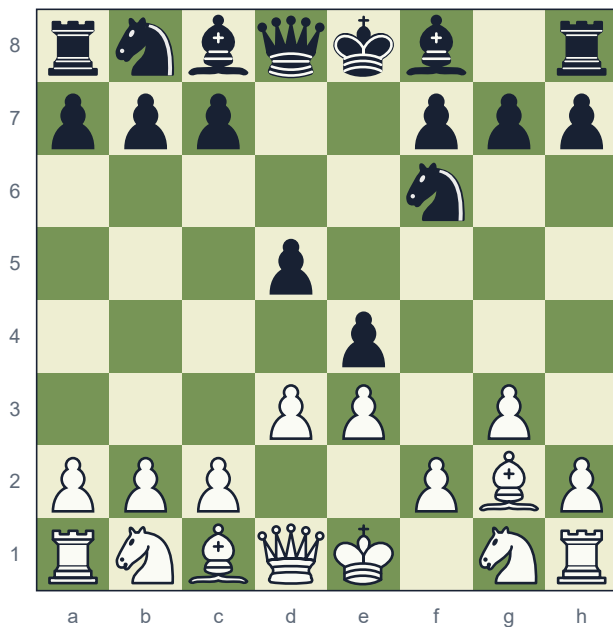
09 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

10 / OPENING RECALL

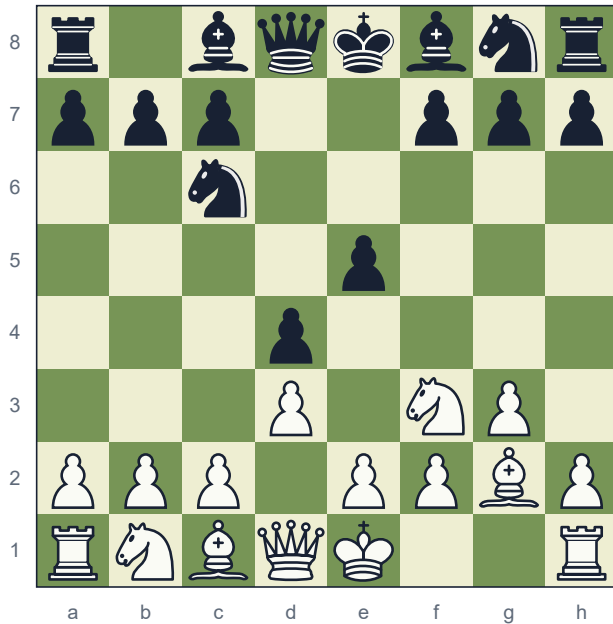
Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 11-12



White to move

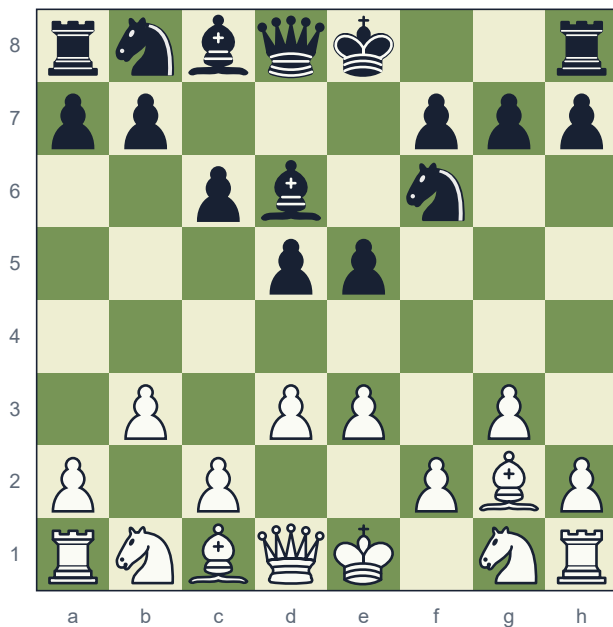
11 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

12 / OPENING RECALL

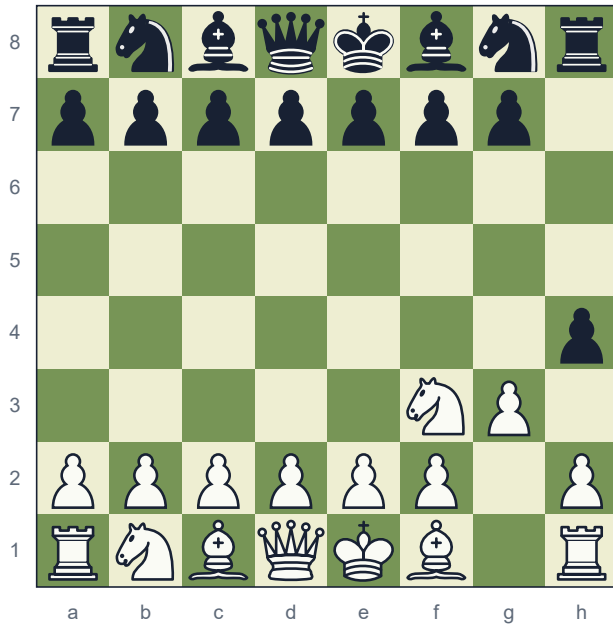
Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 13-14



White to move

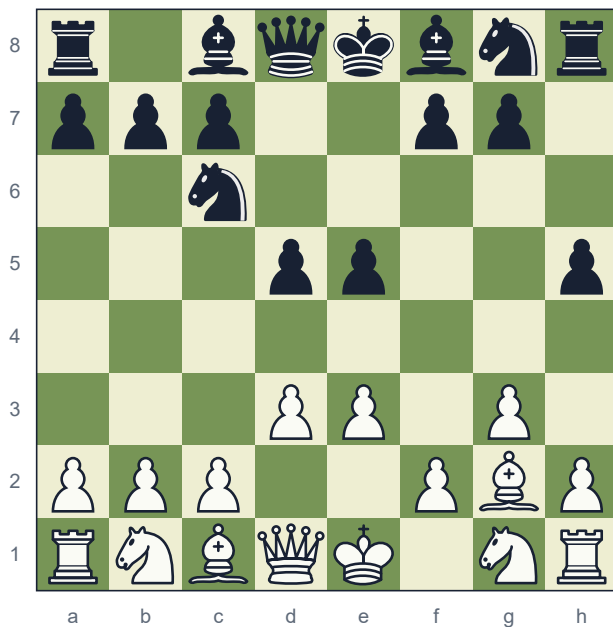
13 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

14 / OPENING RECALL

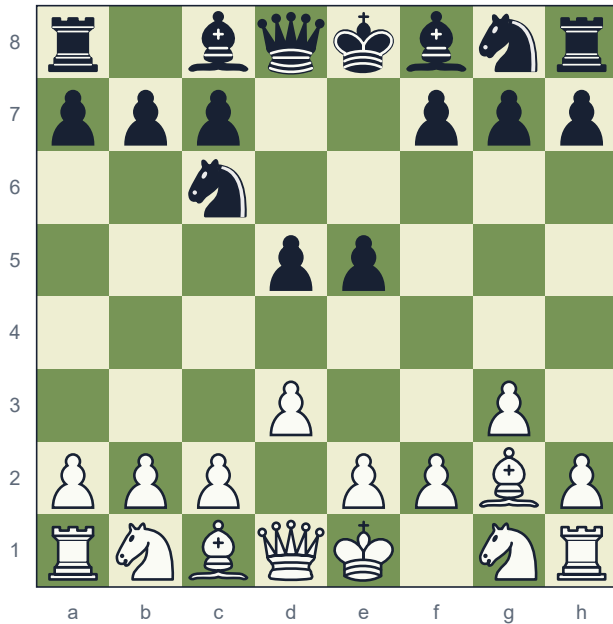
Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 15-16



White to move

15 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

16 / OPENING RECALL

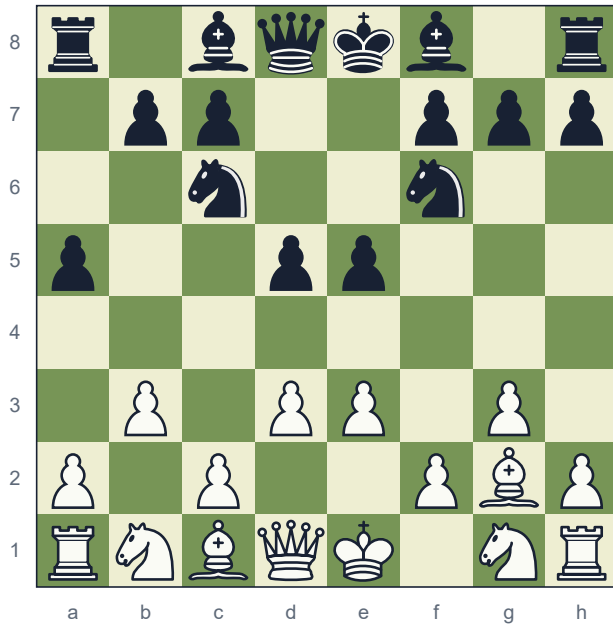
Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 17-18



White to move

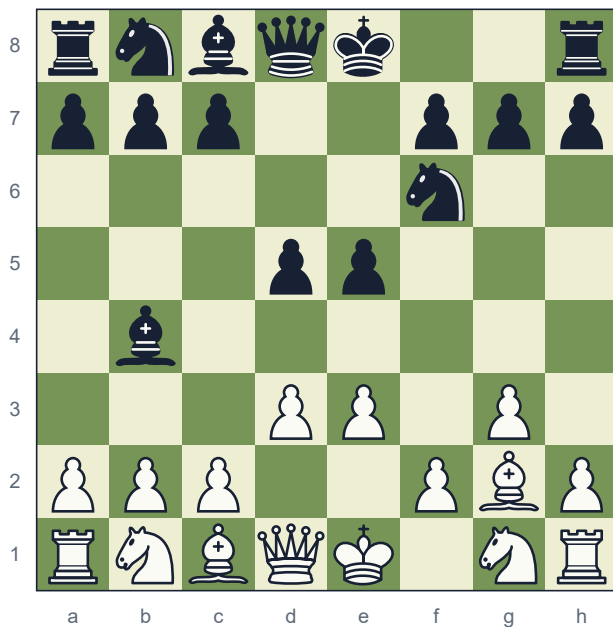
17 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move - in check

18 / OPENING RECALL

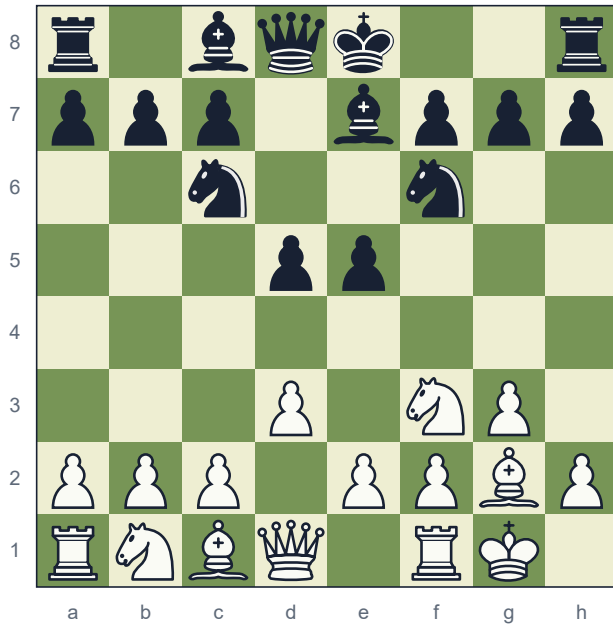
Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 19-20



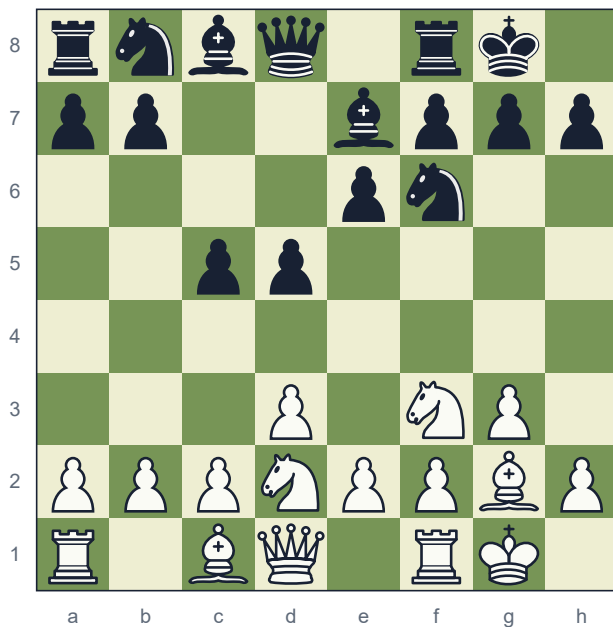
19 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



20 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 21-22



White to move

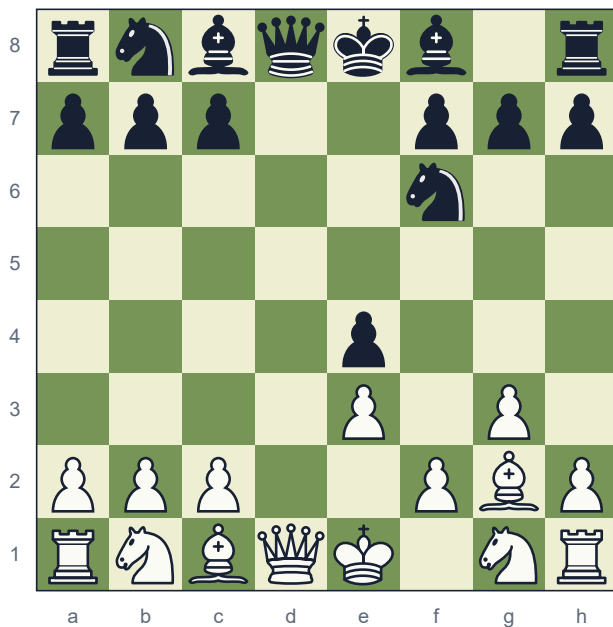
21 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

22 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 23-24



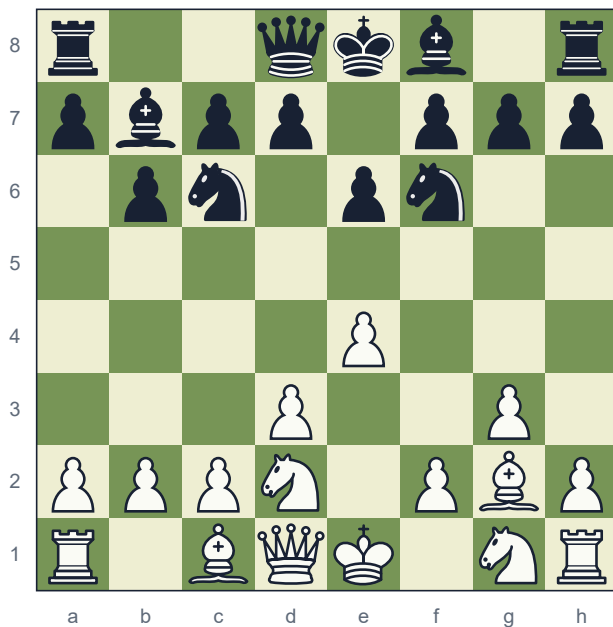
23 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



24 / OPENING RECALL

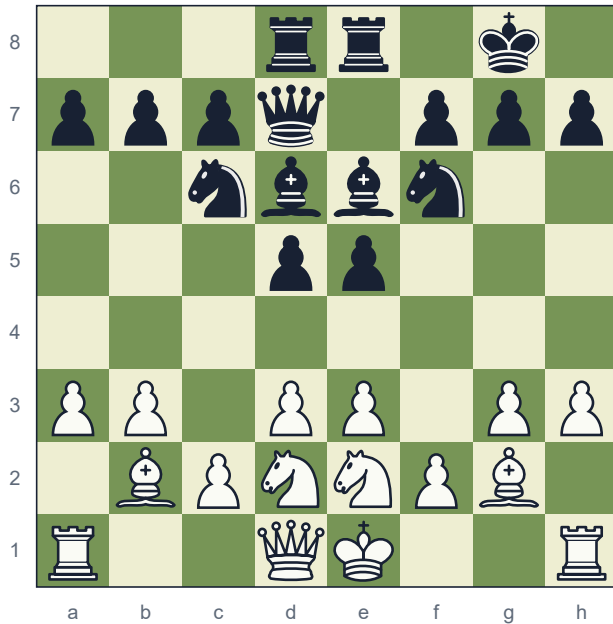
Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 25-26



White to move

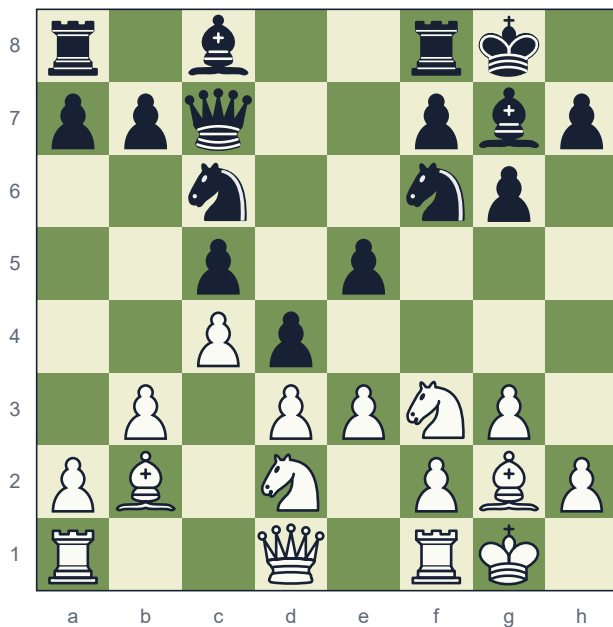
25 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

26 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

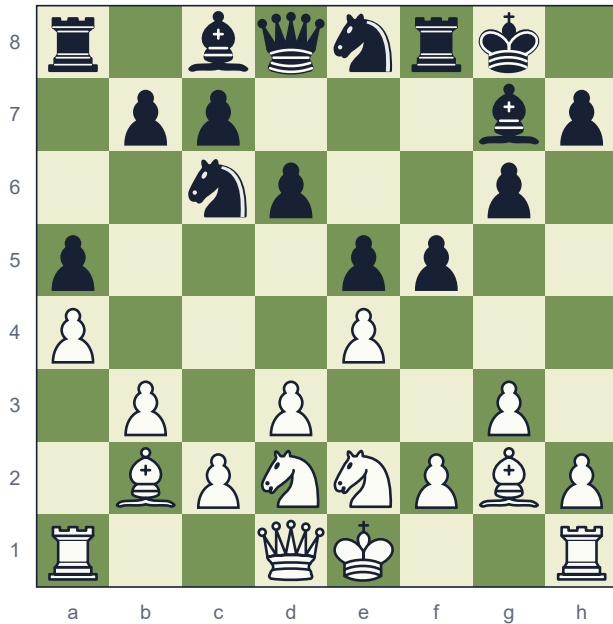
Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 27-28



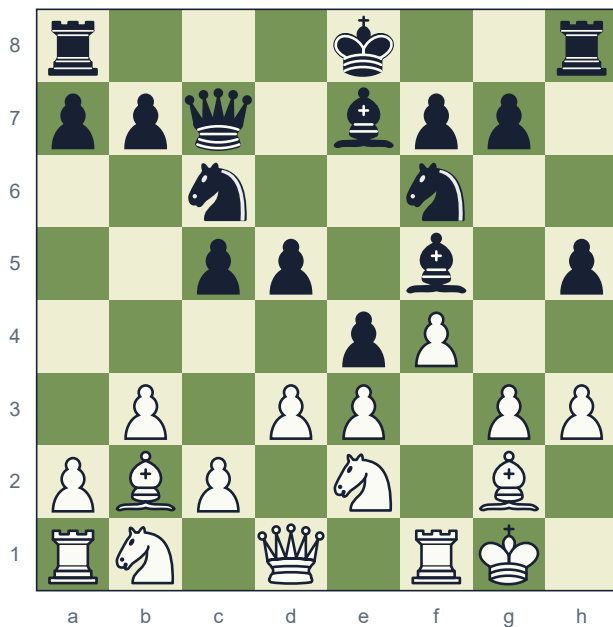
27 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



28 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

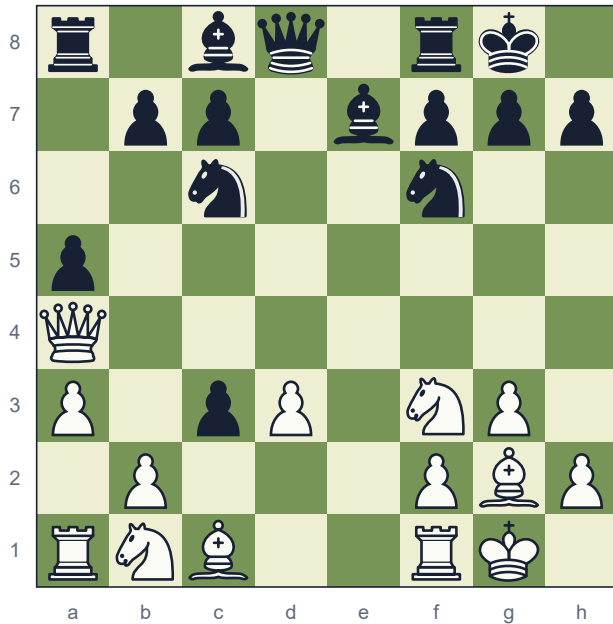
Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 29-30



White to move

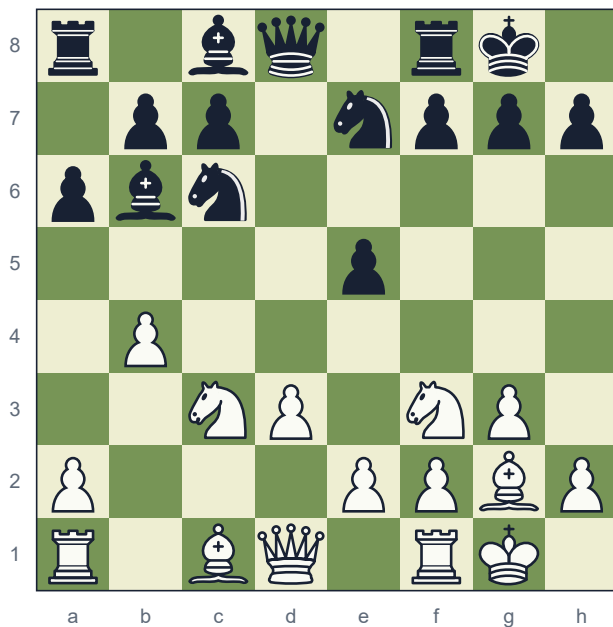
29 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

30 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

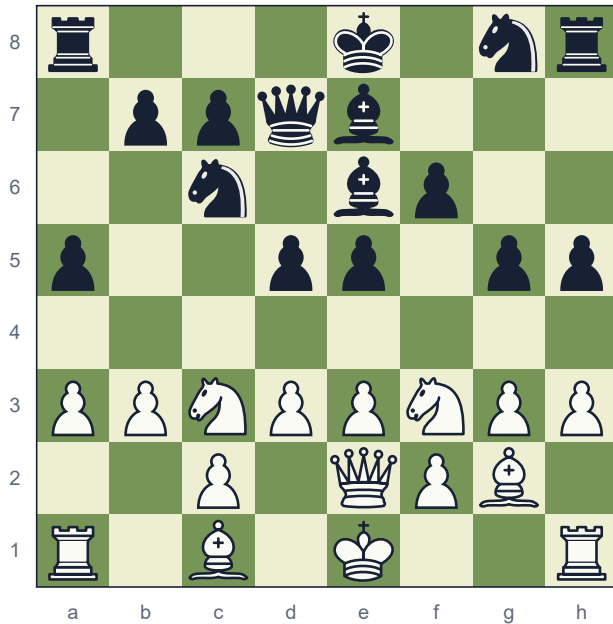
Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 31-32



White to move

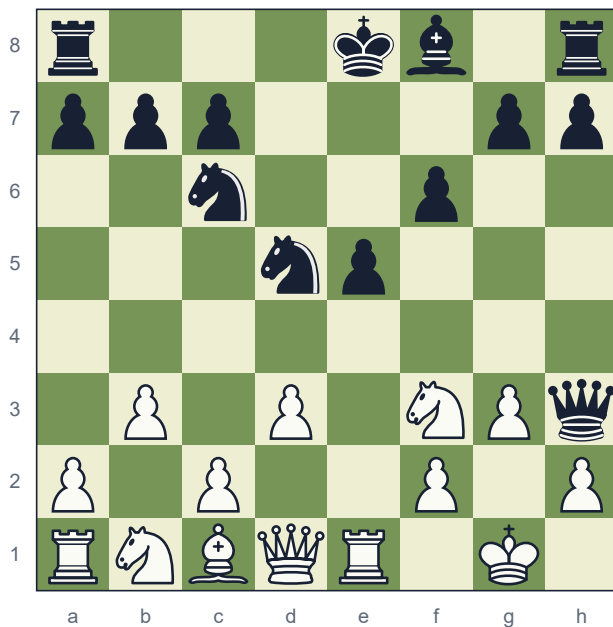
31 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

32 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

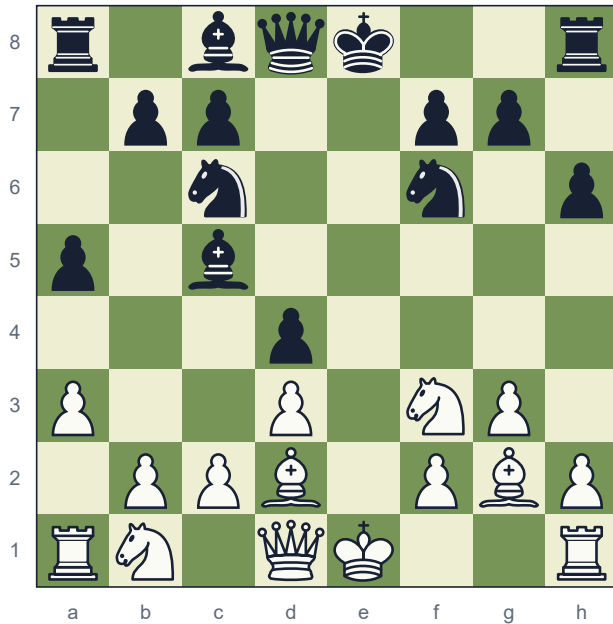
Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 33-34



White to move

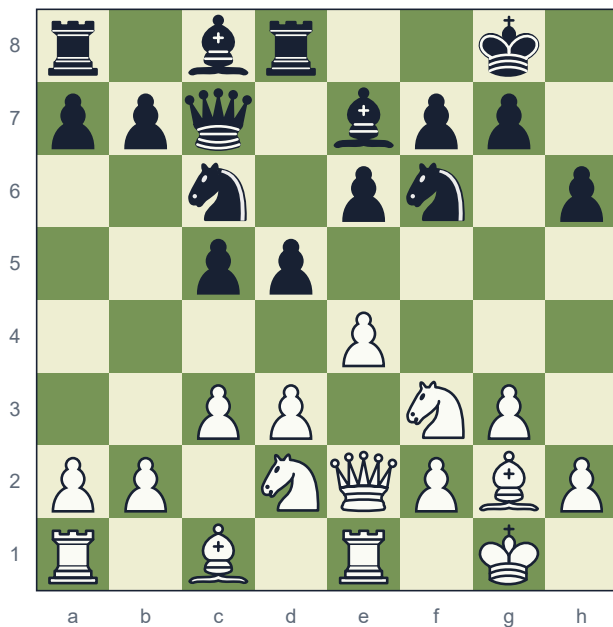
33 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

34 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

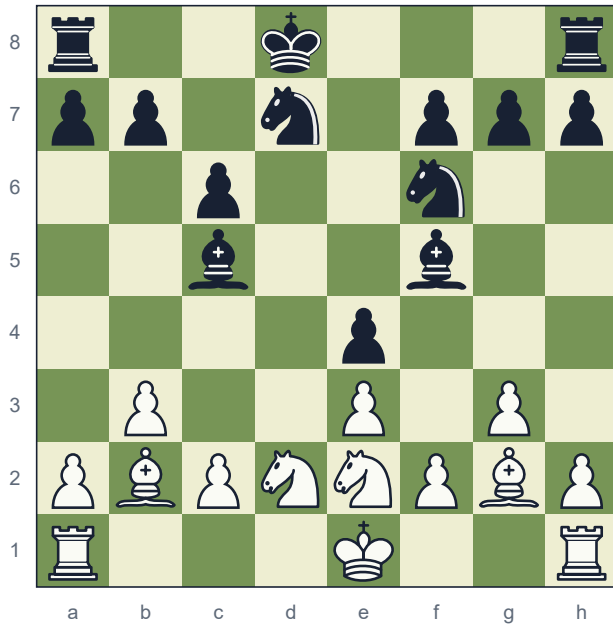
Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 35-36



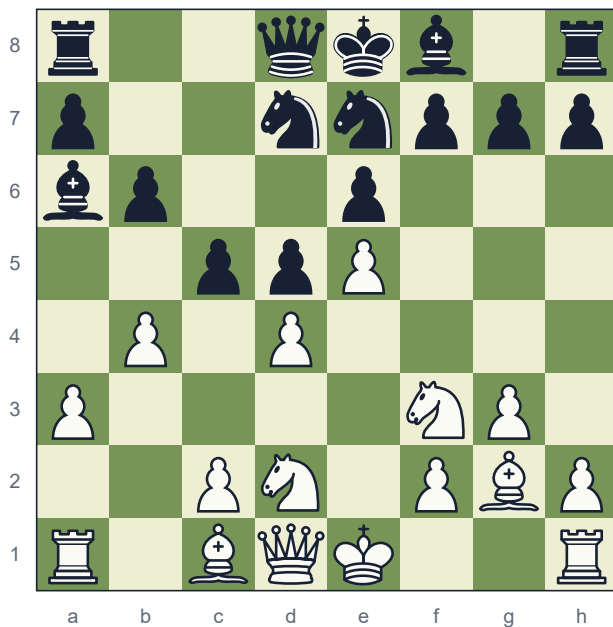
35 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



36 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

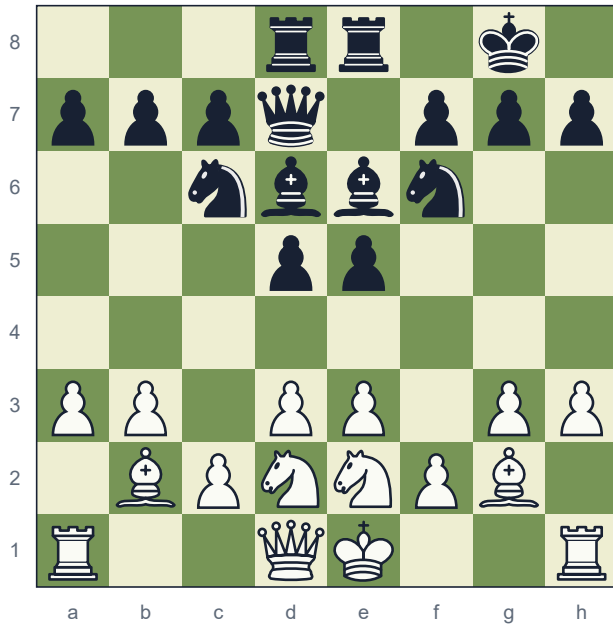
Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 37-38



White to move

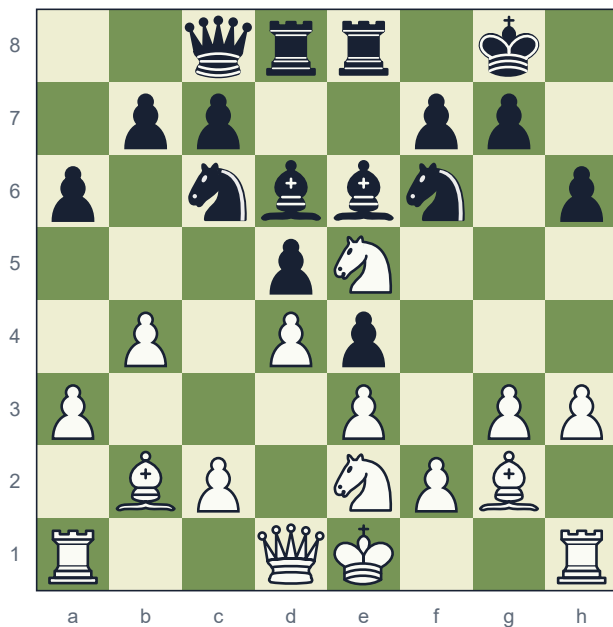
37 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

Compare g4 with Nf3. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

38 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

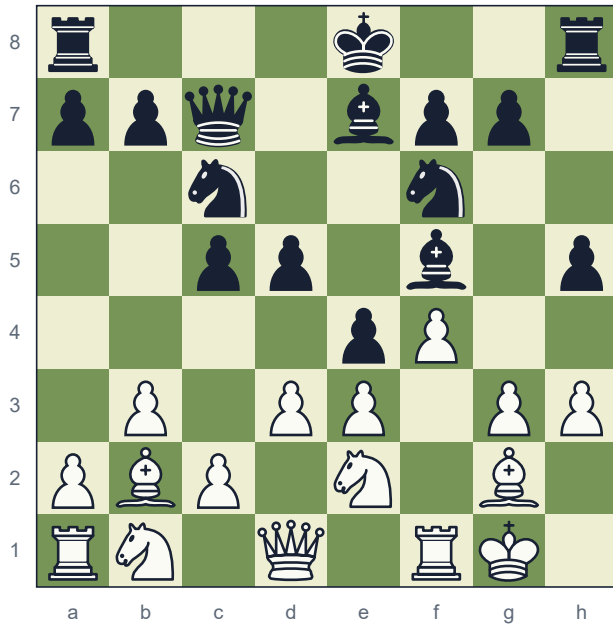
Compare Nxc6 with Nf4. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 39-40



White to move

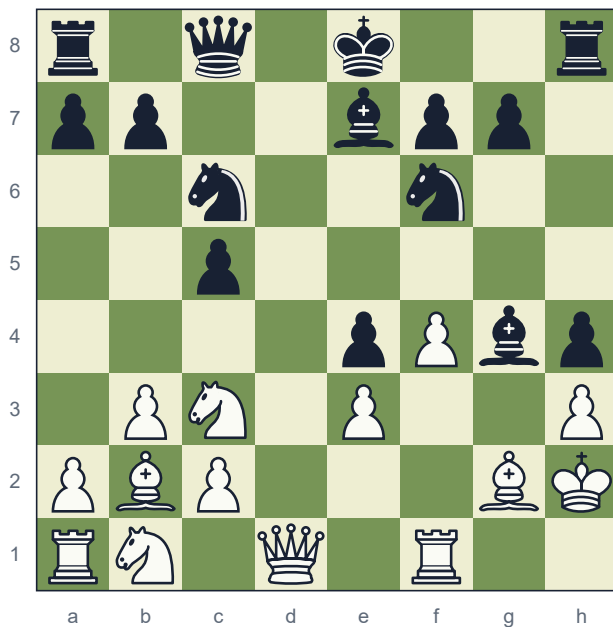
39 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

Compare Bxf6 with dxe4. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

40 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

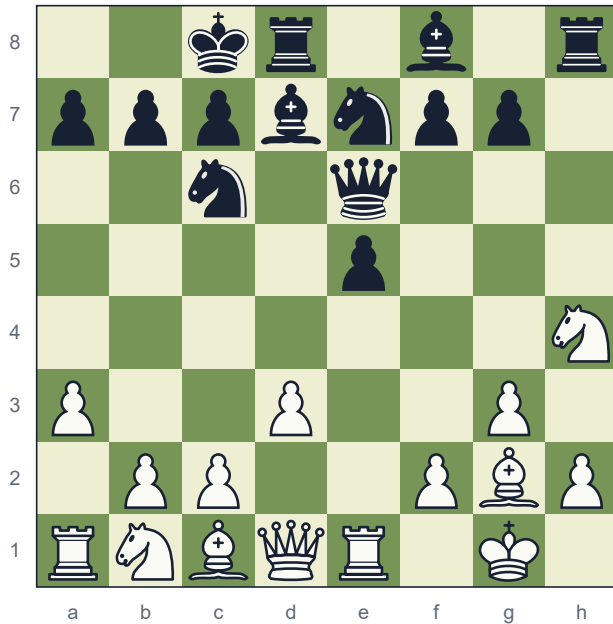
Compare hxc4 with Qd2. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 41-42



White to move

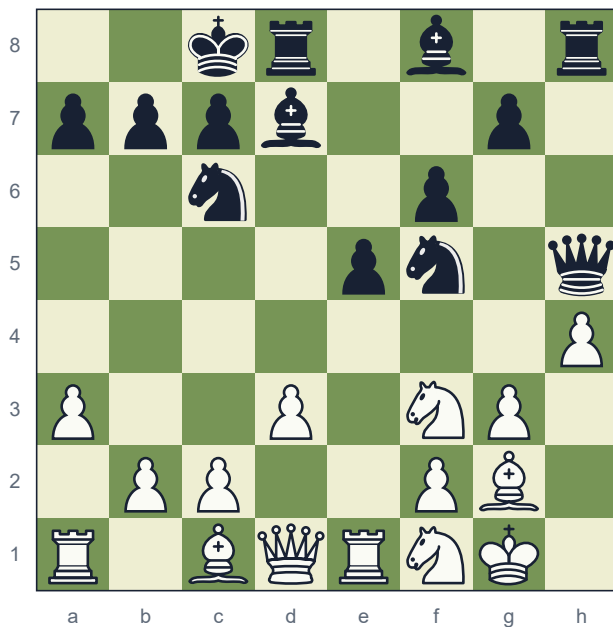
41 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

Compare b4 with Nf3. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

42 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

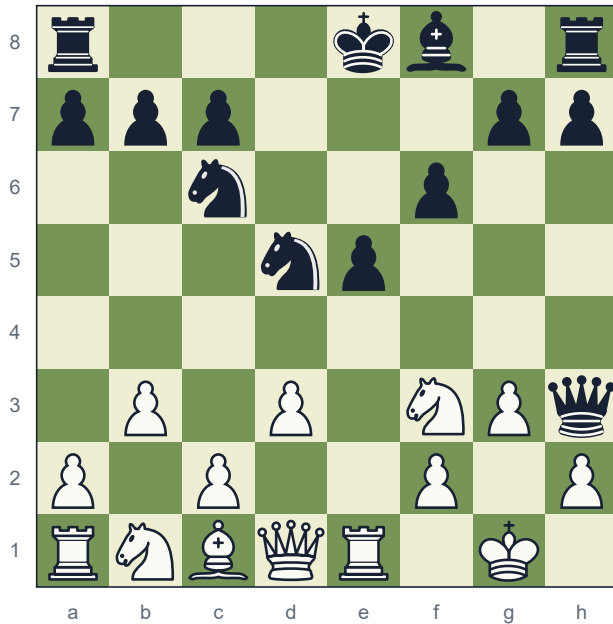
Compare c3 with b4. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 43-44



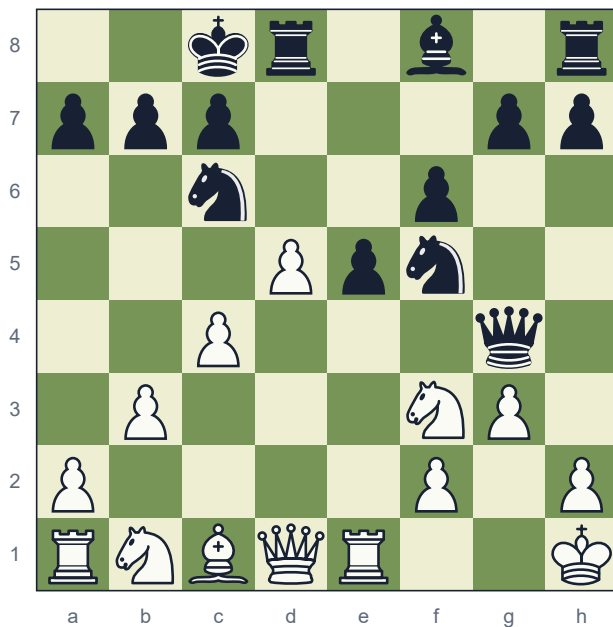
43 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

Compare c4 with d4. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



44 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

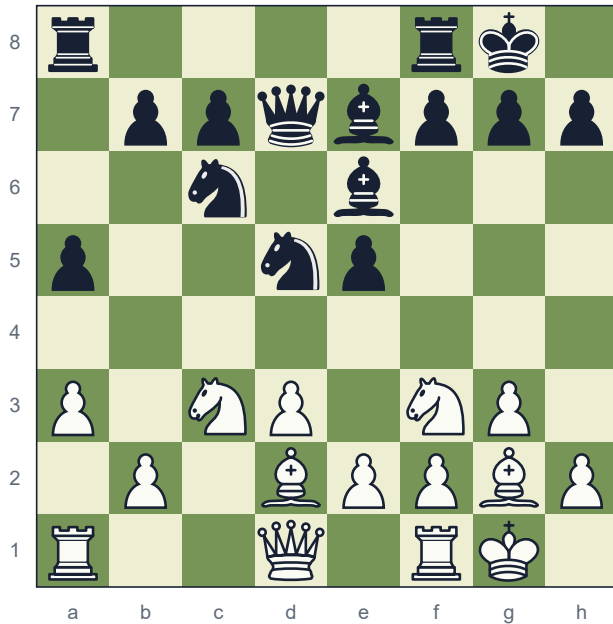
Compare Nfd2 with Nbd2. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 45-46



White to move

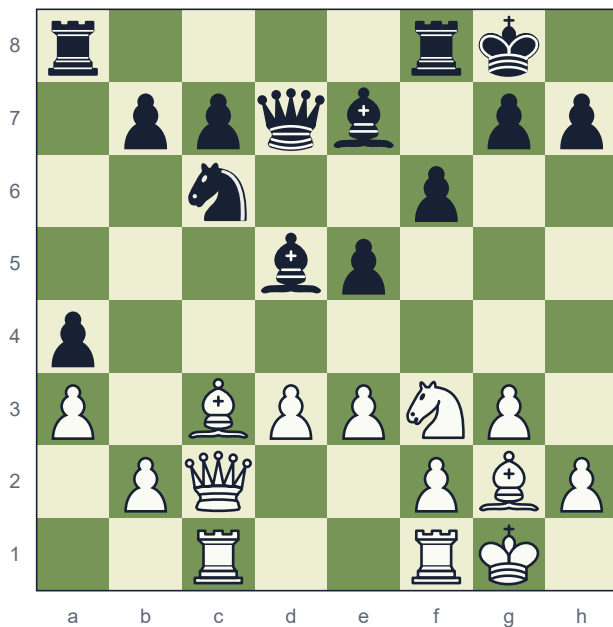
45 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

Compare Re1 with Rc1. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

46 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

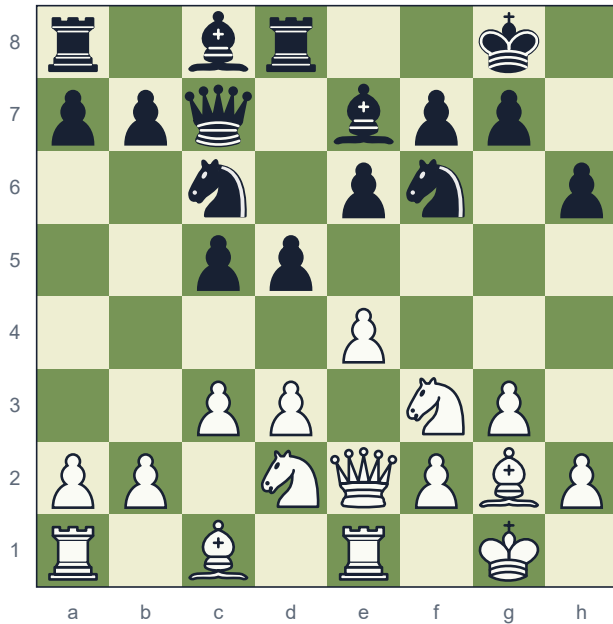
Compare Nh4 with Rfe1. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 47-48



White to move

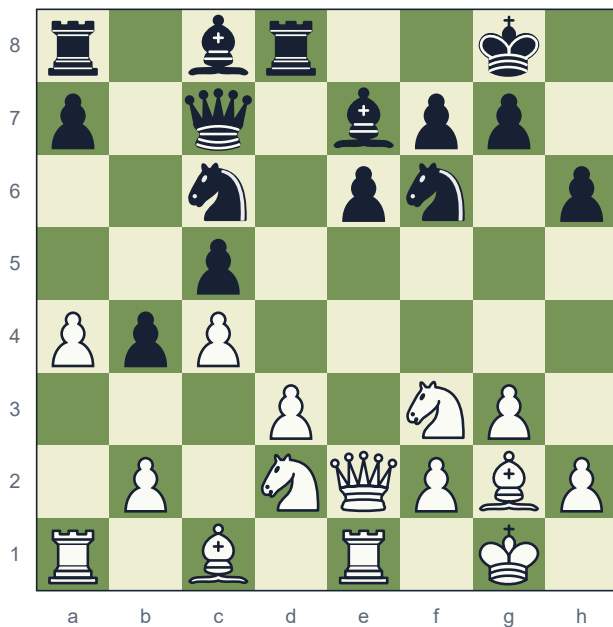
47 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

Compare a4 with a3. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

48 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

Compare Nb3 with a5. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Answers 1-2

01 / HW-01

Course move: 10. h3. White reaches the familiar two-rank formation while Black occupies the center. This quiet illustrative route is not a claim that all ten setup moves are best in every position.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

10. h3 Rad8

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black has more space and can prepare ...e4 or ...d4. White's extra tempo has not prevented a central bind.

02 / HW-02

Course move: 7. Nd2. Black develops modestly and keeps the center intact. White preserves flexibility while the bishops watch long diagonals.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

7. Nd2 Re8 8. h3 Bd6 9. Ngf3 h6

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black may use ...Re8 and ...Bf8 to prepare central expansion. Quiet development can support a serious squeeze.

Answers 3-4

03 / HW-03

Course move: 7. Nd2. Black combines central space with a fianchetto. White's b2 bishop points toward the opposing king side, but central pawns may block its influence.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

7. Nd2 Qc7 8. Ngf3 Nc6 9. O-O e5

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black can advance ...d4 and restrict the b1 knight. The g7 bishop may become stronger than its white counterpart after exchanges.

04 / HW-04

Course move: 7. Nd2. Black has a stable d5-e6 center but has not occupied e5. White has time to prepare a direct central challenge.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

7. Nd2 Nc6 8. Ngf3 b5 9. O-O Qc7

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

...Nc6 and ...e5 can gain more space. Do not wait for Black to complete every central ambition before responding.

Answers 5-6

05 / HW-05

Course move: 7. Nd2. Black's d6 pawn supports e5 and keeps the center flexible. White can choose a partial Hippo or a more active King's Indian Attack structure.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

7. Nd2 a5 8. a4 Nc6 9. e4 Ne8

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black can use ...Nc6 and ...Be6 to develop with central influence. A later ...d5 may seize the initiative if White waits too long.

06 / HW-06

Course move: 8. Nbd2. Both sides restrain the center, but the knights on f3 and f6 block the opposing fianchetto diagonals before b-pawn moves expose the corner rooks. This detail prevents a tactical accident.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

8. Nbd2 Nbd7 9. b4 c5 10. a3 O-O

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Without a blocker on the long diagonal, b3 or ...b6 can expose a corner rook to the enemy bishop. Never build this formation without tracing the diagonal.

Answers 7-8

07 / HW-07

Course move: 6. Bb2. Black establishes c5-d5-e5. White must challenge the center before completing every wing pawn move.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

6. Bb2 Be7 7. Ne2 h5 8. h3 Qc7

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

...d4 can close the center with a large space advantage. If every white piece lacks squares, the setup has become too slow.

08 / HW-08

Course move: 5. Ne2. White develops the king knight and prepares king safety against Black's ambitious center. Delaying b3 can be sensible when the center needs urgent attention.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

5. Ne2 Be6 6. O-O h5 7. c4 dxc4

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black may push ...e4 or ...f4 with tempo. A slow double fianchetto can become a target if the center opens before White castles.

Answers 9-10

09 / HW-09

Course move: 5. exd4. White exchanges the invading pawn and changes the structure. Black retains a d4 wedge, but White has opened a diagonal and can attack the pawn.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

5. exd4 exd4 6. Nf3 Nf6 7. O-O Be7

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

The d4 pawn restricts Nc3 and may support a central outpost. Do not place a knight where an enemy pawn can simply capture it.

10 / HW-10

Course move: 5. dxe4. The central exchange releases Black's knight onto e4. White has prevented a permanent pawn wedge but must now address the active piece.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

5. dxe4 Nxe4 6. Nd2 Nxd2 7. Bxd2 c6

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

A central knight can threaten forks on c3 or f2 depending on the position. Check its concrete attacks before making another pawn move.

Answers 11-12

11 / HW-11

Course move: 5. O-O. White abandons the strict Ne2 formation and develops quickly against Black's space. Nf3 is a practical adaptation when central pressure matters more than symmetry.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

5. O-O Bc5 6. Nbd2 Nge7 7. Ne4 Bb6

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black can consolidate with ...Nf6 and ...Be7. Further waiting can let the d4 pawn become a permanent restriction.

12 / HW-12

Course move: 6. Bb2. Black supports d5 and may expand with ...e4. White's b2 bishop puts indirect pressure on e5, but that pressure depends on the central pawn contacts.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

6. Bb2 O-O 7. Nd2 Re8 8. Ngf3 h6

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

...e4 can gain space and attack useful squares. Do not count a bishop as attacking through your own e3 pawn.

Answers 13-14

13 / HW-13

Course move: 3. Nxh4. Black attacks the g3 pawn before building a center. Nf3 develops and can capture on h4 when Black advances without support.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

3. Nxh4 e5 4. e4 Nc6 5. d3 d5

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black may strike in the center while the knight sits on the rim. Do not keep chasing pawns instead of developing.

14 / HW-14

Course move: 5. h3. White restrains ...h4 by preparing to meet the pawn contact on favorable terms. This is a specific defensive decision, not a requirement to play h3 in every Hippo.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

5. h3 Be6 6. a3 a5 7. Nc3 Qd7

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black can prepare ...g5 or castle long. A pawn on h3 can become a hook if the rest of the position is neglected.

Answers 15-16

15 / HW-15

Course move: 4. e3. Black gains kingside space while delaying development. White should look for central action and king safety rather than merely copying a pawn wall.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

4. e3 g5 5. Nc3 Be6 6. e4 d4

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black can play ...h5-h4 and gain attacking tempi. A passive reply may turn a premature advance into a strong attack.

16 / HW-16

Course move: 7. Bxh3. Black exchanges the g2 bishop and brings the queen toward White's already castled king. White's knight has left g1, so the queen on h3 cannot simply be captured by that knight.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

7. Bxh3 Qxh3 8. e4 Nf6 9. exd5 Nxd5

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

If White's knight were still on g1, ...Qxh3 would lose the queen to Nxxh3. In this line its different square makes the attack a real concern.

Answers 17-18

17 / HW-17

Course move: 6. Bb2. Black attacks the b3 structure and seeks open queenside lines. White must calculate the pawn contact before adding a routine knight move.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

6. Bb2 a4 7. a3 axb3 8. cxb3 Bg4

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

The b2 bishop and a1 rook can become targets when files open. A queenside attack may matter even if your king plans to castle short.

18 / HW-18

Course move: 5. Bd2. The bishop check interrupts the setup. Bd2 develops while blocking; the queen bishop does not have to reach b2 in every game.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

5. Bd2 a5 6. a3 Bc5 7. Nf3 Nc6

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Moving a pawn to block without checking the resulting weaknesses may cost time. A fixed formation is no reason to choose an inferior response to check.

Answers 19-20

19 / HW-19

Course move: 6. c4. White challenges d5 with active development and a castled king. This useful departure resembles a Reti or reversed King's Indian structure more than a complete Hippo.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

6. c4 O-O 7. cxd5 Nxd5 8. Nc3 Be6

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

If Black closes with ...d4, Nc3 may be restricted. Plan the knight route before fixing every pawn.

20 / HW-20

Course move: 7. e4. White adopts a King's Indian Attack center because Black's structure makes it useful. The b-pawn remains flexible instead of being committed automatically.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

7. e4 Nc6 8. Re1 Qc7 9. c3 h6

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black can exchange on e4 or advance ...d4. Do not assume the e5 attack is available in every branch.

Answers 21-22

21 / HW-21

Course move: 7. d4. White uses development and king safety to justify a central claim. The d-pawn advances only after the pieces are ready to cope with exchanges.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

7. d4 e4 8. b4 Re8 9. c4 h5

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Advancing d4 may leave e3 weak or open lines for Black too. A central gain is not free of structural consequences.

22 / HW-22

Course move: 6. Qxd8+. The exchanges open the d-file and allow White to remove queens. Black loses castling rights, but with queens gone the main issue is piece activity and pawn targets.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

6. Qxd8+ Kxd8 7. Ne2 Bf5 8. Nd2 Bc5

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black's centralized king may become useful if the position simplifies further. A lost castling right alone does not prove an advantage.

Answers 23-24

23 / HW-23

Course move: 6. c4. White develops actively and challenges the center with c4 rather than waiting for a full double fianchetto. Black's f-pawn commitment helps define the dark-square battle.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

6. c4 d6 7. Nc3 Nc6 8. Rb1 a5

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black can build a strong kingside attack if given too much time. Do not answer every threat with a small pawn move.

24 / HW-24

Course move: 6. Ngf3. Black blocks the g2-b7 diagonal with Nc6 before putting the bishop on b7. White uses the flank development to establish a central foothold.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

6. Ngf3 d5 7. e5 Nd7 8. d4 Ba6

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Immediate ...Bb7 without a blocker would leave that bishop available to Bxb7. Check the long diagonal before assuming a normal fianchetto is safe.

Answers 25-26

25 / HW-01

White to move. White king e1; central-file pawns c2, f2, d3, e3. Black king g8; central-file pawns d5, e5, c7, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Resolve king safety and choose c4, d4 or e4 as a central challenge. Identify which bishop will become active after the chosen break.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black has more space and can prepare ...e4 or ...d4. White's extra tempo has not prevented a central bind. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

26 / HW-03

White to move. White king g1; central-file pawns f2, d3, e3, c4. Black king g8; central-file pawns d4, c5, e5, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Complete development and decide whether c4 or e4 best opens your bishops. Count the pressure on b2 after the center clears.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black can advance ...d4 and restrict the b1 knight. The g7 bishop may become stronger than its white counterpart after exchanges. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

Answers 27-28

27 / HW-05

White to move. White king e1; central-file pawns c2, f2, d3, e4. Black king g8; central-file pawns e5, f5, d6, c7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Compare e4 with c4 and develop the king knight to support that choice. Decide whether the b2 bishop has useful pressure before exchanging e-pawns.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black can use ...Nc6 and ...Be6 to develop with central influence. A later ...d5 may seize the initiative if White waits too long. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

28 / HW-07

White to move. White king g1; central-file pawns c2, d3, e3, f4. Black king e8; central-file pawns e4, c5, d5, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Develop a knight to support c4 or e4, and calculate the resulting exchanges. Consider whether a partial formation gives more active play than the complete shell.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

...d4 can close the center with a large space advantage. If every white piece lacks squares, the setup has become too slow. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

Answers 29-30

29 / HW-09

White to move. White king g1; central-file pawns f2, d3. Black king g8; central-file pawns c3, c7, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Develop Ne2 or Nf3 and target d4 with c3 when safe. Decide whether the queen bishop belongs on b2 or a more direct square.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

The d4 pawn restricts Nc3 and may support a central outpost. Do not place a knight where an enemy pawn can simply capture it. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

30 / HW-11

White to move. White king g1; central-file pawns e2, f2, d3. Black king g8; central-file pawns e5, c7, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Use e3 or c3 to undermine d4, and bring out the queen knight to support the chosen break.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black can consolidate with ...Nf6 and ...Be7. Further waiting can let the d4 pawn become a permanent restriction. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

Answers 31-32

31 / HW-14

White to move. White king e1; central-file pawns c2, f2, d3, e3. Black king e8; central-file pawns d5, e5, f6, c7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Develop quickly and consider central counterplay. If ...h4 arrives, calculate gxh4 and exchanges rather than assuming the wing is locked.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black can prepare ...g5 or castle long. A pawn on h3 can become a hook if the rest of the position is neglected. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

32 / HW-16

White to move. White king g1; central-file pawns c2, f2, d3. Black king e8; central-file pawns e5, f6, c7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Inspect checks and dark-square threats, develop with tempo if available and look for central counterplay. The king is already on g1, so the task is defending the actual shelter.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

If White's knight were still on g1, ...Qxh3 would lose the queen to Nxh3. In this line its different square makes the attack a real concern. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

Answers 33-34

33 / HW-18

White to move. White king e1; central-file pawns c2, f2, d3. Black king e8; central-file pawns d4, c7, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Complete development and decide whether a later bishop exchange improves coordination. Keep the central pawns supported and castle when safe.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Moving a pawn to block without checking the resulting weaknesses may cost time. A fixed formation is no reason to choose an inferior response to check. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

34 / HW-20

White to move. White king g1; central-file pawns f2, c3, d3, e4. Black king g8; central-file pawns c5, d5, e6, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Support e4, then assess e5 and the available knight routes. Use the KIA course for deeper study of this exact center.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black can exchange on e4 or advance ...d4. Do not assume the e5 attack is available in every branch. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

Answers 35-36

35 / HW-22

White to move. White king e1; central-file pawns c2, f2, e3. Black king d8; central-file pawns e4, c6, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Develop the knights, assess the e4 pawn and activate the king when safe. Do not keep playing for a direct king attack without queens.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Black's centralized king may become useful if the position simplifies further. A lost castling right alone does not prove an advantage. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

36 / HW-24

White to move. White king e1; central-file pawns c2, f2, d4, e5. Black king e8; central-file pawns c5, d5, e6, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Castle, support e4 and compare central exchanges. The position may become a KIA-style game rather than a complete Hippo.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Immediate ...Bb7 without a blocker would leave that bishop available to Bxb7. Check the long diagonal before assuming a normal fianchetto is safe. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

Answers 37-38

37 / HW-LAB-01

The finite search prefers Nf3 (-0.95 from White's perspective), compared with g4 (-1.01 from White's perspective). Develops the king knight toward e5 and d4. In the King's Gambit it also controls h4, making an immediate queen check there unattractive.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

11. Nf3 h6 12. d4 Bf5 13. dxe5 Nxe5 14. Nxe5 Bxe5

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 11. g4 h6 12. Ng3 Ne7 13. Nf3 d4 14. g5 Nfd5

38 / HW-LAB-01

The finite search prefers Nxc6 (-1.15 from White's perspective), compared with Nf4 (-1.16 from White's perspective). The knight captures a knight on c6. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

15. Nxc6 bxc6 16. Nf4 Bf5 17. Qe2 Qb7 18. O-O Qc8

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 15. Nf4 Bf5 16. Nxc6 bxc6 17. Qe2 Qb7 18. Bc3 Nh7

Answers 39-40

39 / HW-LAB-02

The finite search prefers dxe4 (-0.60 from White's perspective), compared with Bxf6 (-1.37 from White's perspective). The pawn captures a pawn on e4. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

11. dxe4 dxe4 12. Nec3 Rd8 13. Nd2 Qc8 14. Qe2 Bxh3

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 11. Bxf6 Bxf6

40 / HW-LAB-02

The finite search prefers hxg4 (-0.39 from White's perspective), compared with Qd2 (-1.24 from White's perspective). The pawn captures a bishop on g4. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

15. hxg4 Nxg4+

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 15. Qd2 Bf5 16. Nb5 O-O 17. Nd6 Bxd6 18. Bxf6 Be7

Answers 41-42

41 / HW-LAB-03

The finite search prefers Nf3 (+0.68 from White's perspective), compared with b4 (+0.00 from White's perspective). Develops the king knight toward e5 and d4. In the King's Gambit it also controls h4, making an immediate queen check there unattractive.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

11. Nf3 Qf5

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 11. b4 Rxh4 12. gxh4 Nf5 13. Re4 Nd6 14. Re1

42 / HW-LAB-03

The finite search prefers c3 (+1.09 from White's perspective), compared with b4 (+0.91 from White's perspective). Places the pawn on c3. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

15. c3 Kb8 16. b4 Nd6 17. c4 Bf5 18. Ne3 Bc8

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 15. b4 Ncd4 16. Be3 Nxf3+ 17. Qxf3 Qxf3 18. Bxf3 g6

Answers 43-44

43 / HW-LAB-04

The finite search prefers d4 (-0.66 from White's perspective), compared with c4 (-1.17 from White's perspective). Changes central space and pawn contacts. Calculate captures, advances and maintaining tension before choosing the next piece plan.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

11. d4

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 11. c4 Nde7 12. b4 Nf5 13. b5 Ncd4 14. Nxd4 Nxd4

44 / HW-LAB-04

The finite search prefers Nfd2 (-0.38 from White's perspective), compared with Nbd2 (-0.44 from White's perspective). Places the knight on d2. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

15. Nfd2 Qxd1 16. Rxd1 Ncd4 17. Nc3 Be7 18. Rb1 h5

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 15. Nbd2 Ncd4

Answers 45-46

45 / HW-LAB-05

The finite search prefers Rc1 (-0.08 from White's perspective), compared with Re1 (-0.08 from White's perspective). Places the rook on c1. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

11. Rc1

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 11. Re1 Nxc3 12. Bxc3 f6 13. Qa4 Rfd8 14. Nd2 Nd4

46 / HW-LAB-05

The finite search prefers Nh4 (-0.10 from White's perspective), compared with Rfe1 (-0.16 from White's perspective). Places the knight on h4. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

15. Nh4 Bb3

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 15. Rfe1 Nd8 16. Nh4 Bxg2 17. Kxg2 g5 18. Nf3 g4

Answers 47-48

47 / HW-LAB-06

The finite search prefers a3 (+0.10 from White's perspective), compared with a4 (+0.03 from White's perspective). Controls nearby wing squares and may restrain a piece or pawn. Compare this useful purpose with the time lost to central development.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

11. a3 b5 12. exd5 exd5 13. d4 c4 14. Ne5 Re8

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 11. a4 Rb8

48 / HW-LAB-06

The finite search prefers Nb3 (+0.18 from White's perspective), compared with a5 (+0.04 from White's perspective). Places the knight on b3. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

15. Nb3 Bb7 16. Bf4 Qc8 17. a5 a6 18. Rad1 Bf8

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 15. a5 Nxa5

A 12-week course you can repeat

WEEKLY WORKLOAD

Aim for four study sessions of 30-45 minutes and two slow practice games. If that is too much, stretch each week to two weeks. Consistency and review matter more than finishing on a deadline.

A 35-MINUTE SESSION

Spend 5 minutes recalling yesterday's position, 10 minutes learning one decision, 15 minutes calculating or playing a position, and 5 minutes writing the lesson. Keep the answer hidden during recall.

USE A MASTERY GATE

Move on when you can reconstruct the main branch, explain its plan and name the opponent's counterplay on two different days. If not, repeat the decision with a changed opposing reply.

DO NOT STUDY EVERY BRANCH EQUALLY

Prioritize the first line of each family and the lines your opponents play. Optional alternatives are comparison material after the main repertoire is stable.

Weeks 1-3

WEEK 1 / BOARD SKILLS AND THINKING ROUTINE

00 foundations; practice coordinates, legal moves, notation and the blunder check. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

WEEK 2 / FIRST OPENING FAMILY

01 family 1. Learn its main route, then two alternatives. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

WEEK 3 / SECOND OPENING FAMILY

01 family 2. Compare the opponent's central choices. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

REVIEW LOOP

Revisit new positions after 1 day, 3 days, 7 days and about a month. A failed recall is useful information: shorten the line and rebuild the reason for the move.

Weeks 4-6

WEEK 4 / THIRD OPENING FAMILY

01 family 3. Add common deviations and one warning position. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

WEEK 5 / FOURTH FAMILY AND BOUNDARIES

01 family 4. Distinguish the main repertoire from optional branches and bridges. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

WEEK 6 / PAWN STRUCTURES

02 strategic lessons 1-4. Identify the correct break from the actual center. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

REVIEW LOOP

Revisit new positions after 1 day, 3 days, 7 days and about a month. A failed recall is useful information: shorten the line and rebuild the reason for the move.

Weeks 7-9

WEEK 7 / DEFENSE AND TACTICS

02 remaining lessons and calculation audits. Practice checks, captures and opponent resources. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

WEEK 8 / FIRST THREE LABORATORIES

03 laboratories 1-3. Play each starting position from both sides. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

WEEK 9 / LAST THREE LABORATORIES

03 laboratories 4-6. Compare candidates before revealing the engine lines. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

REVIEW LOOP

Revisit new positions after 1 day, 3 days, 7 days and about a month. A failed recall is useful information: shorten the line and rebuild the reason for the move.

Weeks 10-12

WEEK 10 / ENDGAME TRANSITIONS

02 endgames. Analyze one legal exchange sequence from your own game. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

WEEK 11 / FULL RETRIEVAL TEST

04 questions 1-48. Write explanations before looking at answers. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

WEEK 12 / CONSOLIDATE YOUR OWN REPERTOIRE

Repair recurring errors and build a small personal file of the positions you actually meet. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

REVIEW LOOP

Revisit new positions after 1 day, 3 days, 7 days and about a month. A failed recall is useful information: shorten the line and rebuild the reason for the move.

Pocket reference / 1

BUILDING A REVERSED HIPPO

Use this card after studying the full explanations. It is a reminder, not a replacement for calculating the current position.

HW-01 The complete formation as a study position

Completing a formation is not the same as gaining an advantage.

HW-02 Black develops Be7

Use flexibility to choose a break, not to postpone every decision.

HW-03 Black fianchettoes

Open the diagonal that helps your pieces most.

HW-04 Black uses ...e6 and ...d5

A restrained opponent still needs to be challenged.

HW-05 Black chooses a ...d6 ...e5 center

Watch the break the supporting pawn can eventually make.

HW-06 Black also plays a Hippo

Block the long diagonal before exposing the corner rook.

Pocket reference / 2

RESPONDING TO CENTRAL SPACE

Use this card after studying the full explanations. It is a reminder, not a replacement for calculating the current position.

HW-07 Black grabs space with ...c5

A three-pawn center calls for a timely lever.

HW-08 Black adds ...f5

Development comes before decorative symmetry.

HW-09 Black advances ...d4 early

Deal with the wedge before finishing the formation.

HW-10 Black advances ...e4 early

Exchanging a pawn can replace it with a stronger piece.

HW-11 Black plays ...d4 before e3

Use the knight square the position needs.

HW-12 Black plays an early ...c6

A blocked diagonal is potential, not present pressure.

Pocket reference / 3

FLANK ATTACKS AND EARLY TACTICS

Use this card after studying the full explanations. It is a reminder, not a replacement for calculating the current position.

HW-13 An immediate ...h5

A premature flank attack may be met by a developing move.

HW-14 The supported h-pawn attack

A defensive pawn move creates a future target too.

HW-15 The ...g5 expansion

Test a wing expansion before it becomes supported.

HW-16 An early ...Bh3 attempt

A queen recapture depends on the knight's exact square.

HW-17 Queenside expansion with ...a5

Defend pieces behind the pawn contact.

HW-18 Black develops ...Bb4+

Respond to the check with the best developing move.

Pocket reference / 4

USEFUL DEPARTURES FROM THE COMPLETE FORMATION

Use this card after studying the full explanations. It is a reminder, not a replacement for calculating the current position.

HW-19 Choose c4 before the complete shell

The best Hippo lesson may be when to leave it.

HW-20 Choose e4 for a KIA transition

Transition by pawn structure, not by a preferred name.

HW-21 Choose d4 against a restrained center

Take central space when your pieces can support it.

HW-22 Trade queens when the file opens

Evaluate the position after the queens disappear.

HW-23 Use Nf3 against a Dutch center

Choose active development when the opponent has a clear attack.

HW-24 Against early ...b6: occupy the center

Use central space and inspect undefended fianchetto bishops.

A practical game-analysis worksheet

GAME DETAILS

Date: _____ Opponent: _____ Time control: _____ Result: _____

FIRST UNFAMILIAR POSITION

Move number: _____ Relevant line ID: _____

What did the opponent's last move threaten? Write the FEN or save the position in your chess program.

MY CANDIDATES

Candidate A and a reply: _____

Candidate B and a reply: _____

Why did I choose the move I played?

DIAGNOSIS

Was the main error opening recall, missed tactics, the wrong pawn break, king safety, an exchange decision or time management? Choose the earliest cause that explains the later problem.

REPAIR

Write one concrete rule tied to the position. Add a short legal variation and schedule the next review. Do not add twenty engine moves that you cannot explain.

Glossary

ANCHOR

The authored move sequence defining a branch; later printed moves may be an illustrative continuation.

COMPENSATION

Activity, king pressure or structural advantages that may offset a material deficit.

COUNTERPLAY

Active threats or pressure that make the opponent address your ideas.

EN PRISE

A piece is available to be captured; check whether the capture is actually safe.

FIANCHETTO

Developing a bishop to b2, g2, b7 or g7 behind a moved b- or g-pawn.

INITIATIVE

The ability to pose threats that influence the opponent's replies.

ISOLATED PAWN

A pawn with no friendly pawn on either adjacent file.

Glossary / continued

MINORITY ATTACK

A pawn advance by fewer pawns against a larger pawn group to create weaknesses.

OUTPOST

A useful supported square for a piece, often difficult for enemy pawns to challenge.

PROPHYLAXIS

A move that anticipates and reduces the opponent's useful plan.

TEMPO

One move of time; useful tempi are gained when threats force helpful replies.

TRANSPOSITION

Different move orders reaching the same position with the same side to move and relevant rights.

ZWISCHENZUG

An intermediate move, often forcing, played before an expected recapture.

Sources and attribution

OPENING NAMES AND ROUTES

Lichess chess-openings is a CC0 reference for established names and entry move orders. The course commentary, study routes and practice curriculum are original. Some Hippo routes use descriptive teaching labels because opening-name databases use that term inconsistently.

<https://github.com/lichess-org/chess-openings>

ENGINE AND LEGAL-MOVE TOOLS

Stockfish 18 supplies finite tactical comparisons and illustrative continuations. python-chess 1.11.2 validates moves, positions and PGN.

<https://stockfishchess.org/download/>

<https://python-chess.readthedocs.io/>

PIECE ARTWORK

The Cburnett piece designs are by Colin M. L. Burnett, as distributed by python-chess. Adapted SVG sources, attribution and the GPL-2.0 license are included in Artwork_Credits_and_Sources. The palette and PDF drawing scale are adjusted; the original piece silhouettes are retained.

<https://python-chess.readthedocs.io/en/latest/svg.html>

Research scope and verification

REVERSED HIPPO CONTEXT

The Black Hippo's double-fianchetto idea provides a structural reference. The White repertoire and its adaptations in this course are original study choices, independently checked rather than mechanically mirrored. <https://www.newinchess.com/the-hippopotamus-defence>

WHAT WAS CHECKED

All 130 course anchors across the five courses were legally replayed. Repertoire-side decisions after the opening commitment received 80,000-node best-move and played-move comparisons; apparent losses above 1.00 were rechecked at 600,000 nodes. Flagged choices were revised. Warning lines deliberately contain mistakes and are marked.

ILLUSTRATIONS AND LIMITS

Short anchors were extended to about move ten using 140,000-node searches. Endpoints used 400,000 nodes; laboratory positions used 500,000 nodes per search. These are finite checks, not proofs of equality or exhaustive modern theory. Optional gambits and full Hippo formations retain practical and strategic risks.

WHAT THE NUMBERS MEAN

Laboratory estimates are expressed from your course side's perspective, so higher is better for that side. They are not literal pawn counts or guaranteed winning probabilities. Close candidate values should be treated as comparable, and deeper analysis may change the ordering.

PUBLICATION CHECKS

PDF text, page geometry, board legality and PGN replay are checked. Every combined-volume page is rendered for visual review. The supplied verification manifest records the final page counts and file hashes.